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2 rescued from sunken ship brought to Odisha
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Nepal flood toll hits 389; rescue work in top gear

- Over 800 people rescued after the flash flood, 910 remain missing, say authorities
- 517 foreign nationals unaccounted for; PM Shah reaches nearest motorable town
- Alert sounded along Bhotekoshi river as satellite images show blockage upstream
- Probe on to determine the role of glacial lakes in the devastating flood, says Nepal

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

The death toll in the flash flood in Nepal's Rasuwa district bordering Tibet touched 389 on Thursday, with 910 people still missing. Nepal's government issued a fresh flood alert after satellite imagery showed that a lake had formed upstream of the Bhotekoshi river due to a blockage, and warned that it could burst.

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal termed the flood "one of the largest natural disasters we have experienced in recent memory" even as authorities continued a massive search-and-rescue operation. "Towns after towns were wiped out in a span of a couple of hours," he said.

Personnel from the Nepal Army, police, and the Armed Police Force raced against time to rescue survivors from mountain villages that were swept away by the flash flood on Wednesday morning.

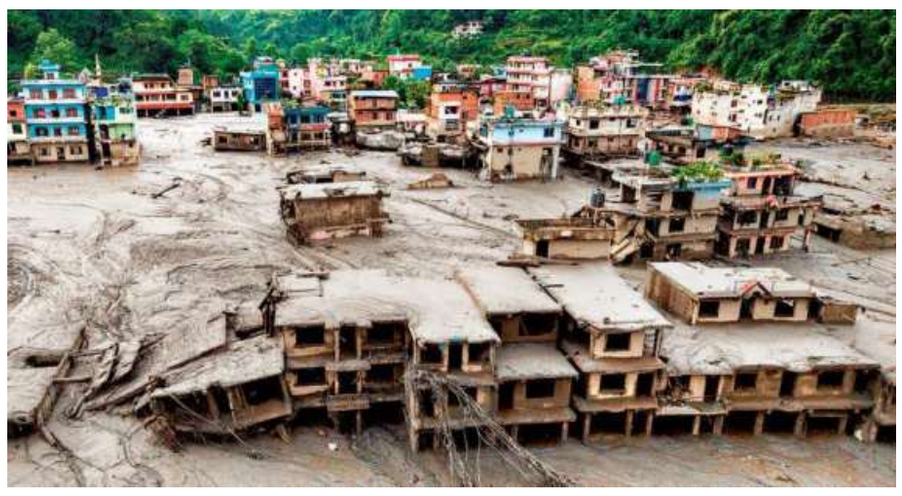
According to authorities, more than 800 people were rescued from flood-affected areas as of Thursday night.

Of the 910 missing, 517 are foreign nationals with people from more than 30 countries remaining unaccounted for, they said.

Raising concerns about another possible flood, the government said "satellite imagery and preliminary analysis indicate that water has accumulated at the site where flooding was reported" on Wednesday. "The lake is continuing to rise, and authorities have warned that it could breach or burst, potentially sending a sudden surge of water downstream." It urged residents, travellers, rescue personnel, and others in the downstream areas to remain alert. "It is advised that people stay away from riverbanks and other vulnerable areas... until further notice," it said.

Nepal's Prime Minister Balendra Shah reached Bidur, the district headquarters of Nuwakot, which abuts Rasuwa, by road. With 19 bridges and 40 kilometres of roads damaged, it is the last point up to which vehicles can reach.

It is still unclear what caused the flash flood. According to the Nepal government, satellite imagery indicated that an avalanche in the Himalayan region triggered a surge of an unusually large volume of water. "Further investigations are under way to determine the role of possible glacial lakes and related events," it said.



Swept away: Sludge surrounds damaged buildings at Bidur in Nuwakot district of Nepal on Thursday, more than 24 hours after the deadly flood tore through the region. AFP

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At least 290 Indians missing, says Centre

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

In a "preliminary assessment" of the situation following the flash flood in Nepal, the External Affairs Ministry on Thursday said at least 290 Indian nationals remain "uncontactable".

"Urgent efforts are under way to ascertain the status and well-being of all Indians in the flood-affected areas," said External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, adding that India is "working closely with the Nepalese side".

After sending an aircraft carrying relief materials to the disaster-hit neighbour on Wednesday, the Ministry on Thursday said that a second consignment of humanitarian assistance and disaster relief materials were handed over to Nepal. Additional support would be extended to the Himalayan nation, it said.

Relatives of those missing waiting near a rescue camp in Trishuli, Nepal, on Thursday. PTI

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Gathering info on travellers: Delhi govt.; 25 return from Mansarovar

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government is currently gathering information about city residents who travelled to flash flood-affected areas in Nepal and beyond, officials said on Thursday.

A group of 25 individuals who visited Mansarovar before the natural disaster struck has returned, the officials said. They added that information is also being gathered about other residents from the national capital who went on personal trips to the affected regions.

IN BRIEF

IIT Delhi rejigs panel to probe student's death

NEW DELHI
Justice Mukta Gupta, a retired judge of the Delhi HC, will now head the inquiry panel set up to examine the circumstances leading to the death of an IIT Delhi student, officials said on Thursday. » Page 2

NLSIU cancels convocation amid stir over CJI invite

BENGALURU
The National Law School of India University, Bengaluru, has cancelled its convocation ceremony amid protests over the invitation extended to CJI Surya Kant. » Page 5

Four Nagas killed in ambush amid Manipur peace efforts

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Unidentified gunmen on Thursday morning ambushed and killed four Naga civilians between Makui Ashang and Thanamba Naga villages in Manipur's Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district.

Officials said the gunmen opened fire on at least six persons who were travelling from Makui to Senapati, a Naga-majority district. The authorities suspect that some groups are trying to undermine the State government's peace-building measures.

The United Naga Council (UNC), an apex body of Manipur's Naga communities, blamed Kuki extremist groups for the attack though no outfit has claimed responsibility. It condemned the "barbaric and calculated" attack on the Liangmai Naga civilians and called it a "direct challenge to peace, the Indo-Naga peace process, and to the very existence of Nagas in our ancestral lands".

'Senseless violence'

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnan Khemchand Singh and Home Minister Govindas Konthoujam condemned the "senseless violence" and said it "strikes at our collective efforts to restore peace and normalcy".

The UNC also appealed to the Nagas to remain vigilant and stand united against "such external threats". The apex Naga body identified the deceased as Tadsongbou Ringkangmai, Mariakdibou Wijunamai, Anil Wijunamai, and Wisobou Charenamai. It said Gaikamang Ringkangmai was injured in the attack, while one Japou M.K. was missing.

UNC alleged that the Kuki National Front (KNF), KNF (Presidential) and Kuki Revolutionary Army were behind the attack.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

Settle SC judge's concerns over Acting Chief Justice internally, say Rajasthan HC lawyers

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

Lawyers' bodies at the Rajasthan High Court's principal seat in Jodhpur and the Bench in Jaipur on Thursday said the issues raised by a Supreme Court judge about the High Court's Acting Chief Justice should be resolved at an institutional forum in the judiciary. The lawyers' associations also emphasised the need for appointing a permanent Chief Justice.

The three Bar Associations in Jodhpur and Jaipur will shortly convene a formal meeting for deciding the course of action over the matter after Justice Sandeep Mehta wrote three letters seeking the transfer of the High Court's Acting Chief Justice, Sanjeev Prakash Sharma.

"Such issues should be taken up at an appropriate forum as a public debate on them will only tarnish the image of the judiciary," Rajeev Sogarwal, president of the High Court Bar Association, Jaipur, said.

He added that a permanent Chief Justice should be appointed in the High Court "without delay".

Besides the High Court Bar Association in Jaipur, the two recognised lawyers' bodies in Jodhpur are the High Court Advocates' Association and the High Court Lawyers' Association.

In his letters addressed to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant this month, Justice Mehta sought the transfer of Justice Sharma while alleging "misuse of powers, favouritism, nepotism, and administrative lapses".

In the letters, the apex court judge also raised concerns over the handling of court cases and infrastructure decisions.

The lawyers' associations also emphasised the need for appointing a permanent Chief Justice in the Rajasthan High Court. FILE PHOTO

'Serious issues'

Ranjeet Joshi, president of the High Court Advocates' Association, Jodhpur, said the issues raised in Justice Mehta's letters were "serious". The representatives of the three lawyers' bodies were in touch and would shortly decide the next course of action, he said. The High Court Advocates' Association had earlier written to the CJI seeking a permanent Chief Justice in the State and raised concerns over the relationship between the Bar and the Bench.

166 fresh H1N1 cases in Delhi in 24 hours

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi reported 166 fresh H1N1 cases in the last 24 hours, an increase from the 138 cases recorded the previous day, taking the cumulative tally to 2,612, officials said on Thursday. Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh inspected Indira Gandhi Hospital at Dwarka in view of the rising number of H1N1 cases in the national capital and reviewed the preparedness of the hospital and the Health Department.

The total number of H1N1 cases in Delhi stood at 2,612, and cumulative Influenza-A cases around 3,300, as per an official statement. The Minister said he has been closely monitoring preparedness across hospitals.

Meanwhile, Delhi Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) president Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged that Delhi government-run Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital is in a state of utter neglect. "Patients are not receiving all prescribed medications. Essential tests and scans are also unavailable at the hospital," he said. AAP MLAs Sanjeev Jha and Kuldeep Kumar visited the hospital to assess the situation.

IIT Delhi reconstitutes panel to probe student's death as protests enter fourth day

Institute says it is committed to ensuring students' well-being; collecting evidence on 'insensitive' remarks by Dean as well as 'tone-deaf' comments made by faculty on deaths by suicide: students

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Justice Mukta Gupta, a retired judge of the Delhi High Court, will now head the inquiry panel set up to examine the circumstances leading to the death of an IIT Delhi student, officials said on Thursday, even as student protests continued on campus for a fourth day.

The panel was reconstituted a day after former Uttarakhand Director General of Police Ashok Kumar, who was appointed as chair of the probe panel, recused himself from the committee. Students had objected to his inclusion, citing his purported comments on recent youth-led agitations, linking the protesters with "radicalisation".

"A new panel has been constituted, with Justice Mukta Gupta as the chairperson. The other members include Pratap Sharan, HoD Psychiatry, AIIMS Delhi. Two student representatives and the IIT Delhi Registrar will also be part of the external probe panel," an IIT Delhi official said.

Students staging a demonstration at IIT Delhi on Thursday night. They said they will continue their stir as the administration has not fulfilled all their demands. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The death of the 31-year-old MSc student, allegedly by suicide on the campus on August 22, has sparked massive uproar among several student bodies. Students at the institute have been protesting since Monday against "systemic issues", which they claim have led to the deaths of eight students by suicide over the past 30 months, two of them this year alone.

On Thursday, students reiterated their demands that include ₹1 crore as compensation to be paid to the mother of the deceased and the resignation of the Associate Dean of Student Welfare. The protesters said they were in the process of collecting evidence from other students, both former and present, on alleged "insensitive" remarks made by the institute's Dean to students on multiple occasions as well as collating evidence from student on faculty and staff members allegedly making "tone-deaf and disparaging" comments on death by suicides.

In response to the demands of the students, the IIT Delhi administration, in a statement, said it is committed to ensuring students' well-being and enhancing its support infrastructure with multiple steps already being implemented.

'For student well-being'

Listing some of the measures, the institute said when it comes to mental healthcare infrastructure for student well-being, it has counsellors available 24/7, psychiatrists (including AIIMS/VIMHANS experts); fully reimbursed external care, emergency response protocol, Academic Unit Wellness Committees and a buddy programme. The institute said it also has grievance redressal channels, including a Board for Student Welfare, specialised SC/ST/OBC cells, hostel wardens, the Internal Complaints Committee, and confidential counselling channels s - ensuring transparent resolution.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help.)

Bulldozers roll into Delhi Race Club; stables razed

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Demolition work began at the century-old Delhi Race Club in Lutyens' Delhi on Thursday, shortly after the Centre took possession of the 53.24-acre premises and halted racing activities, officials said.

The Land and Development Office (L&DO) took over the property following a Patiala House Court order on Tuesday dismissing the club's plea seeking an interim stay on the August 11 eviction order passed by an Estate Officer under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971.

Bulldozers demolished several structures, including the stables, bookmakers' ring, winning post, photo-finish camera, and saddling enclosure, a club official said. The club had more than 250 horses, of which around 200 have been taken back by their owners, while about 50 remain on the premises. The club has been given time until September 14 to complete the process of moving the remaining horses, according to officials.

The L&DO sought assistance from the New Delhi police for deployment during the demolition. No untoward incident was reported.

Debris lying scattered as the Centre took possession of the 53.24-acre premises in the Race Course area on Thursday. Several structures were demolished, including the stables, bookmakers' ring, winning post, photo-finish camera, and saddling enclosure. PTI

The dispute over the property began in March when the L&DO issued a notice directing the club to vacate the government land within 15 days, stating that it was required for public purposes. The club challenged the notice before a single-judge Bench of the Delhi High Court, which had directed the authorities not to proceed further with the matter until July 30.

However, the Centre had appealed the single-judge Bench order before a Division Bench of the High Court. The Division Bench of the High Court set aside an interim order that stayed the show-cause proceedings against the club, allowing the eviction process to continue.

On August 11, the Estate Officer directed the club to vacate the premises within 15 days, holding that its lease had expired on December 31, 1994, and had not been renewed.

The Centre has maintained that the lease executed in 1926 was temporary and that the club had remained in unauthorised occupation since January 1, 1995. The club's main appeal against the eviction order is scheduled for final disposal before the court on September 26.

Teen flaunts firearm on social media; apprehended

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The police have apprehended a 17-year-old youth from north-east Delhi's Welcome area for allegedly displaying an illegal firearm in a video posted on social media, officials said on Thursday, adding that the weapon has been seized.

Following information about the video circulating widely on Instagram, a police team conducted a raid and apprehended the teenager on Wednesday. The police have recovered a country-made pistol from his possession during a search. A case has been registered and further probe is going on, officials added.

Goal is to ensure no woman goes unheard: DCW chief

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Lata Gupta, newly appointed chairperson of Delhi Commission of Women (DCW), on Thursday said her sole objective is to ensure that no woman goes unheard in the national capital. In an interview with *The Hindu*, Ms. Gupta said every woman must feel supported and cared for. "This is what the commission was formed for and I will ensure it remains accessible to the women of Delhi. Women must not feel they are alone in this city," she said.

"There are so many women who are not aware of their rights, who don't know the legal process to follow in case of harassment, either at the workplace, at home or at public places. Our focus is to expand awareness and take it to colonies through RWAs, at offices, schools and colleges," the DCW chief said.

DCW chairperson Lata Gupta in her office. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Ms. Gupta was appointed at the end of July this year. The post remained vacant for two years after former chairperson Swati Maliwal resigned in 2024, following her nomination to the Rajya Sabha by the then-ruling Aam Aadmi Party.

A former two-time municipal councillor from Laxmi Nagar in the East Delhi Municipal Corporation, Ms. Gupta has also worked with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Mahila Morcha and served as the vice-president of Delhi BJP. Ms. Gupta said she wants the DCW to create greater awareness so that not a single complaint goes unheard. "I don't compare my work with anyone. We are focusing on digitisation of complaints, thorough follow-ups and time-bound action," she said.

Besides running women's helpline and overseeing the Sakhi One-Stop centres, the DCW will focus strongly on Prevention of Sexual Harassment at workplaces Act (POSH) and cyber fraud, she added.

Lawyer, father held after wife dies by suicide

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A lawyer and his father were arrested on charges of dowry harassment following the death of his 29-year-old wife, the police said on Thursday.

The woman died allegedly by suicide in her south-west Delhi residence on Wednesday. The police said her husband, Harshal Varma, was not present at the site at the time of incident. His father Dinesh Kumar Varma runs a jewellery shop at R.K. Puram in Delhi. The woman's father told mediapersons that she had been facing dowry demands since her marriage in February."Prima facie, there no visible injury marks were found on the body. Post mortem report is awaited," an officer said.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help.)

GIPMER expands neurovascular health care

The Delhi Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Neuro Cath Lab at Govind Ballabh Pant Institute of Postgraduate Medical Education & Research (GIPMER) has completed six months of service, expanding access to advanced neurovascular care for patients. Inaugurated by Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh in February, the lab provides diagnostic cerebral and spinal digital subtraction angiography, endovascular coiling of intracranial aneurysms, and arteriovenous malformation embolisation.

Anita Jagetia, Director Professor and Head of Department of Neurosurgery, GIPMER, said the facility had enhanced the institute's ability to manage complex cases.

Over 1,000 IGDTUW students land plum placement offers

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women (IGDTUW) successfully developed and handed over 75 surveillance drones to Delhi Police under the 'Netra-Naari-Netritva' initiative, and over 1,000 students secured placement offers, with the highest package of ₹1 crore, as per the Chief Minister's Office (CMO).

Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday attended the valedictory ceremony of the 'Prabodhan' Induction Programme-2026 at the IGDTUW. They also inaugurated the university's lecture hall complex equipped with modern facilities. "During the recent placement season, IGDTUW students received more than 1,000 placement offers, with the highest package recorded at ₹1 crore. These achievements reflect the growing confidence of Delhi's daughters," the CMO said in a statement.

Delhi L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu with CM Rekha Gupta at the Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women on Thursday. ANI

131 kg of expired food articles destroyed

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi's Food Safety Department identified and destroyed over 131 kg of expired food articles, including *besan* (gram flour), *khoya* (soft cheese), and *atta* (whole wheat), during an inspection, officials said on Thursday.

Ahead of Raksha Bandhan and Janmashtami, surprise inspections were conducted on Wednesday at sweet manufacturing units in Okhla, Badli, Nihal Vihar, and Narela, as well as at mandis, including Okhla Subzi Mandi and Ghanta Ghar Subzi Mandi.

The drive comes ahead of Raksha Bandhan and Janmashtami festivals.

The teams also collected 37 samples of paneer, ghee, sweets and other food products.

Now, Maharashtra CM says auto and taxi drivers will get 1 year to learn Marathi

Fadnavis says his govt. has accepted the drivers' request for more time; announces no action will be taken during this period for not having the required knowledge of the State's official language

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday announced that the government has decided to give autorickshaw and taxi drivers one year to learn "functional Marathi".

The Chief Minister made the announcement after a delegation of representatives of autorickshaw and taxi drivers, led by Haji Arfat Shaikh, met him.

"They requested one year's time. The State government has accepted their demand. No action will be taken against the during this period. Marathi classes will be organised and study material will be provided to help migrant drivers learn functional Marathi. They have come forward and are willing to learn. Therefore, it was necessary to give them time," Mr. Fadnavis said.

The State government had announced in April that non-Marathi drivers must have basic proficiency in the language. FILE PHOTO

Facing backlash

The move comes days after the Transport Department headed by Shiv Sena Minister Pratap Sarnaik carried out a checking drive and issued notices to drivers who failed a Marathi test.

The State government faced backlash by a section of drivers, especially ahead of the 2027 Assembly election in Bharatiya Janata Party-ruled Uttar Pradesh. Maharashtra hosts a large workforce from U.P. across major economic hubs like Mumbai, Pune, and Nashik.

Mr. Fadnavis said the representatives shared the concerns of drivers. "They support the decision to learn functional Marathi, but said people of different age groups are in the profession. Many of them left studies years ago. In such a short span, it is difficult for them to learn the language. They have made an elaborate plan to learn functional Marathi in one year. So, the State government will help them learn it," he said.

The government had announced in April that non-Marathi drivers must attain basic proficiency in the State's official language and set August 15 as the deadline. Marathi classes were then organised for the drivers in the interim period.

Police remove TMC hoarding after scuffle

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

A billboard, bearing the logo of 'All India Trinamool Congress', was removed from a building located at 9, Camac Street on Thursday after Kolkata Police and civic officials were embroiled in a scuffle with Trinamool Congress (TMC) leaders, including party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and MP Derek O' Brien. The police said several other offices were located in the building and a billboard of a political party cannot be put up on it.

Timings
DELHI

FRIDAY, AUG. 28		
RISE	05:57	SET 18:47
RISE	18:54	SET 05:52
SATURDAY, AUG. 29		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:46
RISE	19:24	SET 06:49
SUNDAY, AUG. 30		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:45
RISE	19:54	SET 07:48

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	34	26
Safdarjang	34	26
Palam	34	24

Delhi Palam Today
35°C The weather will be mostly dry. Day will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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Employees' stir intensifies as Punjab CM cancels meet

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH/FEROZEPUR

Work was affected in various government departments and outpatient department services remained suspended in public hospitals in Punjab on Thursday as over three lakh government employees went on a State-wide strike pressing for their demands that included release of pending dearness allowance.

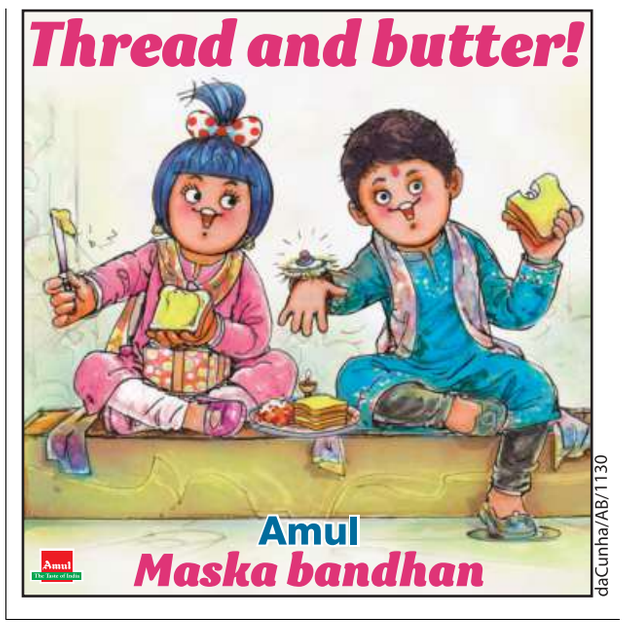
A scheduled meeting between Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and representatives of the employees' bodies in Jalandhar was cancelled after he made it clear that talks would be held only when they call off the strike. The employees, however, insisted on holding an unconditional meeting.

Mr. Mann also claimed that Punjab government staff are the highest paid among all government servants in the country.

Large participation

Over 150 employees' bodies under the banner of the Punjab Sanjha Mulazam Manch have joined hands for the 'maha hartal'. Over 3.5 lakh pensioners are also participating in the strike. Government offices either wore a deserted look or had very thin presence with many taking casual leave. Protests were held at district headquarters and other places.

The strike by government staff is seen as one of the biggest mobilisations against the Aam Aadmi Party dispensation in the State particularly ahead of the 2027 Assembly poll.



Amid speculation of Cong. joining J&K govt., Dy. CM exudes hope; Karra shuts down buzz

Press Trust of India
JAMMU

Jammu and Kashmir Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Kumar Choudhary on Thursday said the Congress, being a ruling alliance partner, has every right to join the Omar Abdullah-led government and expressed hope that it would soon take a decision in this regard.

His remarks came amid speculation over the Congress joining the National Conference-led government in Jammu and Kashmir. "The Congress has joined the alliance with a clear heart and clear intentions, and we hope that it will soon join the government as well," Mr. Choudhary told reporters in Jammu.

"Ever since this government was formed and we entered into the alliance, it was our desire that the Congress should join the government. There has been some delay as the Congress was unable to take a decision... but now we hope that it will join the government soon," the Deputy Chief Minister said.

'Restore Statehood'

However, Jammu and Kashmir Congress president Tariq Hameed Karra ruled out his party joining the government in the Union Territory, saying the Congress will not join the Cabinet till Statehood is restored to J&K.

Mr. Karra said the Congress could remain part of the government but would not accept a Cabinet position until the rights of the people of Jammu and Kashmir, which were "unconstitutionally, undemocratically and unilaterally" taken away, are restored.

2020 Delhi riots: Supreme Court seeks police's reply on bail petition of accused in UAPA case

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has sought a response from Delhi Police on a plea filed by Athar Khan seeking bail in a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) concerning the "larger conspiracy" behind the 2020 riots in Delhi.

A Bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M. Pancholi issued notice to Delhi Police on an appeal filed by Mr. Khan challenging the Delhi High Court's July 7 judgment refusing bail to him. "Issue notice. List after eight weeks," the Bench said.

The High Court had dismissed Mr. Khan's appeal challenging the trial court's January 29 order that denied him relief, stating that he was but "one of the main conspirators who conspired to cause deaths during the riots" and not a "local-level operator".

His lawyer sought bail on the grounds that he was a "local-level facilitator" who had been in custody for six years and that the apex court granted bail to similarly placed co-accused.

'Clearly distinguishable'

The High Court had considered the Supreme Court's findings on the bail pleas by the co-accused and held that Mr. Athar's role was "clearly distinguishable" from those given relief.

INBRIEF

Mizoram House adopts 'Ro Min Rel Sak Ang Che' as State song

The Mizoram Assembly on Thursday unanimously adopted the Mizo patriotic song 'Ro Min Rel Sak Ang Che' as the official State song. Chief Minister Lalduhoma, who moved the resolution, said around 14 States in the country already have their own State songs and there was no objection to having a State song as long as it did not conflict with the National Anthem and the National Song. PTI

40 electric scooters gutted in Bihar showroom fire

A fire broke out at a electric scooter showroom in Bihar's Rohtas district on Thursday morning, gutting around 40 scooters and three e-rickshaws, the police said. The incident took place at Akorhi Gola Bazar in the district. Showroom operator Jitendra Kumar Singh said he was cleaning the premises when the battery of a scooter parked inside exploded. PTI

Correction

The headline, 'ITA calls for targeted invention to safeguard 'troubled' Darjeeling and Dooars tea industry', in an article published in some editions on August 27, 2026, should have read 'ITA calls for targeted intervention...' The error is regretted.

Jharkhand Cong. launches Statewide protest opposing mines and minerals Act

Day-long dharnas held in all 24 districts; Centre attempting to usurp the rights of States, says party leader; State BJP president accuses the Congress of seeking to 'divert attention from real issues'

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Jharkhand unit of the Congress on Thursday staged protests in all 24 districts against the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026. It alleged that the law would restrict the State's powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing land parcels and cause financial losses.

Hitting back, State Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) chief Aditya Sahu said the Congress's continuous opposition to the Act is merely "a conspiracy to mislead the nation and divert attention from real issues".

Dharnas were organised at Collectorates and memoranda were submitted to President Droupadi Murmu, through Deputy Commissioners, seeking her intervention in the matter.

In Ranchi, Congress workers led by State party president Keshav Mahto Kamlesh took out a march from Bapu Vatika at Morabadi Ground. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Rajesh Thakur, former State Congress chief and AICC observer for West Bengal, said the Centre is making a bid to "usurp the rights" of States through the Act and called it a "direct attack" on Jharkhand's economy.

Congress workers taking out a rally in Jharkhand's Koderma on Thursday against the mines and minerals Act. X/INCJHARKHAND_

"Jharkhand received mineral-based revenue of approximately ₹1,380 crore in 2024-25 and ₹7,487.91 crore in 2025-26, providing financial strength to various State development and public welfare schemes. Restricting the right to levy cess on minerals could result in an estimated annual revenue loss of up to ₹14,656 crore for Jharkhand. How will displaced persons, tribals, and indigenous communities sustain themselves?" Mr. Thakur said.

'Unacceptable move'

The Congress leader said directives from Delhi are "unacceptable" when the land and minerals belong to Jharkhand and the people bear the brunt of pollution and displacement.

He questioned why the Centre is attempting to "curtail the States' power" to levy a cess when "the Supreme Court has already granted them this right".

'Made State an ATM'

Addressing a press conference in Ranchi, Mr. Sahu described the Congress as a party "devoid of genuine issues". He alleged that the party has turned Jharkhand - where it is a ruling ally of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha - into "an ATM".

"A massive student agitation is under way, false cases are being registered, and students are being intimidated by the police. The Congress wants to divert attention from this issue. It has treated Jharkhand like an ATM and is opposing this Act solely because their wrongful income from coal is about to stop; their anger is a reaction to this impending loss," the State BJP chief said, referring to the recent student protests demanding scrapping of State-level exams.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari during the inauguration of LTM's state-of-the-art IT campus in Kolkata on Thursday. ANI

At IT campus launch, CM invites skilled workers back to W.B.

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Observing that the objective of his government was to create employment opportunities for the State's large pool of educated youth, West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Thursday inaugurated LTM's state-of-the-art IT campus, 'Ananda Niketan', in New Town, Kolkata.

The Chief Minister also urged skilled and educated professionals from the State working elsewhere in India and abroad to return, assuring them of employment opportunities under the "double-engine government".

Mr. Adhikari assured LTM, a Larsen & Toubro group company formerly known as LTIMindtree, that the State government would hand over an additional 10 acres of land for setting up a data centre. The company had written to the government seeking the land around two months ago, he said.

'Premier tech hub'

"West Bengal is moving ahead with immense momentum. With our rich talent pool, upcoming world-class infrastructure and brand new industry-friendly policies, West Bengal is fast cementing its position as the premier tech and innovation hub," Mr. Adhikari said in a social media post.

After the Bharatiya Janata Party government came to power in May this year, the new government has attempted to rebrand West Bengal as an investment destination.

Shah hails water management in Gujarat under Modi; says no drought in State in last 25 years

Press Trust of India
AMRELI

Union Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said Gujarat has undergone a major transformation in water management after Narendra Modi became the State Chief Minister in 2001, and claimed the State did not witness a drought-like situation in the last 25 years.

Mr. Shah was speaking after inaugurating a 21-acre lake developed by a trust run by diamond baron and Padma Shri recipient Savjibhai Dholakia at Dudhala village in Gujarat's Amreli district.

Recalling the severe droughts of 1985, 1986 and 1987, the Union Home Minister alleged that corruption was rampant under the then Congress government, including in the government-run Rafaleshwar cattle camp during the drought period.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurating the 'Gujarat Gaurav Sarovar', on World Lake Day, in Amreli on Thursday. PTI

"If we create a system to save every single drop of rain and ensure it seeps into the earth, the threat of drought will never loom over our country and State," said Mr. Shah.

'1.5 lakh check dams'

He said the Modi government in the State constructed 1.5 lakh check dams in a single year in 2003 and later expanded water conservation efforts through projects such as the Narmada canal network, SAUNI Yojana and Sujalam Sufalam Yojana.

The foundation stone of the Narmada project was laid by then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru in 1964, but its gates were opened after Mr. Modi became the Prime Minister, Mr. Shah said.

Bodoland Territorial Council's Deputy Speaker found dead

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Bijit Gwra Narzary, the Deputy Speaker of Assam's Bodoland Territorial Council (BTC), was found dead in Tamulpur district's Kumarikata on Wednesday evening. A Bharatiya Janata Party leader who represented the Darrangajuli constituency of the BTC was found dead at his residence. Police said the reason behind his death was being ascertained.

BTC chief mourns death

BTC chief and Bodoland People's Party president Hagrama Mohilary mourned the Deputy Speaker's death.

"I am deeply saddened by the untimely demise of Bijit Gwra Narzary, fHonourable Deputy Speaker of the Bodoland Territorial Council. His sudden passing is an irreparable loss to our community and public life," Mr. Mohilary said in a condolence message.

Bijit Gwra Narzary

Former BTC chief and MP Pramod Boro, who heads the United People's Party Liberal, also offered his condolences on Narzary's demise.

"I pray for the eternal peace of the departed soul and extend my heartfelt condolences to his family, loved ones, and all those mourning this immense loss. May they find strength and courage to overcome this difficult time," he said.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

BJP's 'true casteist nature' is exposed by its Haldwani ritual defence, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) Uttarakhand unit chief Mahendra Bhatt of defending the alleged purification ritual conducted at a venue in Haldwani after Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there, the Congress on Thursday asked whether the ruling party would act against him for "defending untouchability".

Mr. Bhatt had said the venue had been "polluted" by slogans that were not appropriate for a religious place, dismissing the Opposition's criticism of the ritual.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said the remarks showed that Union Minister J.P. Nadda's expression of regret in the Rajya Sabha over the incident involving the Congress president was "a mere eyewash".

J.P. Nadda's expression of regret in RS a mere eyewash, said Cong. leader K.C. Venugopal

"It was evident from Day 1 that Union Minister J.P. Nadda's statement of regret in the Rajya Sabha was a mere eyewash. If Mr. Nadda truly meant that the BJP doesn't subscribe to such acts, how is the BJP's own Uttarakhand chief is defending the so-called 'shuddhikaran' that their workers did after Kharge ji's event?" Mr. Venugopal said in a post on X.

"The BJP's true casteist nature keeps rearing its ugly head, no matter how much cover-up their leaders attempt. If there is even an iota of truth in Mr. Nadda's statement in Parliament, they must sack Mr. Mahendra Bhatt and take strict criminal action against those who insulted Kharge ji," he said.

It's a tragedy: Khera

Congress media and publicity department head Pawan Khera, while sharing a video of Mr. Bhatt's remarks, said, "In the 21st century, Dalits are still subjected to such dehumanising practices. That itself is a tragedy. But if this can happen to the Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha and one of the tallest Dalit leaders in the country, (it) elucidates how far worse the everyday reality must be for ordinary Dalits."

Exam to hire teachers in one phase: Bihar CM

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

The Bihar government on Thursday agreed to the main demand of protesting students for conducting Teacher Recruitment Examination-4 (TRE-4) in a single phase.

"The government has been serious about the students' demands from the very beginning. Now, a decision has been taken that this year's TRE-4 examination will be conducted in a single phase. Along with this, nine other important decisions have also been made," Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary wrote on X while sharing the information.

Alleged use of children in poll campaign not a ground to set aside victory, T.N. Chief Minister tells Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has contended before the Madras High Court that his rival candidate in the Tiruchi East Assembly constituency, S. Inigo Irudayaraj of the DMK, had failed to demonstrate how the alleged use of children in an election campaign could be raised as a ground for nullifying an election.

"Even assuming the allegations to be correct for the limited purpose of the present application (to reject the election petition)," the election petitioner had failed to plead the necessary material facts to declare an election void under Section 100 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, he said.

The DMK's Irudayaraj had accused Vijay of having "blackmailed" children.

The submissions were made in an application filed before Justice V. Lakshminarayanan to reject Mr. Irudayaraj's election petition. After hearing senior counsel Srinath Sridevan, assisted by Pranjal Agarwal, appearing for the Chief Minister, the judge directed the Registry to number the application and list it on August 31.

In his election petition, Mr. Irudayaraj had accused the Chief Minister of having "blackmailed" children during the 2026 Assembly election campaign. "The first respondent (Mr. Vijay) has, through his speeches, emotionally targeted and, to a degree, even blackmailed vulnerable children and impressionable minds to garner the votes of their family members," he said.

However, in his plea to reject the election petition, Mr. Vijay said an election petition could not be filed on the basis of mere assertions that the voters were "emotionally swayed" without there being any material facts to establish that the appeal made by the returned candidate had resulted in a particular number of votes having been cast in his favour.

The CM also said that though the election petitioner had accused him of having used religion to garner votes, the petitioner had not set out the precise words, communication, or representation. He argued that the allegations regarding excess poll expenditure were vague, and that the expenditure incurred by the TVK functionaries could not be attributed to him.

Separately, Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna of the TVK denied the allegation that he had misrepresented the assets owned by him and his wife, Daisy Aadhav Arjuna, in his election affidavit, and urged the Madras High Court to reject an election petition filed by his rival candidate, Karthik Mohan of the DMK, challenging his victory from the Villivakkam constituency.

'Correct disclosure'

In the rejection application, also filed before Justice Lakshminarayanan, the Minister said he had made true and correct disclosure in the Form 26 affidavit filed before the Returning Officer, and that even if any information had been missed, that by itself could not become a reason for invalidating an election unless there were materials to prove that such non-disclosure had materially affected the result of the polls.

BJD opposes biometric attendance proposal for college students

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Thursday criticised the Mohan Majhi-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government's move to introduce biometric attendance system for college students, alleging that it was an attempt intimidate students.

"The State government, in an attempt to hide its own inefficiency, is talking about biometric attendance for students... The government is trying to intimidate students in the name of discipline. Such an approach of the government towards Gen Z is not appropriate," said BJD spokesperson Lenin Mohanty.

"Biometric attendance has still not been introduced for teachers and staff in colleges across the State. In this context, proposing to introduce a biometric attendance system for students is a reflection of the Tughlaqi policy of the government," he said, also claiming that BJP leaders are interfering in the management of colleges.

Mr. Mohanty pointed out that the government announced free education from kindergarten (KG) to postgraduate (PG) level in the State. "However, no clear instructions in this regard have been issued, due to which fees are still being collected from students," he said.

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ISSN 0971 - 751X

INBRIEF

Bevco records liquor sales of ₹771.29 cr. during Onam week

The Kerala State Beverages Corporation (Bevco) clocked liquor sales of ₹771.29 crore during the eight days leading up to Onam till August 25. The corresponding figure during the previous year was ₹694.9 crore, its Managing Director told *The Hindu*. The highest daily sales of ₹132.87 crore during the period was recorded on August 24, while the sales on August 25 was ₹126.34 crore. The sales figures for Uthradom were lower compared to the previous year's ₹137.64 crore.

Seven killed as bus hits auto in Andhra Pradesh town

Seven people were killed, and eight sustained injuries when a private bus rammed an autorickshaw at Addaroad Centre in Chilakaluripet town of Palnadu district, Andhra Pradesh, on Thursday. Fifteen people, all from Veluru village in Chilakaluripet mandal, had travelled in the autorickshaw to Konda Manjuluru village in J. Panguluru mandal of Prakasam district, the police said.While returning to Veluru, the autorickshaw was taking a turn at Addaroad Centre when it was hit by a private travel bus travelling from Vijayawada to Tirupati.

Keralam forest officials to face custodial torture trial

Eight Forest officials from Keralam, including an IFS couple, will face trial for custodial torture, a decade after the alleged incident. Last week, the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court, Thiruvananthapuram, ordered the prosecution of IFS officers T. Uma; her husband, R. Kamalahar; and K. Vijayanandan, and forest officials T.S. Mathew Jyothish, T. Sreejith, R.B. Arunkumar and K.S. Anu Krishnan on a complaint from Aji Brait, an accused in the Malayattoor elephant poaching case in 2015.

NLSIU cancels convocation amid protests over CJI invite

Varsity cites 'unavoidable circumstances', says graduates can collect degree certificate from office or get it through courier; students and alumni were against inviting CJI and BCI chief to the event

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, has cancelled its convocation ceremony for the graduating students of 2026.

In a letter dated August 27, a copy of which is with *The Hindu*, the Registrar said: "On August 3, the academic administration team emailed graduating students, with advance notice, informing them that September 12 was the proposed date for the annual convocation. Despite our collective best efforts, we are unable to hold the 34th Annual Convocation due to unavoidable circumstances."

NLSIU students had expressed solidarity with NALSAR students, and sought the BCI's apology. FILE PHOTO

"All students will be conferred their degrees *in absentia* after due approval by the governing bodies. Students may elect to receive their certificates by courier or collect them on campus," the letter said.

The decision came after graduating students and alumni of NLSIU wrote to the administration on August 15, opposing the invitation extended to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra for the convocation. The letter opposing the invitation was signed by 165 graduating students, 409 current students, and 128 alumni.

The letter was in support of Hyderabad's NALSAR University of Law students and faculty, and had sought the BCI's apology. The BCI chief had directed the State Bar Council not to enrol NALSAR students after they opposed the presence of the Chief Justice at their convocation.

The university told *The Hindu* that "no student will suffer any adverse consequences arising out of the decision not to hold a convocation."

HC says no to Mamata faction operating frozen bank accounts

The Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday refused to pass an interim order allowing the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress faction to operate four debit-frozen bank accounts holding around ₹804 crore, observing that granting such relief would undermine its earlier order permitting the political party to meet day-to-day expenses.

The matter will come up for hearing again after the Durga Puja vacation, before which the parties will file their affidavits stating their respective positions, the court directed.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya observed that passing a further order permitting operation of the four accounts would render his previous order "faulted".

The TMC had sought permission to operate four accounts with public sector banks that were debit-frozen by West Bengal Police, claiming there were lacunae in the FIRs related to the freezing.

Probe nod sought

The State government submitted that steps had been taken in the criminal prosecution in accordance with law and sought permission for the police to continue its investigation.

After hearing the parties, Justice Bhattacharyya said in view of his July 9 order appointing a special officer to clear and meet the day-to-day expenses of the political entity from three other debit-frozen accounts, no further order was required at this stage regarding the four accounts.

Shivakumar meets Congress top brass in Delhi amid Minister resignation demand

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/ NEW DELHI/ KALABURAGI

Amid the Opposition demand for the resignation of Planning and Statistics Minister B. Nagendra, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar met the party's Central leadership in Delhi on Thursday.

Responding to queries on political developments in Karnataka, Mr. Kharge dismissed speculation regarding an imminent Cabinet reshuffle or organisational changes. He clarified that decisions concerning ministerial appointments, portfolio reallocations, or Cabinet changes fall strictly under the purview of the Central leadership.

D.K. Shivakumar

"Any inclusion to or removal from the Cabinet will have to be done with my consultation. I have received no proposal on the matter," he said.

The party's assessment on Mr. Nagendra's issue was that the Governor was yet to accord sanction for prosecution in the case of Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy and former BJP Minister M.P. Renukacharya among others, and that the BJP was "playing politics" to bring down Mr. Nagendra to protect the interest of its own ST leader and former Minister B. Sriramulu.

According to party sources, the meeting also revolved around the induction of a woman into the Cabinet, and continued pressure by legislators to be inducted. Four women are being considered for one possible slot, and various combinations are being seen, sources said.

Meanwhile, a group of about 10 Congress legislators will be meeting the Central leadership on Friday seeking "honourable posts" according to their seniority, when heads of boards and corporations are nominated.

Government of Telangana
Department of Mines and Geology
2nd Floor, B.R.K.R Bhavan, (Burgula Rama Krishna Rao Bhavan), Government Offices Complex, Tank Bund Road, Saifabad, Hyderabad, Telangana-500063
Website: www.mines.telangana.gov.in e-mail: dmg-eauction-mines@telangana.gov.in

No. 2263906/DM&G-MI/Lst/2023 **Date: August 28, 2026**

Notice Inviting Tender
"Invitation of bids for grant of Mining Lease for Limestone Block and Composite Licence for Limestone Block"

Government of Telangana in exercise of the powers conferred by Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 and in accordance with the Mineral (Auction) Rules, 2015, invites tender from the eligible bidders for the e-auction of major minerals in the state.

Eligibility conditions, timelines, terms, and conditions etc. for participating in the electronic auction are provided in the Tender Document available in electronic form only and can be downloaded from e-auction portal of MSTC Limited.

Interested and eligible bidders can register themselves on the above e-auction portal. The bidders can participate in the bidding only after online purchase of the Tender Document on payment of the Tender fee from the above e-auction portal. Any revision, clarifications, addendum, corrigendum, time extensions, etc. to the tender document will be hosted on the above e-auction portal only and no separate notifications shall be issued in the press.

Model Tender Document and Mineral Block Summaries are available free of cost and Block Specific Tender documents are available for purchase on the e-auction portal of MSTC Limited (https://www.mstcecommerce.com/auctionhome/mlcln/index.jsp).

The date for commencement of Sale of Tender Document is August 31, 2026. The pre-bid conference would be organised in hybrid mode on September 22, 2026. The venue, time and link for virtual mode shall be notified separately on the MSTC portal. The last date for purchase of Tender Document on the e-auction platform is October 12, 2026, and the last date for submission of the bid is October 19, 2026, on or before 17:00 hours (IST). The bidders shall note that financial bids are invited in digital format only and technical bids are invited both in digital and physical format.

List of Mineral Blocks for Auction

S. N.	Name of the Block	Mineral	District	Concession Type	Area (sq.km)	Exploration Level	#Price of Tender Document in (Rs.)
1	Mattampally Block-2	Limestone	Suryapet	ML	3.85	G3	5,00,000
2	Ganeshpalli Block	Limestone	Jagtial	CL	4.00	G4	3,00,000

#The Price of Tender Document for mineral block is exclusive of GST. GST is payable under Reverse Charge Mechanism.

R.O. No. : 472-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt: 27.08.2026

Sd/-
Director of Mines and Geology (FAC)

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

B KRISHNA BABU (68), Retired Foreman (Non Supervisory), Canteen Dept, The Hindu Chennai passed away on 26.08.2026. Address: 886 LIG I Phase III TNHB MG Nagar Ambattur Chennai - 600058. Ct: 99625 91365.

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LEGAL NOTICE

DISTRICT CONSUMER DISPUTES REDRESSAL COMMISSION, THENI

C.C. No. 55/2025
Sugapriya ... Complainant
Versus
1.The Branch Manager, M/s Adhar Housing Finance, Theni.
2.The Branch Manager, M/s Bajaj Allianz General Insurance Co., Theni.
3.The Branch Manager, Pramerica Life Insurance, 4th Floor, Building No. 9, Tower B,Cyber City, DLF City Phase III,Gurgaon, Haryana.
---Opposite Parties

The above-mentioned complainant has filed a complaint before the District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission against the 3rd Opposite Party alleging deficiency in service and unfair trade practice, and in the said complaint, the matter has been posted for hearing on 9.09.2026. In this regard, if the 3rd Opposite Party has any objection, they may appear before the Hon'ble Court at 10.00 a.m. on the said date and state their objections. Failing which, the matter will be decided ex parte.

Mr. T. Ambasshankar, B.A., B.L.,
Mr. A. Jeganathan, B.A., B.L.,
Mrs. S. Banumathy, B.A., B.L.,
ADVOCATES
4, South Street, Thenkarai, Periyakulam, Theni Dt, Tamilnadu.
Place: Periyakulam
Date: 28.08.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

TO INFORM that my original builder buyer agreement, Allotment letter and booking receipt of Espania Royale Floors, TDI Infrastructure Ltd, Kamaspur, Sonipat has been lost of customer ID KRF–00248 and Unit No. RF–52/SF, receipt No. 0001243 of Rs. 350000 Dated – 24/03/2012. Finder may contact:– Mr. Jasper deswal –9211431748

Urban Development & Housing Department
Govt. of Bihar
1st Floor, Vikas Bhawan, New Secretariat, Patna - 800015
Phone: 0612-2215580 | Fax: 2217059 | Email: urbansec-bih@nic.in
09/न०वि०(विविध)–11/2026–9030

TENDER CANCELLATION NOTICE
PR No. 007250 (Urban) 2026-27

Due to unavoidable reasons, the Request for Proposal (RFP) invited for **"Retender (Group 3)- Request for Proposal for Selection of Consultant for the Preparation of Town Planning Scheme(s) for the Multiple Greenfield Satellite Townships in Bihar "** bearing PR No. 007250 (Urban) 2026-27and NIT no-6903 is hereby cancelled.

(Prabhat Bhushan)
Officer on Special Duty
Urban Development and Housing Department

PR- 010657 (Urban) 2026-27
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
e-PROCUREMENT NOTICE
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer HP PWD Division Manali at Katrain on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh invites the percentage rate bids in electronic tendering system, for construction of following work from the eligible and approved contractors/Firm registered with HP,PWD,

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Estimated cost of the Work	Bid Security / EMD	Cost of Document	Period of Completion.
1.	Balance work for the construction of By Pass road from NH 03 Saba Restaurant to Club House Manali 0/00 to 1/800 (SH:- Metalling and Tarring, W-metal beam, U and V-shape drain and road furniture etc.)	1,81,44,787/-	3,62,900/-	5000/-	6 Months

Key dates:-

1.	Date of Online Publication	27.08.2026 at 11.30 AM.
2.	Document Download Start and End Date	27.08.2026 to 02.09.2026 at 05.00 PM.
3.	Bid Submission Start and End Date	27.08.2026 to 02.09.2026 at 05.00 PM.
4.	Physical submission of EMD and cost of tender document	03.09.2026 at 10.00 AM
5.	Date of Technical Bid opening, Evaluation of Technical Bid	03.09.2026 at 11:30 AM

Bidders documents can be downloaded from the website http:/.hptenders.gov.in .The documents downloaded from the Missing site should not be tempered, and if any such tempering is detected before or after the opening of bids, the bidder shall be penalized and black listed.
The Bidder is requested to study ITB, HP. PWD. Form-6 and 7/8 and general Rule and Direction, conditions of contract clauses and upload all required document in pdf from on the website http:/.hptenders.gov.in and submit all desired documents in original with in specified period to the office of the Executive Engineer HP PWD Manali at Katrain.
Other details can be seen in the bidding documents. The employer shall not be held liable for any delays due to system failure beyond its control. Even though the system will attempt to notify the bidders of any bid updates, the employer shall not be liable for any information not received by the bidder, it is the bidders responsibility to verify the website for the latest information related the tender.
Other terms and condition shall remain same as given in the bid document.
Terms & Conditions:-
Scanned copy of Registration Enlistment with H.P.P.W.D. Deptt.
Scanned copy of PAN TIN Income Tax clearance certificate .
Scanned copy of work done certificate of similar nature of work.
Scanned copy of Earnest Money and Cost of Form.
Scanned copy of Machinery i.e. Air Compressor, Tipper, Road Rollers, sencer Paver etc.
The Bidder should have already installed Hot Mix Plant Minimum DM-45 with in specified permissible distance 60 Km. from the Division as per MOST Guidelines form the site of work for JOB.

HP / 2954/26-27
HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMAPRK
Executive Engineer, HP PWD Division Manali, at Katrain.

GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
DIRECTORATE OF BACKWARD CLASSES WELFARE
CHENNAI- 600 005

e-Tender Notice No.01/2026-27 **Dated:26.08.2026**
e-TENDER NOTICE - INVITING TENDER UNDER FIXED RATE CONTRACT FROM MANUFACTURERS OF MODERN BICYCLES ALONG WITH HELMET AND WATER BOTTLE FOR SCHOOL GIRLS AND BOYS WITHIN INDIA

For and on behalf of the Governor of Tamil Nadu, Online e-Tenders are invited under fixed rate contract for the supply of School Girl's and Boy's Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and water bottle under Two Cover System from the reputed Bi-cycle Manufacturing Firms within the Union of India. The firms should conform to IS Specifications (IS No. 10613: 2023 or latest) as specified in the Tender Document and have valid ISO certification and capacity to deliver the Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water Bottle as per the requirements.

DETAILS OF e-TENDER NOTICE NO. 01/2026-27

Tender inviting Officer/ Authority Designation Address	**The Director,** Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Description of item	Procurement of approximately **2,37,133** numbers of School Boys Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle and **2,95,255** numbers of School Girls Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle. Total **5,32,388** number of Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle to be supplied for the year 2026-27.
Period of supply	**150** days from the date of receipt of Purchase Order.
Earnest Money Deposit	**Rs.70,00,000/- (Rupees Seventy Lakh only)** payment should be made only through online.
Tender documents available for obtaining e- Tender	For free download of Tender document and for further details please visit the Government portal https://tntenders.gov.in & e-Tender should be submitted only through Online mode.
Period of submission of e-Tender	From **29.08.2026 to 28.09.2026** at 3.00 PM through online mode at https://tntenders.gov.in
Date, Time and place of Pre-bid meeting	On **08.09.2026 at 11:00 AM,** in the Conference Hall of Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Submission of two Sample Modern Bicycles (one Girl and one Boy), Date, Time, Place and Officer.	**28.09.2026 upto 05.00 P.M** **THE DIRECTOR,** Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Date, time and place of Opening of Technical Bid of the e-Tender	**On 29.09.2026 at 11:30 AM** through online mode at **https://tntenders.gov.in**

DIPR/2677/Tender/2026
DIRECTOR, BACKWARD CLASSES WELFARE.

कार्यालय अधिष्ठाता, गजराराजा चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय, ग्वालियर
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क्रमांक 32143/क्रय/2026 ग्वालियर, 20 अगस्त 2026

प्रथम ई-निविदा सूचना

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1	Medical College & Attached Hospitals	One Time Rapair, CAMC & Operation of VRV System Make - Daikin	2026_DME_531219_1
2	Medical College, J.A. Group of Hospitals, Super Speciality Hospital & Hostels	Generators CMC & Maintenance Work (Rate Contract Yearly)	2026_DME_531220_1
3	MDRU	Purchase of 450-500 Lit. Refrigerators - 02 Nos.	2026_DME_531221_1
4	Medical College, J.A. Group of Hospitals, Super Speciality Hospital & Hostels	Coolers, Ceiling Fan	2026_DME_531222_1
5	Medical College, J.A. Group of Hospitals, Super Speciality Hospital & Hostels	Mechenic Workshop Repair Material - Rate Contract	2026_DME_531223_1
6	Microbiology	Laboratory Consumables Items	2026_DME_531224_1

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G17732/26

Students at the Manjari ST Hostel in Maharashtra have been protesting in the corridors of the boys' section, with the women commuting about 4 km daily to the protest site. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

Gen Z Adivasis ask for more

In Manjari village, on the outskirts of Pune, tribal students have been protesting for over two weeks with a hunger strike against the Maharashtra government, which they say has not heard them for years. Among 14 demands is their need for better hostel infrastructure and Supreme-Court-mandated employment assured nine years ago. **Vinaya Deshpande Pandit** speaks with the students, many of whom are first-generation college-goers

Students have been protesting for 16 days at the Manjari ST Hostel on the outskirts of Pune city, seeking safety, health, and better educational quality and infrastructure. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

As the media cameras hover over a youth group of 70-80 students, men on the left and women on the right, they lash out at the booms: "The government should feel ashamed! Its young generation has been suffering silently, raising demands in a democratic manner. And what are they doing? Ignoring our voices. The Adivasi will not be silent now. We are the children of Birsa Munda," says a youth, his fists clasped. "There will be consequences if anything happens to our brothers and sisters who have been on a hunger strike," says another young woman.

A group of medical staff intervene as they check the vital parameters of the students lying down at the Manjari ST (Scheduled Tribes') Hostel on the outskirts of Pune, Maharashtra. Sleeping on cotton mattresses, covered in dusty blankets, these students on a hunger strike, gather all the energy when questions are posed to them.

A group of students sits around their heads, whispering in their ears about the delegation which has left to speak with the government. The blue table fans are tilted horizontally, to give relief to the students lying down, weak from not eating for 14 days.

Other protesters are busy checking their social media feed. Some live stream the protest on their personal social media handles. A public announcement system is in use almost all the time, motivating the students to fight for their rights.

At the hostel are posters of Dalit icon Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, the 19th-century educator-social reformer Savitribai Phule, and the 19th-century social reformer Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj. One is of Birsa Munda, the tribal leader the young woman referred to, who fought for indigenous rights. The government celebrated his 150th birth anniversary in 2025 with much ado.

Tribal students have been protesting from August 12-13 in at least 25 parts of Maharashtra, to draw the government's attention to their long-pending demands. These include the filling up of 12,500 government-job positions for tribals, as directed by the Supreme Court in 2017; better living conditions, kitchens, and reading rooms in hostels; improved and expanded educational facilities and infrastructure.

The government has held four rounds of talks with the protesters in Manjari. The students have a list of 14 demands. First, the government accepted one, suspending the clause of age limit for admission to the tribal government hostels.

On August 28, as the protest entered its 16th day and political mobilisation grew, Maharashtra's Tribal Affairs Minister, Ashok Uike, told students that the government has accepted all their demands. The students say they will withdraw the agitation once they receive the written draft of the government's assurances.

Hunger caused a strike

Hung from the ceiling in the corridor where the protest is taking place, are effigies of tamasha performers, legs dangling overhead. Tamasha is a local folk dance, and is also a word used pejoratively in Marathi to refer to drama. The protesters, most in their 20s, have put them up satirising what a senior administrative officer said. "'Stop your tamasha,' he told us. So we hung these here, to tell him that we won't," says a woman.

> We have sat for these protests for the last four years, ever since I entered the hostel. Why do we have to protest every year to make ourselves heard, to get basic concerns like safety and hygiene addressed?
>
> **GAURI PARDHI**
> A student in the Manjari ST Hostel

The narrow lane leading to the three buildings of the government-run tribal boys' hostel on the outskirts of Pune has been unusually abuzz with activity since Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's Pune visit. In his 'Chhatron ki Goonj' (Resonating Sounds of Students) rally held on August 22, he gave the protesting students a platform to speak, thereafter writing a letter to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, asking him to address the concerns of the students. It was after this that the age cut-off in hostels was removed.

Women come to the protest site daily, commuting about 4 km from the girls' hostel. Sometimes there may not be electricity or water; sometimes the bus is delayed.

Bustle in the lanes

Outside the narrow lane of the hostel, police *bandobast* (arrangement) has increased. So has the footfall. Several political parties and social organisations have visited to express their support. When political parties' delegations give lofty promises of support, the girls quickly seek their names and contact details.

The residents of the buildings around the hostel in the residential area are piqued by the rise in social interest. Standing around the muddy ditches in the lane, they whisper to each other about the flow of visitors.

As a doctor from the nearby Loni Kalbhor Public Health Centre checks the blood sugar and blood pressure levels of the agitating students, 26-year-old Shweta Irnak shrieks, her body convulsing. The doctor is unable to draw blood from her fingertips for a routine blood sugar level test. "They have pricked all my fingers. I can't take it anymore," she says, as the doctor announces that she needs to be moved to the hospital immediately.

Shweta Irnak (centre), 26, flanked by fellow protesters in Manjari village, Pune district, Maharashtra. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

"Their condition is critical. Shweta needs immediate medical attention. We have already evacuated Nikita Mechikar to the health centre," says Dr. Manoj Thawre. Of the six tribal students on a hunger strike in Manjari, Shweta is the second and the only girl at the protest site now. Nikita is under medical supervision at the Loni Kalbhor Primary Health Centre after she refused to go to a larger medical facility, Sassoon Hospital, about 15 kilometres away.

The medical team says that the blood pressure of all the protesting students has dropped; so has their blood sugar level. "But we are giving them only symptomatic treatment as they have refused to take any medicines. We administer IV fluids, but they come back to the protest site," he says. A nurse on rotation duty writes down the vital parameters of all the students on a chart.

For Nikita Mechikar, Shweta Irnak, Sharad Thokal, Rajaram Padvi, Vijay Bamble, and Rahul Dhanve, their hunger strike is a mission to force the government to hear their voices. These tribal youth from different parts of Maharashtra are united by their resolve not to give up.

First-generation learners

The immediate trigger for the protest this year was the government order issued on August 5, which capped the age limit for stay in the tribal hostels at 26 years. Several students say the hostel gives them the place to study for competitive exams and apply for jobs in the city, so that they can eventually stand on their own feet.

Tribal organisations and students' unions gave a memorandum to the government, seeking that the age limit be scrapped. After protests started in different parts of Maharashtra, the government issued a fresh order on August 14.

In this order, they increased the age limit to 30 years. By this time, the protests had already begun, and were fuelled by the death of three tribal girls from snake bite at a private aided tribal ashram school in Gadchiroli. The protesters demanded that the families of these girls receive compensation of ₹1 crore. They also asked for health insurance.

"There is so much competition in education, in jobs. Several of us are the first generation in our families to go for higher education. We don't have any resources to stay in big cities, to find jobs," says 21-year-old Gauri Pardhi from Junnar, a taluka in Pune district. Sitting at the protest site, she talks about how her younger brother is also a part of a similar protest in Ghodegaon, about 75 km away.

The government scrapped the age limit, but Vijay Waghmare, Secretary, Tribal Development Department, says the original intent of putting an age cap for stay in hostels, was to give younger tribal girls the opportunity to come and study in large cities.

"The younger tribal students need more sheltering and a sense of community belonging when they leave their house at the age of 18. The older tribal students will continue to be supported through the Swayam Scholarship scheme until they turn 30," he says. This is specifically for those who do not get hostel accomodation.

The students say that the state needs to build capacity to absorb more tribals in hostels. "For several years, the government has not increased the number of tribal hostels or the number of students who can be accommodated in them. Give us opportunities to study. Build more hostels," says Navnath More, a protester.

Many complain that ST hostels are often at the edges of cities, making commute time to colleges long and difficult. They want hostels within cities.

According to the state government, 59,020 students stay in 490 tribal hostels in Maharashtra.

A reiteration of needs

Among the list of demands the tribal students have made, is the withdrawal of Government Resolutions that restrict student assembly, protests, and union participation. They have also sought an immediate halt to invasive and compulsory medical practices, such as pregnancy tests in female tribal hostels, and have demanded better security for students.

"Most of these demands have been made each year. We have sat for these protests for the last four years, ever since I entered the hostel. Why do we have to protest every year to make ourselves heard, to get basic concerns like safety and hygiene addressed?" asks Pardhi.

Students also want the central kitchens which supply food shut, so fresh food is cooked at each tribal school location. "The tribal ashram schools are located far apart. Often, the food is cooked several hours before, and transported up to 100 km. There are times it goes bad. The children stay hungry," says Suchitra Pagi, also on protest.

Government officials say central kitchens are easier to monitor. "Quality control becomes easier. Local level complaints of bad food are avoided. This is a tried and tested model," an official of the Tribal Department says. For the tribal students studying in colleges, the protesters want the government to halt the Direct Benefit Transfer money and provide messes in each hostel instead.

On the filling of job vacancies, a government official says, "It is not something that can be done overnight. Our talks are on. We will find a way to handle this, but many departments are involved." Minister Uike told the protesters that he would discuss the issue with the Chief Minister and find a resolution.

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Crafting art (Clockwise from left) Artur Zurawski with Rani Mukherjee; Aditi Rao Hydari; filmmaker Kaizad Gustad; and Artur Zurawski. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA AND ARTUR ZURAWSKI

Polishing dreams

In Delhi for his solo exhibition, Artur Zurawski, the noted Polish cinematographer, talks about his craft and working with Indian stars

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Of late, Indian filmmakers are looking for an outside eye to realise their creative vision. They are turning to European directors of photography to give their celluloid dreams a shade of everyday reality. One of the most significant names of this surge is Artur Żurawski, whose lens work has redefined the visual language of commercial Hindi cinema. After capturing a monsoon-soaked Goa in Kaizad Gustad's *Jackpot*, the Polish cinematographer pivoted to raw realism when he injected a documentary-style grit into the Bollywood thriller *Mardaani*. Then he grounded Salman Khan's *Sultan*, a sports spectacle in Haryanvi texture, and this year he reunited with Rani Mukerji to frame the third installment of *Mardaani*.

In Delhi for his solo exhibition of still photographs with the Polish Institute, Artur says his role is to bring larger-than-life stories closer to life without making the experience too exotic for the audience. Initially shocked by the colours in frames, Artur says he is trying to balance art and culture. In European cinema, he says, actors have minimal hand gestures. "Here it is a little too much for me. I would advise the directors to limit it, but then it is culture." As for the emotions, Artur says they are not too different from what he experiences back home. "People of both countries have learnt to live with generational trauma. You faced the Partition, we were not on the map of the world for more than a century," he says.

Discovering India

What worked with Artur was that he didn't come to India with an image in mind. He was introduced to Satyajit Ray's cinema after working in India. Someone gifted him a DVD of Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Black*, but he did not know Rani was conscious of her camera profile or that no one can say 'no' to Salman. "For me, they were performers without the baggage of stardom. Rani trusted me completely. Salman comes to the set for a limited period of time, but he is open to suggestions. I knew I had to get the best out of his charismatic face. For the rest, there are body doubles!"

This intimacy is reflected in the 40 photographs on show at the exhibition, meaningfully titled *I See You*, where the moving images of Rani Mukerji and Aditi Rao Hydari go beyond the characters that exist on screen. "These are not behind-the-scenes photographs. The idea is to preserve traces of encounters and relationships that remain invisible once the film is complete," he muses.

As a cinematographer, Artur, who still cherishes his conversations with Pradeep Sarkar, says his job is not just to suggest to the director what angle will work, but also to stop him from spending time and money on unnecessary shooting. "I don't always succeed because sometimes the director is not clear in his head and shoots everything in wide angle as well as close-up and leaves the decision for post-production. When the director scratches his head, I sweat," Artur grins. Pushing for discretion in the use of technology, he says, as small drones have become accessible and affordable, the surprise factor in aerial shots has almost gone. "In *Mardaani*, I shot action sequences with one camera, but in *Sultan I* deployed seven. Yash Raj (Films) ordered an anamorphic lens from Germany for me to help elevate the wrestling sequences and add emotional depth."

Against the use of artificial intelligence in cinema, Artur, who took a workshop at AJK Mass Communication Research Centre in Jamia, says making movies through generative AI would be a catastrophe for creativity. "It can be used for creating a particular moment, like the way special effects are used, but these days it seems producers are eager to create entire movies through AI. It will still require a DOP because only he knows how to frame a shot to get the emotions. The danger is if the new generation of DOPs grow up with AI, they might not be able to differentiate."

Reflecting on the trends in cinematography, Artur shares that these days old lens are being tuned to create an unpretentious effect. "Lens that have issues with focus or edges are being used to create an impactful image. It could well be for one scene. Filmmakers want to recreate the effect of an iconic film, so we research to find the lens used, then when it could not be created through special effects."

After commercial success in India, Artur is now working on an art-house Nepalese film with director Bikash Subedi. Called *Shirjara*, Artur says, it is about the transformation of a young London-based AI engineer who travels to Nepal with her grandmother to code empathy. "The story is simple, but it requires technology to shoot at night or at dawn with natural light. I convinced Bikash to take the equipment from India, and do the post-production in Poland."

This cross-pollination of ideas is something that Artur cherishes. "I can say the food on Indian film sets is much better than what we get back home."

The exhibition runs until August 29 at Anant Art Gallery, Safdarganj Enclave.

All roads lead South

South Indian music, food, cinema, and art come together at the South Side Story

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Delhi has always been a city of arrivals. People come here from across the country, bringing with them their languages, food, music, memories and ways of making a home.

It is this spirit of cultural cross-pollination that Red FM's South Side Story has tapped into for the past seven years. What began as a music festival celebrating South Indian artistes has steadily grown into a broader cultural gathering, bringing the food, literature, cinema, dance and traditions of the South to audiences in the North. Now in its eighth edition, the festival returns to Delhi on August 29 and 30, with an eclectic line-up that moves from Thaikkudam Bridge and Karthik to dancer Shobana, Raghu Dixit, Avial, Baby Jean and Aksomaniac.

"We realised that it can't just be a music festival. It needs to be an experiential festival where people come and experience the culture, food, art, literature and cinema. That's why we have brought in kalaripayattu, chendamelam, the Onam sadya, literary conversations, cinema, art and craft. We want people to come and spend the entire day here," says Nisha Narayanan, director and COO, Red FM.

The desire for variety extends to the way the music is programmed. Rather than splitting the festival across multiple stages by genre, South Side Story brings artistes from disparate musical worlds together on one stage – from folk and experimental music to pop, rap and classical forms.

There is also Spotlight, an initiative that gives emerging talent a chance to perform after being shortlisted by the South Side Story jury. "We invite artists who may not have had the opportunity to perform on a platform of this scale. It is important for us to create a space for newer voices and give audiences a chance to discover them," says Nisha.

Cultural exchange (Above) Raghu Dixit; (below) the audience at the previous edition of South Side Story. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

And perhaps that is why the festival's audience extends beyond the South Indian community. According to Nisha, around 30-35% of its Delhi audience comprises people from the North who come to experience the music, food and culture of the South. In a city where almost everyone has arrived from somewhere else, perhaps the appeal is less about discovering an unfamiliar culture and more about recognising how easily one culture can make room for another.

South Side Story will be hosted at KD Jadhav Indoor Stadium on August 29 and 30. For tickets log on to southsidestory.in

Don't be a drag

With Kitty Su Beauty, three matte liquid lipsticks, two glosses, and a philosophy borrowed from drag come together

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Launched by The LaLiT in 2011, Kitty Su is India's pioneering queer-affirming nightlife brand, bringing together music, drag, performance and unapologetic self-expression. For 15 years, it has been at the centre of India's drag, queer nightlife and performance culture, so makeup has always been more than makeup here.

To mark Kitty Su's 15th anniversary, media personality Rakhi Sawant launched Kitty Su Beauty, billed as India's first queer-led beauty brand, at The LaLiT New Delhi. Hosted by founders Keshav Suri and Cyril Feuillebois, the evening brought together beauty, drag, nightlife and queer culture.

The collection itself is small and deliberately so: three weightless matte liquid lipsticks and two treatment glosses, designed to survive stage lights and long nights without feeling like you have applied industrial paint to your face. Lipsticks start at ₹399 for minis and ₹1,950–₹2,490 for full sizes; glosses are ₹1,950.

"We didn't want to make a beauty brand because nightlife brands are supposed to have one. We wanted to make it because Kitty Su already had a beauty language of its own," says Keshav Suri, executive director, The LaLiT Suri Hospitality Group. For Keshav, that language begins with a simple distinction.

"Enhancement assumes there is something about you that needs fixing. Expression begins from a completely different place: there is nothing wrong with you."

Lip service (Left) The Kitty Su Beauty collection; (inset) Keshav Suri with Rakhi Sawant at the launch in Delhi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

That thinking also explains why the brand comes from queer nightlife and drag rather than the familiar celebrity-beauty playbook. "Queer nightlife has been experimenting with identity, beauty and transformation long before the beauty industry decided to call it innovation," Keshav says. "We didn't want to borrow that culture as an aesthetic. We wanted to build from the people and the spaces that actually created it."

Hash Brownie, the Delhi-based drag queen, performer and makeup artist who worked on the collection, puts it more simply: "Drag taught me that makeup is a language." It is not necessarily about making someone prettier. It can create a character, alter proportions, communicate a mood or deliberately contradict what people expect to see. Drag performers, she points out, also have to make products work, often improvising, layering and ignoring the instructions entirely.

That irreverence shaped the collection's colour story. Hash wanted the shades to have a strong identity without becoming restrictive. "A product should give you a starting point, not a set of rules." The three lipstick shades – Hotline, Tantric and Blackmail – are designed to be more versatile than their names suggest. Hotline can be an unapologetic red lip, a blush or a face pigment; Tantric brings earthy depth and warmth; while Blackmail can go graphic and editorial. The same three shades, Hash says, should be able to look completely different on three different people.

Wear with pride

Cyril Feuillebois, founder, Kitty Su Beauty, which has been in the works for around three years, approached the formulas with a similar idea: performance should not mean punishment. "Performance should come from the product, not from having to fight with it," he says. The brief was to create colour with presence and staying power without making it heavy or uncomfortable, particularly for makeup designed to withstand movement, heat, lights and long nights.

For Hash, the larger idea extends well beyond drag. "You don't need a stage, a wig or a drag name to experiment with who you want to be." Makeup can be subtle one day and excessive the next; it can reveal something or invent an entirely new version of you. "Sometimes, the most empowering thing makeup can give you is simply the freedom to decide what you want to look like."

After 15 years of building a nightlife institution around freedom, performance and self-expression, Kitty Su is now taking the same philosophy into beauty. Really, it was already wearing the lipstick. It has just finally put it in a tube.

Kitty Su Beauty will be available at kittysubeauty.com and Amazon.

Danger from above

Natural outbursts in hilly terrain are rising amid climate change

Disaster struck Nepal on Wednesday after a flash flood ravaged the Himalayas and foothills. As of Thursday, at least 359 people including several foreign tourists, had died, while at least 300 Indians remained missing. Satellite imagery analysed by global agencies, including the Indian Space Research Organisation, points to a glacier collapse or ice-rock avalanche in Tibet, possibly followed by a temporary river blockage and its sudden failure. An earthquake was initially suspected, but evidence has not borne it out. While the immediate flood wave has passed, there are warnings of possible secondary flooding from debris blockages upstream. There has been extensive damage along the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli corridors, with settlements washed away and hydropower and monitoring infrastructure damaged. Nepalese authorities said 35 motorable and 45 suspension bridges and about 40 kilometres of roads had been damaged.

Given that it is the monsoon, north India and the larger Himalayan regions are under the influence of a powerful Western Disturbance. It would thus not have been unreasonable to attribute the floods to these extratropical storms that can cause clouds to collide with mountains and release enormous quantities of rain at short notice. But the ubiquity of satellites is helping establish a more complex picture, pointing to collapsing glaciers and recalling the October 2023 South Lhonak Lake disaster in Sikkim. There, an eponymous Himalayan glacier suddenly gave way, releasing millions of tonnes of water, debris and rock that pulverised Sikkim's largest hydropower project. Subsequent analysis showed that the resulting Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF) had been years in the making. The Indian Himalayas have nearly 7,500 glacial lakes and about 15,000 glaciers, some monitored through remote sensing. Yet, fully assessing their condition requires site visits, difficult because these lakes lie in inhospitable terrain while expeditions are generally feasible only from July to September. Even with satellite monitoring, accurately forecasting a glacier collapse remains exceedingly difficult – and can be counterproductive if warnings trigger panic among residents who, often because of habit or lack of alternatives, are unlikely to move out of harm's way. Dams and hydropower projects in such terrain are often among the first casualties of these natural outbursts, which are increasing amid global warming. Beyond relief and rescue, governments must enforce construction codes, discourage settlements and large projects in known vulnerable zones, and invest in better tracking of glacier health. Such monitoring can feed long-term disaster planning into development programmes. A tragedy is frequently not the result of a conspiracy but the product of passive neglect; the latter can be addressed.

New-age fires

Fire accidents in ICUs need better and more evacuation facilities

Not too long ago, India's fire accidents typically occurred in industrial facilities, large offices, mass gatherings, firecracker units and railway compartments, caused by faulty machinery, weak safety procedures and careless use of flammable materials. While these risks persist, what has got added to the country's poor record in fire safety in the last 15 years or so is residential buildings, hotels and hospitals, especially Intensive Care Units (ICU). Electrical fires now seem predominant, often caused by increased appliance use, overloaded electrical systems and poor maintenance. ICUs are especially vulnerable with their oxygen-rich environments. This month, back-to-back accidents at neonatal ICUs in Amravati, Maharashtra, and Chhindwara, Madhya Pradesh, claimed the most vulnerable: newborn babies. The Amravati fire was put out in 30 minutes, but the smoke was too much for the three babies admitted because of complications. A faulty ventilator is suspected to be the cause. In the NICU at Chhindwara District Hospital, a short circuit in a warmer triggered a fire and three babies, just days old, suffered burns. Over the past 15 years, ICU fires, including the one in Jhansi in 2024, in which 18 newborns died, have not served as a wake-up call. The Amravati fire shared many features with previous incidents.

Perhaps the best way to respond to these new-age fires would be to treat ICU accidents as a distinct category. ICUs are sealed compartments where smoke fills up very quickly. In an NICU, where patients cannot self-evacuate, evacuation drills are essential. A best-case setup would have three independent exits, with at least two allowing horizontal evacuation, automatic sprinklers, independent power lines for large equipment, oxygen cylinder bed supports, and fire drills every two years. A well-designed ICU also locates oxygen outlets away from sockets. Following a Delhi NICU fire, the National Neonatology Forum called for mandatory fire safety certification for NICU-equipped hospitals, regular power audits, analogue addressable alarms, and an evacuation protocol – now RACE or Rescue, Alarm, Confine, Extinguish/Evacuate. The 2026 National Guidelines on Fire and Life Safety in Healthcare Facilities can be a useful starting point for ICU-NICU safety. Beyond all this lies an issue in power quality: electrical harmonics. NICU equipment is packed with electronic components that draw distorted current, which can silently overheat neutral wiring, transformers, and loose connections without tripping a breaker. Post-fire reports citing generic "short circuits" or "technical faults" may well be missing this harmonic-driven degradation, a largely unaudited risk factor.

Why 543 should remain 543

S.Y. Quraishi

Former Chief Election Commissioner of India and the author of 'An Undocumented Wonder – The Making of the Great Indian Election'

Days after both Houses of Parliament were adjourned *sine die* on August 13, 2026, the monsoon session has yet to be formally prorogued. The delay has prompted speculation that Parliament could be reconvened for another attempt at the constitutional amendment linked to delimitation and women's reservation. Whether or not that happens, it gives urgency to a question Parliament must confront: must delimitation necessarily mean an enlargement of the Lok Sabha?

Numbers alone cannot decide

At first glance, the issue looks like arithmetic. India's population has grown enormously since Lok Sabha seats were frozen half a century ago, so it seems natural to argue that representation must now expand correspondingly. But, constitutional design is not arithmetic alone.

Article 81 requires representation broadly to correspond to population, "so far as practicable", while Article 82 provides for readjustment after every Census. Yet, Parliament has twice modified the mechanical application of this principle when another compelling national objective was at stake. In 1976, through the 42nd Constitutional Amendment, the inter-State allocation of seats was frozen on the basis of the 1971 Census so that States successful in family planning were not politically penalised for reducing population growth. The freeze was later extended by the 84th Amendment until the publication of figures from the first Census conducted after 2026. Parliament thus recognised that population matters, but it is not the only constitutional value at stake.

The government has reportedly suggested increasing every State's representation by roughly 50%, arguing that this would leave each with the same 'proportion' of Lok Sabha seats that it has today. On the face of it, that appears to answer the fear of the southern States of losing their relative position. But 'proportion' tells only half the story.

Suppose Uttar Pradesh rises from 80 seats to 120, while Tamil Nadu rises from 39 to about 59. Their proportional relationship remains unchanged. Yet, the absolute gap in voting strength rises from 41 Members of Parliament (MP) to around 61. Parliament does not vote in proportions; it votes in absolute numbers. Governments are formed by numbers, and confidence motions, legislation, and constitutional amendments are decided by numbers. A 50% pro-rata increase may preserve the ratio while widening the numerical gap.

The 1976 freeze therefore embodied a federal compact: States that succeeded in population stabilisation would not see their political voice diminished for doing what national policy encouraged. That understanding should not now be thoughtlessly discarded.

There is also a misconception that delimitation and enlargement are inseparable. They are not. India has already shown that constituency boundaries can be redrawn without changing the number of seats allocated to each State. The delimitation after the 2001 Census reorganised constituencies within States while maintaining the existing inter-State allocation.

> Delimitation, federal fairness and women's representation can all be achieved without enlarging the Lok Sabha

That principle can be adopted again. The 2027 Census can provide the basis for redrawing constituencies within each State so that populations are more evenly distributed. Boundaries can reflect demographic movement and urbanisation. None of this requires increasing the Lok Sabha beyond 543 or disturbing the present federal balance.

A continuously expanding legislature is also not an inevitable consequence of population growth. The United States House of Representatives has remained at 435 voting members (there were some temporary exceptions) for more than a century despite enormous population growth. Switzerland's National Council has remained at 200 members since 1963. Going a step further, Hungary reduced its Parliament from 386 members to 199, while Italy reduced its Chamber of Deputies from 630 to 400. There is no democratic law requiring legislatures to grow whenever population grows.

Bigger House, weaker deliberation

There is another serious concern: what a larger House does to Parliament's own functioning. Parliamentary time does not expand with the number of MPs. Even with 543 members, many MPs hardly get opportunities to speak, ask questions or raise matters of public importance. A Lok Sabha enlarged by 50%, to more than 800 members, would reduce those opportunities further. It may increase representation numerically while weakening the quality of deliberation, one of Parliament's most important functions. Indian MPs already represent the largest average constituencies among the world's major democracies – several times the size of a U.S. congressional district or a U.K. constituency. Freezing the House at 543 while the population keeps growing means that burden only increases after delimitation, and the case for more representatives to improve accessibility is a real one. But it does not follow that the additional representatives must sit in Parliament. Most citizens approach elected representatives over roads, schools, hospitals, local services and State administration - matters substantially within the State sphere. If population growth has made constituencies unwieldy, strengthening representation at the State level is, therefore, a more sensible solution. More MLAs and smaller Assembly constituencies can bring representatives closer to citizens without continuously enlarging the national legislature.

That expansion faces none of the federal-arithmetic constraint that makes Lok Sabha expansion fraught. A larger Assembly shifts no balance between States – each answers only to its own population. Vidhan Sabhas can therefore grow to meet accessibility needs without disturbing the inter-State balance in Parliament that the 1976 freeze was designed to protect. Then comes women's reservation. One-third reservation for women is now being connected with delimitation, and enlargement of the Lok Sabha is presented partly as a way of accommodating women without disturbing existing political interests.

But women's representation should not become a constitutional justification for enlarging the House. One-third of the present Lok Sabha is approximately 181 seats. Women can receive their constitutionally promised representation within the existing House of 543. The purpose of reservation is to alter who occupies parliamentary seats, not necessarily to create hundreds of additional ones.

A 50% expansion could produce a curious result: the number of women MPs would rise, which is desirable, but so would the numerical dominance of the already larger States. A reform intended to correct one representational imbalance could deepen another. Women's representation and federal fairness are both legitimate constitutional objectives. India need not choose between them.

Preserve 543, undertake reforms

The solution is simple: retain the Lok Sabha at 543; preserve the present inter-State distribution of seats; undertake delimitation within States on updated population figures; implement women's reservation within that structure; and expand the Vidhan Sabhas to absorb the accessibility pressure that population growth has created.

For half a century, States have pursued demographic policies knowing that successful population stabilisation would not reduce their parliamentary influence. Southern States in particular invested heavily in education, health care and family welfare and achieved fertility levels that national policy itself encouraged. To reward that success with a larger political advantage for States where population grew faster would invert the incentive the Union deliberately created.

The question, therefore, is not whether population should matter. Of course it should. The question is whether it should now mechanically rearrange the federal political balance that India consciously preserved for five decades. Twice before, Parliament amended the constitutional framework to preserve the existing inter-State allocation despite population changes. There is no reason it cannot do so a third time. The uncertainty over whether Parliament may be recalled makes this more than an academic debate. Decisions taken now could shape the federal balance of the Republic for decades.

Delimitation is necessary. Women's representation is overdue. Updated constituency boundaries are desirable. But none of these objectives requires an 800-plus-member Lok Sabha.

Sometimes constitutional wisdom lies not in making institutions larger, but in preserving the balance that has allowed them to endure; 543 has served India for more than half a century. There is a strong constitutional, federal and democratic case for letting this number remain 543.

India's return to its Central Asian neighbourhood

Pankaj Saran

Former Deputy National Security Adviser, Ambassador and Convenor, NatStrat

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to travel to Central Asia in the next few days, the first port of call being a state visit to Uzbekistan, followed by participation in the meeting of Heads of State of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) in the Kyrgyz capital, Bishkek, called Frunze in Soviet times. The change of names is not just symbolic. It represents the birth of a new region.

Central Asia is an evocative moniker. The region lies landlocked, situated between two giants, Russia and China. In most of its countries, the post 1991 generation has largely taken over, engaged in finding a new internal equilibrium. Islam is the main religion, but does not define identity and is therefore not a political project. The fight against radicalisation and terrorism is uncompromising. Occasional catastrophes such as the devastating Crocus City Hall terror attack in Moscow in 2024, China's constant fear of spread of radicalisation in the border regions and export of instability and extremist ideology from Afghanistan are everyday reminders of the challenges.

In Central Asia, there are a multitude of ethnicities, languages, geographies and resource endowments. These influence domestic and foreign policy choices, with Turkmenistan practising rigorous neutrality. Relations among countries are complicated by legacy disputes over borders, water resources and overlapping ethnicities. Türkiye and Iran are dominant influences, while the United States and the European Union are working their way in as Russia's hold weakens and China's grows.

Mr. Modi's 2015 visit to all five Central Asian countries was historic. It marked the end of an unstated Indian policy of deferring to Russia in its periphery – politely keeping away. In 2017, India was welcomed into the SCO as a full member by Russia, as Pakistan was, by China. To mark the 30 years of their independence/diplomatic ties, India made an unprecedented gesture of inviting all Central Asian leaders as chief guests for the Republic Day in 2022. The COVID-19 pandemic forced the event to be held only virtually, but not without it leading to the creation of high-level mechanisms for cooperation, including the India-Central Asia Dialogue.

> The Prime Minister's visit is an opportunity for India to deepen its strategic presence, expand economic ties and strengthen its diplomatic influence

Beyond geography

If South Asia and West Asia, not to speak of East Asia and the Indian Ocean Region are India's neighbourhoods, Central Asia is no less. A lack of overland connectivity does not take away from the civilisational links India has with the region – in culture, religion, language and architecture. Geographically, India and Tajikistan are separated only by the narrow Wakhan corridor that lies in Afghanistan. India is part of the continuum that is the Eurasian landmass.

Pakistan, a historically new piece in the equation, seeks to usurp the historical lineage based on religious affinity. Its tactic to cut India off, physically and otherwise, from these historical connections, like its other India-centric gambits, is, as anecdotal evidence shows, doomed to failure. Yet, India must not allow this to succeed. Countries of the region are today looking beyond Russia and China for partners in their socio-economic development. India's lived experience as a plural, moderate and democratic society is admired not feared in the region.

It is against this background that Mr. Modi's decision to go back to the region must be welcomed. India should build upon the foundations to consolidate its rightful place in the region, whether in the economic, trade, defence, natural resources, technology spheres or in softer areas such as cultural, educational, health and tourism exchanges. The choice of a state visit to Uzbekistan is consistent with the steady improvement of relations under President Mirziyoyev since 2016. It is among the most dynamic countries of the region, and most forward in the diversification of its foreign policy. Any Indian visitor to Tashkent, Samarkand or Bukhara will vouch for the empathy and resonance between the two peoples.

There are also hardnosed reasons – Uzbekistan has been uncompromising in its fight against terrorism and extremism. Its intimate knowledge of Afghanistan, and pragmatic approach towards the Taliban, are of key importance to India. India has had detailed discussions with it on alternative rail and road connectivity routes through Iran and Afghanistan which need to be revisited in the light of recent developments in these countries.

India and the SCO

Starting from the small beginnings of the "Shanghai Five" in 1996, the SCO, in its 25th anniversary, has grown to 10 members, 15 dialogue partners and two observers. With the exception of 2024, Mr. Modi has been a regular participant in SCO Heads of States meetings. India's SCO engagement is driven by geography, not ideology. Within the SCO chambers, negotiating against a China-Pakistan dyad is demanding but essential. India has kept its head above the swamp by suggesting several ideas to enhance cooperation in the economic, technological and civilisational fields. In Tianjin last year, Mr. Modi put forward the vision of security, connectivity, and opportunity for the SCO. In the instant case, for a country as overwhelmingly dependent on China as Kyrgyzstan, the SCO, and India in particular, offers a valuable geopolitical lifeline.

Taken together with his visits to the Indian Ocean Region last month, Mr. Modi would have traversed far-flung corners of India's maritime and continental neighbourhood in quick succession reflecting India's geostrategic imperatives and opportunities.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A Himalayan disaster

Two major factors behind the Nepal disaster are its mountainous terrain and the intensity of the cloudburst or the melting of glaciers in the higher Himalayan ranges. The steep slopes would have allowed gushing water to reach the plains quickly; they can also become death traps for those caught in sudden downstream flows. While the media is still trying to assess the toll, it is certain to run into the thousands. This particular disaster is unprecedented in the scale of its destruction, with hundreds of villages and small towns wiped out. It is truly heartbreaking.

V. Lakshmanan,
Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Post-disaster relief is no longer enough. It is most essential that Himalayan nations must collaborate on joint early-warning networks, real-time data sharing, and resilient infrastructure.

Kshirasagara Balaji Rao,
Hyderabad

Revive cultural institution

Tamil Nadu's apex cultural body, the Eyal Isai Nataka Mandram, is inactive, while the Kalaimamani State awards remain suspended. The TVK government should revive the institution, reconstitute its executive/general councils, and reform the awards process by separating classical arts from cinema.

V.P. Dhananjayan,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Is English a foreign language in India?

Apoorvanand

Professor in the Hindi department of the University of Delhi

Ganesh Devy

Former professor of English and the man behind the People's Linguistic Survey of India project

PARLEY

The Supreme Court has been discussing linguistics this month while hearing challenges to the CBSE's three-language formula, which mandates that two of the three languages must be native Indian languages, a category that does not include English. The top court had wondered whether it was correct to treat English as a "non-indigenous" language, given its long history in the country, and its role as a link language in governance and higher education. So should English be considered a foreign language in India? Apoorvanand and Ganesh Devy discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Priscilla Jebaraj**.

Is English a foreign language in India?

Apoorvanand: No. It came from outside the geography that we define as India now. But it has been Indianised. We cannot now say that English is foreign to the soil because it's being used in different forms and for different purposes by people across India.

Ganesh Devy: Hindi and English are born of the same Indo-European language family. One part of that family came to us 3,500 years ago; that was Sanskrit and one of the descendants of Sanskrit is Hindi. Another part came through Europe 400 years ago, in the 17th century. So, they both belong to the same root language, and both of them have come to us at different times.

In fact, the only major indigenous language in India is Tamil as it does not come from outside. But for that reason, we cannot impose Tamil on all students. Similarly, we cannot impose English or Hindi. So in India, the language question cannot simply be seen in terms of which is foreign, which is indigenous.

The history of English in India includes both imperialism and the freedom movement, Macaulay and Gandhi. How has this complicated the issue?

GD: Macaulay's minute is relatively recent, dated 1835; the East India Company had started using English in India almost 230 years before that. The interaction between English and other languages started in the 17th century and intensified during the 18th century. In the 19th century, the English governors in Calcutta, Bombay, and Madras insisted on teaching children in native languages, that is, the regional languages. Elphinstone very clearly gave written instructions to teach children in Gujarati and Marathi in the Bombay presidency. But by 1835, the East India Company was thinking of how to bring in legislation to replace Persian, which had been kind of a national language connecting India for several centuries, and that is when Macaulay came in.

AP: English came as a language of traders and missionaries and gradually became the language of the administration and the state, but then it also became the language of education. We see an elite being formed through English and also the formation of nationalism or nationalist ideas through English. So that's a very complex journey. We cannot treat English as a simple imposition on Indians. Indians adopted it, domesticated it, and then used it against those who had colonised India. Then, it became a language of liberation for many communities who did not have access to education or knowledge for generations.

A semi-open class in a school in New Delhi on January 24. R.V. MOORTHY

English has become the language of aspiration and status. How does that impact social and political dynamics?

GD: The creation of an English-speaking elite has to be seen in the historical context of an earlier experience, where Sanskrit had formed an elite which brought in the *varna* system. The English language created an elite in India who tried to change that system and make India a modern society. Moreover, in India, in order to get a good job one often needs to migrate outside one's State. And as soon as migration is involved, the need for English is enhanced.

AP: English is connected with social mobility as well as geographical mobility. No other language gives you this advantage.

According to the 2011 Census, 10% of the Indian population speak English, and the numbers are only increasing. Has this resulted in the suppression of other Indian languages or has it spread multilingualism?

AP: It would be very simplistic to make a direct cause and effect relationship, because multi-linguality is a feature of India and there are different reasons for which people use different languages at different levels. In my Delhi classroom, the students are largely from the so-called Hindi belt. But for most of them, their home or street language is actually Bhojpuri or Braj or Avadhi or Maithili. So there are many languages which live side-by-side, performing different functions.

> We cannot treat English as a simple imposition on Indians. Indians adopted it, domesticated it, and then used it against those who had colonised India. It became a language of liberation for many communities
> **APOORVANAND**

Being a teacher of Hindi, I regret that Hindi is in fact erasing many languages, which had a very rich tradition and which are living languages such as Maithali or Braj or Avadhi or Dondari or even Adivasi languages, because the state is not investing in them. They have now become oral languages, pushed to the margins, while all attention goes to Hindi. It's Hindi imperialism in Hindi areas; Hindi is a coloniser.

What is the impact of the rise of English as well as Hindi on other languages?

GD: First, let me say that the Census of India is not at all a clear mirror as far as language is concerned. For example, if a language is spoken by less than 10,000 persons, the Census says it is not a language. Then, if you look at how many individuals are studying in universities in India, the total figure at any given time in the last 10 years would be about four crore. Each one of them know English as a second language because English is the language of higher education, and yet the Census does not reflect those figures.

Hindi has been gulping other languages. In the Census itself, some 56 other languages are included as subsets of Hindi. There is a language called Pawri which is spoken by the Pawra Adivasi community, on the border of Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh, who do not understand Hindi at all. Yet that is shown as a subset of Hindi. It is the same with Tamil, Kannada and Marathi. All smaller languages are being shown as subsets of larger languages and that comes from the state's desire to have some kind of linguistic unity.

India is made of many languages and that is the fundamental truth. Just last week, in Maharashtra, rickshaw drivers and taxi drivers were on strike because there is a compulsion that they have to pass an examination in Marathi, based on grammar. Why would a taxi driver need Marathi grammar? He has functional Marathi. Indians speak a lot of functional languages. They speak English, not as the British do, but as a functional language. They speak Hindi all over India as a functional language. And I think we should never forsake the beauty of having multiple functional languages in our pocket, in our hearts, and in our brains.

But there is also a vested interest in English in India from English language publishers and English medium schools. They bat for the continuance of English partly out of commercial interest. I don't agree with that.

AP: On the CBSE and their stress on a three-language formula, and the insistence of policymakers that they want children to learn the mother tongue – all this is farcical because people know that all these policymakers are sending their own children to English medium schools and that English is social capital, cultural capital, and capital in real terms.

There's also a significant amount of Indian literature written in English today, including works in translation. And of course, films and the Internet freely mix languages. How does that change the debate?

GD: In the 6th, 7th, and 8th centuries, many Indians produced books in Sanskrit. Then, in the 15th and 16th centuries, India was producing more books in Persian. Today, India is producing more books in English than they produce in England. But our desi languages have still survived.

So the production of books, movies, and songs in a certain language is not necessarily an indication of a profound fundamental cultural shift. There are just two small questions to be asked to anybody who is writing English fiction or non-fiction. The first is, when that person goes into any spiritual space, is their prayer also in English? The second question is, is the audience only Indian or is it a global audience? The answers to these two questions will reveal the exact significance of the shift.

By the way, the English came here and had an impact on many things. But Indian music remains Indian music. We have internalised but not replaced. So, our cultural reception of English culture has been calibrated, granular, and is not wholesale as in Australia, U.S. or in Canada where native cultures were wiped out.

AP: I would disagree with that. For example, in my daughter's generation or the generation after, their first love in music is through English and not "Indian music". I don't see any problem in that and I don't see them as culturally uprooted. Would we say that this young generation or those bands which sing only in English are not culturally Indian? It's a very complex concept and the whole anxiety about maintaining nativity and creating a difference between what is indigenous and what is foreign is also problematic. Therefore, I would like to argue that English has made India its home. Those who want to declare that it's a foreign language, in fact, want to hide the fact that Hindi colonises other languages and so do Tamil and other languages, when you create these as meta languages and others as sub languages.

To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Rajinikanth, a secret Chennai park, and a Gandhi impersonator

Stories don't always begin with pitches; sometimes, they can emerge from unexpected gates and casual strolls

Srinivasa Ramanujam

The best stories in journalism are not necessarily the ones that begin with a strong pitch, or take hours of research and painstaking reporting; sometimes, they are the ones that a reporter simply discovers along the way.

Recently, I challenged myself to find the place where actor Rajinikanth had shot his first film, *Apoorva Raagangal*, in 1975. Tamil cinema fans will remember the iconic shot of the newcomer pushing open a gate and striding into a house – almost as if announcing his arrival in filmdom.

I was determined to find this gate and the house.

Armed with a few clues from old-timers, I managed to find it at a dead-end street in a quiet Adyar neighbourhood. The gate had changed, but the house was spectacularly intact, almost exactly as it had appeared in the old Tamil film starring Rajinikanth and Kamal Haasan. We spoke to the owners and shot a video in which I mimicked the way Rajinikanth strode in, standing at the exact same place.

Story done, I was ready to head out when I chanced upon a small gate on the opposite side. It looked like the entrance to a park, but seemed deserted. Curious, I walked in, only to discover a walk-through park along the Adyar river. It was one of the most beautiful sights I had seen in Chennai, a city I have lived in for over four decades.

In some strange way, the wooded trail and quiet pathway felt like they belonged to me. Ever since this discovery, I've dragged along all my favourite people to experience it and take a stroll. I wrote about it too, while refusing to divulge the exact location lest it become too crowded.

Another time, a visit to a popular landmark led me to a story I wasn't looking for. On a boring weekend afternoon, after a Sunday nap, my daughter pestered me to take her out. We decided to head to the Marina Beach for some fresh air and to try our hand at balloon shooting. As we strolled towards the sea, something odd caught my attention: a man dressed as Mahatma Gandhi, his body covered in silver paint, standing completely still. He would occasionally wave at children, but otherwise he looked like a statue. He had a box in front of him and even a QR code stuck to his trousers for those who preferred digital payments.

I asked him for his number and he mumbled something in Telugu. Days and many conversations later, with the help of a translator, I wrote about this man from Khammam in Telangana who dresses as Gandhi.

He said with regret that people were forgetting Gandhi and this was his way of reminding them about the father of the nation. This was also one way in which he was saving up for his daughter's wedding.

The same happened in Varanasi, where a casual stroll along Assi Ghat led me to a unique training ground for *gusthi* wrestlers. Before long, another story fell into place: I found that many young boys and girls go to the ground for strength training and learn *gusthi* in order to participate in local tournaments. Varanasi may be known for its spirituality, but physical fitness too is deeply woven into its culture.

One of the cardinal rules of life, and perhaps even more so in journalism, is to be curious, not judgmental. Curiosity is often the starting point for stories that reporters never set out to find.

As a journalist, it's not always about finding a story; sometimes, it's about allowing the story to find you.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Tasting childhood

A sweet treat: Children eating chewy candy, a popular sweet of the city, at the landmark Marina beach in Chennai, which has been celebrating Madras Week, on August 27. R. RAGU

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 28, 1976

Thanjavur teak to be auctioned

Tiruchi, August 27: For the first time teak grown on canal banks in Thanjavur will be put on auction by the Forest Department, Mr. K.A. Bhoja Shetty, Chief Conservator of Forests and Mr. Venkatakrishnan, Conservator of Forests, Tiruchi circle, said here to-day.

The Tamil Nadu Forest Department has proved that teak could be profitably grown on canal banks, they added and paid tributes to Mr. V.S. Krishnaswamy, erstwhile Chief Conservator of Forests, at whose initiative the Department took up teak cultivation on the canal banks of the Cauvery delta in Thanjavur district in 1955-56.

To-day teak has been raised over the entire network of the canal system in Thanjavur district covering an area of 8,000 hectares.

The first auction of the Thanjavur teak will be conducted on September 3 at Saliamangalam before the Conservator of Forests. All along teak came from the western ghats and hereafter at periodical intervals of three or six months, Thanjavur teak would be auctioned.

At the first auction over 2,500 poles would be available for bidding, Mr. Bhoja Shetty said.

Mr. Shetty added that similar teak plantations had been raised throughout the Cauvery baks and Tambarabarani bank belts.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 28, 1926

Indian methods of teaching

A correspondent writes:– Dr. B.B. Dey, Professor of Chemistry, Presidency College, Madras, delivered the inaugural address of the Science Branch, Teachers' College Teachers' Association, Saidapet, on Wednesday, 25th at 5 p.m.

The lecturer pointed out that teaching work had come to be regarded as a very dull and dreary affair; and that the class of teachers were as a whole, considered as a group of very prosaic people.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people at risk in Peru due to El Niño

1.2 million. The El Niño weather phenomenon, which has brought some rain and an unexpected rise in temperatures to Peru, could put more than 1 million people at risk in regions of the country vulnerable to climate change, according to national authorities. "Based on historical data from all the regions... approximately 1.2 million people could be affected," they said. REUTERS

Number of migrants pulled from sea off Mauritania

160 The Mauritanian Coastguard said on Thursday that it had rescued more than 160 migrants, including 17 children, from a boat in trouble off its coast, its second major emergency operation in a week. The migrants were "exhausted by the journey and the insecurity of the vessel" when they were rescued, a Coastguard statement said. AFP

Budget approved by Taiwan lawmakers for locally made drones

7.6 in $ billion. Lawmakers in Taiwan approved a $7.6 billion budget for locally made drones on Thursday as the island democracy seeks to strengthen its defences against a potential Chinese attack. Taiwan has ramped up military spending in recent years and is building up its defence industry to make equipment and ammunition on the island. AFP

Number of Indian coal power plants with critical low fuel

45 Forty five power plants in India are operating with critically low coal inventories, government data showed, as monsoon rains disrupt supplies and electricity demand rises. The plants with coal stocks below 25% of their required inventory or with critically low stocks to generate power for less than three days has risen from 31 at the end of July, the data showed. REUTERS

Ladakh's revised VAT on natural gas to boost clean energy adoption

5 in per cent. Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Thursday announced a significant reduction in value-added tax on natural gas from 21% to 5% to promote affordable clean energy and improve ease of living. He said the move would give a major boost to the Centre's larger plan to roll out the city gas distribution (CGD) network. PTI

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Can India build a strategic fuel system?

India's proposed strategic-fuel programme would expand crude, LNG and LPG storage, but building reserves alone will not guarantee energy security; the system will work only if India can move the fuel through ships, pipelines and distribution networks, while having clear rules on ownership, financing, and replenishment

EXPLAINER

Kalyan Mangalapalli

The story so far:

West Asia-related disruptions have exposed a vulnerability in India's energy-security system. India can import large quantities of crude oil, LNG and LPG, but its ability to store, transport and release these fuels during a prolonged disruption differs sharply by fuel. India already operates underground strategic crude-oil storage and two underground LPG caverns, but has no operating underground natural-gas storage facility.

Against this background, the government is considering a decade-long strategic-fuel programme that would add about 28 MT of crude-oil storage, 9 MT of LNG storage and 4 MT of LPG storage. Reuters reports that the proposed reserves are intended to provide nearly two months of crude and LNG demand and about six weeks of LPG demand. The programme remains under consideration and should therefore be treated as a proposed target, not committed capacity.

How much storage does India have today?

India's position varies considerably by fuel. For crude oil, Phase I of the Strategic Petroleum Reserve provides 5.33 MT of underground capacity, with actual storage of about 3.37 MT, or roughly 63-64% utilisation, across Visakhapatnam, Mangaluru and Padur. A further 6.5 MT has been approved under Phase II at Chandikhol and Padur.

However, execution on the Chandikhol project remains protracted amid ongoing land acquisition requirements and finalisation of commercial PPP frameworks.

LPG has a much smaller underground footprint. The Visakhapatnam and Mangaluru caverns together provide about 0.14 MT of capacity. A proposed 4 MT strategic reserve would therefore represent roughly a 30-fold increase in underground LPG capacity.

Natural gas presents the largest storage gap. India currently has no operational underground gas-storage facility. Its gas-security system instead depends on domestic production, LNG imports, import terminals, commercial inventories and pipelines.

These figures also highlight an important distinction between storage capacity and inventory. A facility has a physical capacity, but the fuel it holds can vary. Not all inventory is necessarily immediately accessible either. During a crisis, the critical measure is therefore not simply how many tonnes can be stored, but how much fuel is available and at what withdrawal rate it can reach consumers.

What does the proposed 9 MT of LNG storage mean?

LNG is particularly prone to confusion because India already has substantial LNG import and regasification infrastructure. A regasification terminal can receive LNG and convert it into natural gas, but its regasification capacity does not constitute strategic inventory.

LNG is stored as a cryogenic liquid at around -162°C, requiring specialised insulated tanks and boil-off gas management. Underground gas storage is different: LNG is first regasified and the resulting natural gas is injected into a depleted reservoir or cavern.

India already operates underground strategic crude-oil storage and two underground LPG caverns, but has no operating underground natural-gas storage facility. GETTY IMAGES

The PNGRB-ICF study provides a useful but narrowly defined stress test. Its 2030 scenario examined how much additional LNG infrastructure would be required to supply priority consumers for 20 days under stress conditions. It estimated a requirement of about 0.56-0.6 MT of LNG equivalent, achievable with roughly eight additional LNG tanks. The combined cost of the tanks and the associated strategic inventory was estimated at around $1 billion. This was a scenario-specific estimate, not an assessment of India's overall strategic LNG requirement.

The proposed 9 MT strategic inventory is an order of magnitude larger. Against the ICF projection of roughly 58 MT of annual LNG imports, 9 MT represents about 56 days of imports – hence the description of approximately two months of LNG import cover. It does not mean two months of India's total gas consumption.

The difference is important. A 0.6 MT requirement addresses a 20-day priority-sector stress scenario; 9 MT represents a much broader strategic objective of buffering India against prolonged LNG-import disruption. The associated investment would therefore be substantially larger.

Does all the gas have to be stored as LNG?

No. India could eventually use a portfolio of surface LNG tanks and underground natural-gas storage.

Additional LNG tanks would hold inventory directly at import terminals. A separate proposal from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas would require LNG import terminals to maintain storage capacity 10% above their normal operating requirement, with the additional capacity available to the government during supply or price disruptions.

For longer-duration requirements, depleted oil and gas reservoirs, which account for 74% of global working gas volume, could provide much larger volumes of underground gas storage. Salt caverns offer different advantages: faster injection and withdrawal and the ability to cycle inventory more frequently, potentially making them useful for shorter-duration balancing.

But a depleted field cannot simply become a storage site because production has ended. Reservoir characteristics, cap-rock integrity, pressure behaviour, existing wells, cushion-gas requirements and pipeline connectivity must all be assessed. India's sedimentary basins – including Krishna, Godavari, Cambay, Mumbai Offshore and Rajasthan – offer potential locations, but moving from geological potential to usable storage requires subsurface investigation, site selection, engineering, construction, testing, filling and pipeline integration.

Salt caverns face a similar qualification process. Rajasthan's salt-bearing formations have been investigated for solution-mined caverns, but suitability depends on depth, thickness, purity, geometry, groundwater and mechanical properties.

Can India scale its crude and LPG experience?

Crude is the most mature component. India already operates underground crude caverns and has developed the associated engineering capabilities. The U.S. Strategic Petroleum Reserve illustrates the scale possible with salt caverns, with authorised capacity of 714 million barrels across 60 caverns. But the U.S. system works as an integrated network of caverns, pipelines, marine terminals and refineries. Storage is therefore fundamentally an infrastructure system, not simply an underground space.

LPG is technically proven in India but presents a much larger scaling challenge. A proposed 4 MT reserve would require a substantial network of new caverns or other storage facilities, together with import terminals, pipelines, pumping systems and bottling infrastructure.

The Mangaluru cavern illustrates the complexity. Underground construction requires geological and hydrogeological investigation, rock-mechanics analysis and groundwater management, particularly where work takes place alongside operating surface facilities. Scaling the system would require sustained capabilities in geophysics, geomechanics, tunnelling, reservoir engineering and project execution.

What happens if the fuel cannot reach India?

Because energy security relies heavily on maritime logistics, including vulnerable chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz and long-distance routes from the U.S., India is proactively diversifying both its import sources and shipping capabilities. To reduce reliance on foreign vessels, State-run oil refiners and the Shipping Corporation of India plan to invest $1.5 to $2 billion in a joint venture to acquire 59 ships. Simultaneously, Indian Oil is expanding sourcing through new 2027 agreements with Algeria and increased U.S. purchases, while exploring direct stakes in Very Large Gas Carriers to secure greater control over its supply chain.

What about pipelines?

Pipelines provide the final link between imported or stored fuel and inland consumers. PNGRB has recently authorised approximately 1,800 km of new LPG pipelines across six States, involving investment of around $0.7 billion. These pipelines improve connections between supply sources and inland markets and reduce dependence on road movement, but they do not themselves add strategic storage. Their value lies in improving deliverability.

The same principle applies to natural gas. Underground storage is useful only if it can inject into and withdraw from the gas grid at the required rate. LNG tanks are useful only when regasification and downstream pipelines can move the gas. LPG caverns require connections to bottling and distribution systems.

Who pays for the strategic reserves?

The reported $42 billion programme, which has yet to be confirmed by the government, combines infrastructure CAPEX with the cost of purchasing and maintaining strategic fuel inventories. Reuters reported that more than half could go towards storage infrastructure, with the balance used to purchase and fill the reserves. Financing would be a challenge and the government shot down reports that a cess would be charged to pay for the reserves.

The financial obligation does not end with construction. Billions of dollars of fuel would need to be purchased, financed and maintained. Stocks released during a crisis would then have to be replenished, potentially when commodity and freight prices are higher. The policy therefore needs to establish who owns and finances the inventory, minimum stock obligations, emergency-release authority, and who bears replenishment and price risk. A commercial-cum-strategic model could reduce the public burden, provided commercially used capacity remains available during emergencies.

Is storage enough to make India energy-secure?

Building 41 MT of combined storage is only part of the equation. A strategic reserve is effective only if India can seamlessly access fuel, transport it inland, and replenish stocks after a release.

Ultimately, energy security relies on an integrated framework: reserves buy time, shipping brings the next cargo, pipelines deliver fuel inland, and governance dictates emergency execution. The ultimate test of India's strategic fuel programme will be its ability to coordinate all these elements simultaneously when a crisis hits.

(The author is an Energy and Emerging Technologies expert)

THE GIST

- India's existing strategic storage differs sharply by fuel, with crude having the most developed system, LPG a limited underground footprint and natural gas no operational underground storage facility.
- The proposed 28 MT of crude, 9 MT of LNG and 4 MT of LPG reserves would represent a major expansion, but the LNG requirement should not be confused with existing regasification capacity or narrower 20-day stress scenarios.
- Geological suitability, infrastructure and project execution will determine how quickly storage can scale, while shipping and pipelines remain critical to ensuring fuel reaches consumers during prolonged disruptions.

IN THE LIMELIGHT

Gulzar at 92: the remarkable art of staying relevant without ever standing still

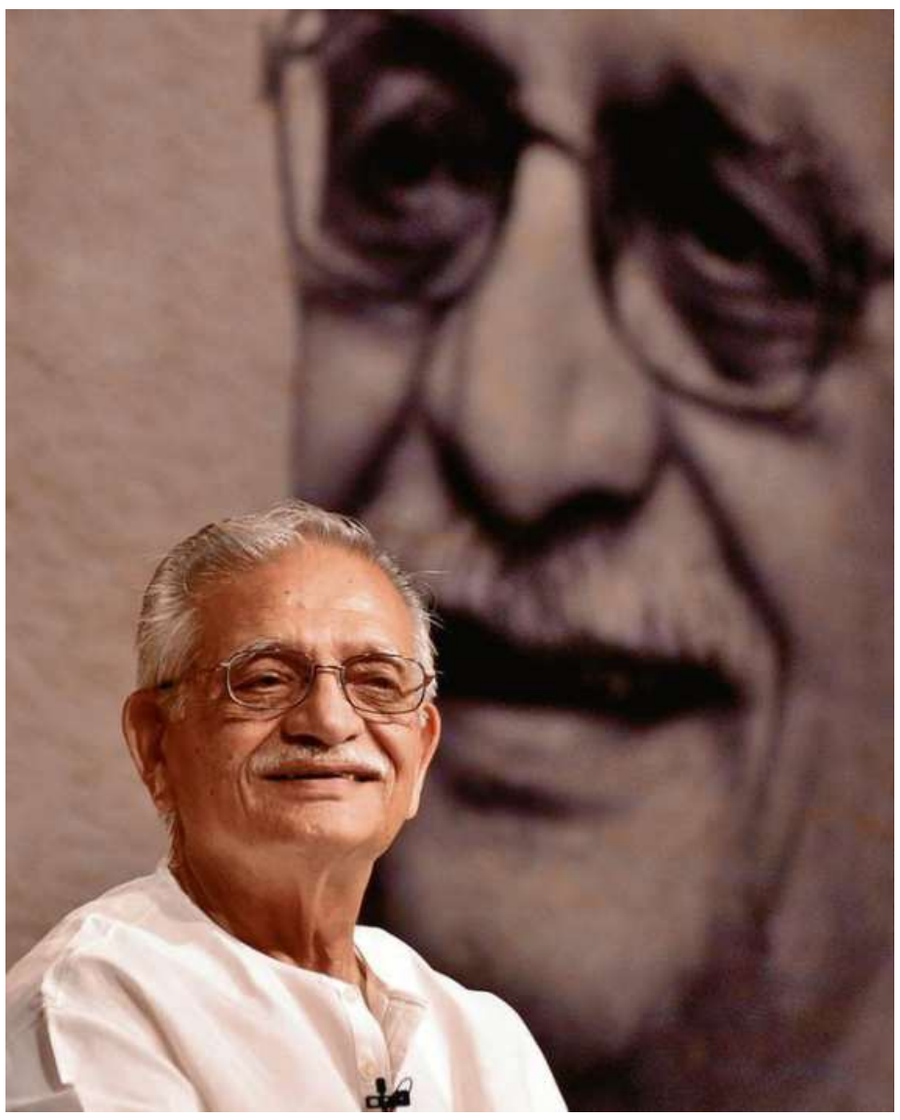
Gulzar's career across poetry, lyrics, cinema, television, translation and children's writing has been marked by an unmistakable voice, reinvention and an incorruptible curiosity; his work has reached generations through its emotional heft and rare ability to distil the mundane into exquisite poetry

Kalyan Sundareswaran

A river runs for centuries and yet belies the idea of permanence. It flows away as it flows in, can both flood and run dry, take in tributaries, change course and annex newer territories. A long creative career carries a similar paradox. While retaining an essential recognisable voice, it must continually acquire new vocabularies. For over seventy years, Picasso painted and sculpted with evolving brilliance not merely surviving shifting artistic movements but actually spearheading most of them.

And there is not a more compelling Indian parallel to this than Gulzar. Rarely has someone spent decade after decade at the very summit of multiple demanding public crafts, without a prominent phase of decline and without the grandiosity that often accompanies greatness. An influential Urdu poet, a lyricist, a film and television director, author, screenwriter, children's writer, translator, Gulzar has looked into this world through every possible lens and the world too has looked back gratefully, bestowing on him some of the highest national and international honours, from the Dadasaheb Phalke Award to the Jnanpith Award, and from the Oscar to the Grammy. To tweak one of his own lines he wrote for the film '*Anand*' (1971), his career has not just been extensive but expansive too (*Zindagi badi honi chahiye, lambi nahi*).

Gulzar came to film songwriting at a time when the lyricists' fraternity was a formidable roll-call of masters such as Shailendra, Sahir Ludhianvi, Shakeel Badayuni, Rajendra Krishan amongst others. Gulzar wrote his first film song for Bimal Roy's '*Bandini*' – *Mora Gora Ang Laile* set in Vaishnava verse. And right away, he had found his niche as a lyricist in a roomful of titans.


Gulzar. FILE PHOTO

A voice of his own

Though bound by the strict film song conventions of metre, rhyming, musicality, situations and the need to fit lyrics into a pre-composed tune, Gulzar has always commanded a singular, unmistakable idiom. While this signature is instantly perceptible, it defies easy definition. The style is a curious blend of abstraction (*Is mod se jaate hain* from '*Aandhi*'), symbolism (*Wo Yaar hai Jo Khushboo Ki Tarah, Jiski Zubaan Urdu Ki Tarah* from '*Dil Se*'), poetic flourish (*Do Nainon Mein Aansoo Bhare Hain, Nindiya Kaise Samaye* from '*Khushboo*'), paronomasia (*Sare ke Sare gama Ko Lekar Gaate Chale* from '*Parichay*'), political messaging (*Haal Chaal Thik Thaak Hain* from '*Mere Apne*'), allusion to nature (*Hawaaon Pe Likh Do* from '*Do Dooni Chaar*'), vivid imagery (*Chhote Chhote sheheron* from '*Bunty Aur Babli*'), dark humour (*Goli Maar Bheje Mein* from '*Satya*'), arcane vocabulary (*Aab-o-dana dhoondhte hain ek aashiyaana dhoondte hain* from '*Gharonda*'), a rich worldview (*Aane Wala Pal* from '*Golmaal*'), and above all, an emotional heft (*Humne Dekhi hai In Aankhon Ki Mehekti Khushboo* from '*Khamoshi*') that can entirely ambush a listener mid-song.

Critics may argue that such sophistication is at odds with a "film" song, a form expected to resonate with the masses without demanding much of interpretive labour. And yet Gulzar has repeatedly proven otherwise. Many of his songs have captured popular imagination like none other, such as *Humko Mann Ki Shakti Dena* from '*Guddi*', a regulation prayer song in schools even today, or *Beedi Jalaile* from '*Omkara*' oozing a rustic exuberance or the infectiously playful *Kajra Re* from '*Bunty Aur Babli*'. Despite his uncommon idiom, his songs have found universal acceptance, aided by composers such as R.D. Burman, A.R. Rahman and Vishal Bhardwaj who have matched their crafts effortlessly to his calibre.

The same intellectual courage defines Gulzar's trajectory as a filmmaker and a screenwriter. Many of Gulzar's films have been adapted from works of literature. As a writer himself, he could easily find a story's emotional register and seamlessly infuse it into cinema with sensitivity to things like language, character, subtext, silence, refrains and motifs. He also made films which were topical, championed progressive values, spoke truth to power, presented nuanced worldviews and asked uncomfortable questions all without ever tipping into preachiness. His debut film '*Mere Apne*' placed disaffected youth at the centre of a story about political disillusionment and loneliness. His '*Aandhi*' was a political drama which gave its female lead enormous agency, where the male lead plays second fiddle to her. His '*Mausam*' delicately handles the misplaced romantic affection a sex worker feels for her own biological father, a narrative choice most directors would have flinched at back then. His '*Maachis*' was a bold and layered exploration of radicalisation set against the Punjab insurgency, probing raw wounds without pointing fingers. He has never been the one to take the easy path, neither in his choice of subjects nor in his treatment of them.

Beyond the world of cinema

As a poet and a prose stylist outside films, Gulzar has been nothing short of prolific. His Partition stories carry the emotional authority of having experienced it first-hand. He has written for children with the same sincerity he reserves for adult readers. His poetry seamlessly moves between the formal architecture of the Urdu *ghazal* and *nazm* and the autonomy of the free verse. He is also the creator of the *Triveni*, a three-line verse akin to an Indian *Haiku* whose third line, with a sleight of mind, entirely alters the emotional meaning of the first two. Translations are a telling part of Gulzar's oeuvre. Apart from translating literary giants such as Tagore and Kusumagraj independently, he has also translated several scores of contemporary poets across all Indian languages, which have been anthologised in his *A Poem a Day*. What emerges from this vast body of work is simply a relentless love not just for the written word but also for the reader and a rare ability to distill the most mundane into exquisite poetry. Gulzar is like the itinerant water-carrier whose vessel continues to pour out to generations of thirsty readers and yet always remains filled to the brim.

Another remarkable aspect of Gulzar is his unmitigated affection and respect for his seniors and peers that runs through his work, somewhat like the moon borrowing the sun's luminosity but making it gentler for the passage. Be it in his biographical sketches or in his long-form interviews or even his adaptations of their lives and works, there is an unfeigned humility and a willingness to let someone else's genius stand taller than his own. He has quoted or paraphrased other poets such as Khusrau, Ghalib and T.S. Eliot in his works, showing how grounded and secure he is in his own craft. His narratives on the likes of his mentor Bimal Roy, his friend R.D. Burman, his seniors Shailendra, Sahir, Faiz and many others are full of tenderness. His television serials *Mirza Ghalib* on the life of the talismanic Urdu poet and *Tehreer Munshi Premchand Ki* too are glorious cases in point.

The Gulzar phenomenon

Yet, his towering stature has ironically birthed a curious modern phenomenon. Having assumed a quasi-mythological status amongst the masses, Gulzar's name is routinely invoked to lend gravity to mediocre verse he never wrote. The Internet is awash with lines misattributed to him to confer credibility and heft to anything vaguely poetic. It is an irony of our times that the more a voice commands our trust, the more it is forced to speak words it never uttered. Though a vigilant community of admirers actively combat this digital misattribution through the hashtag #NotByGulzar, its sheer volume shows how perversely his poetic persona has permeated the public consciousness, more as a brand to be flaunted rather than the painstaking artist he has always been.

In an age of public posturing where dilettantes know just enough to make sparing content for mindless scrollers with decreasing attention spans, where flamboyance is rewarded more than moderation, where the patient romance of Test cricket has lost ground to the titillations of T-20, Gulzar stands as a raging testimony to longevity and restraint. His endurance is less owing to a kind bargain struck with time than to his rigour, his resilience as a man of his craft and his incorruptible curiosity that still propels him to say things and find new ways of saying them.

In one of his own songs from the 80s film '*Hip Hip Hurray*', he writes: *Roz tere jeene ke liye ek subah mujhe mil jaati hai*
Murjhati hai koi shaam agar to raat kahin khil jaati hai
Main roz subah tak aata hoon, aur roz shuru karta hoon safar
Haath badha ae zindagi, aankh milake baat kar
(Everyday to live by you, I find a morning bright
Even as the evening withers, out blooms the night
I get to the morning everyday, and start my daily streak
Give me your hand, life, look me in the eye and speak)

As Gulzar turned 92 this August 18, 2026, what sets him apart is his ability to repeatedly meet life with the alertness of someone encountering it for the first time, look it right in the eye and dare to chronicle its triumphs and sorrows with fidelity and imagination.

(*Kalyan Sundareswaran is an IT professional with Infosys. Views expressed are personal.*)

FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the plural of "staff"? (S. Srinivasan, Madurai)

If you are thinking of people working in an organisation, then the plural is "staff".The word is an uncountable noun. In most universities, for example, we have teaching staff and administrative staff. Like the nouns "jury", "government", etc., the word "staff' can be followed by either a singular or a plural verb. Here are a few examples.

The staff is of the opinion that we should go on strike.

The staff were excellent.

The word is normally not used to refer to a single individual. If you wish to refer to a single person, then you could say "staff member", "staff person", etc. Some people use the word "staffer"; not everyone, however, accepts this word.

What is the difference between 'fairly' and 'rather'? (B. Lakshmi Chandrasekhar, Vijayawada)

"Rather" is the stronger of the two words. When you say that the movie was "rather good ", it implies that it was pretty good; it was much better than you had expected. So in your opinion, people should go and see it; you recommend it. On the other hand, when you say that it was "fairly good", what you are implying is that it was ok. There was nothing great about the film; if the friend wants to, he/she may go and see it, but you wouldn't recommend it.

Similarly, when you tell someone that his English is "fairly good", you are not really complimenting him. All that you are saying is that his English is ok. Here are a few more examples.

Jyothi made a fairly/rather good presentation.

During summer, it gets fairly/rather warm.

What is the origin of the expression "French leave"? (M. Ram Mohan, Narsampet)

This is another example of how much the English hated the French. I guess we shouldn't be talking about this now, considering the fact that the two have joined forces along with the United States to fight the Taliban.

But historically, the two nations couldn't stand each other. Even now, it is not uncommon for an Englishman to refer to a Frenchman as a "frog", because the French consider frog legs a delicacy. The term "French postcards" is used to refer to picture postcards with naked ladies on them. When someone uses foul language, you can hear the person saying, "pardon my French" –thereby implying that the French had the habit of swearing.

When someone goes on "French leave", he or she takes off without informing the authorities. According to the English, it was standard practice in France in the 18th Century to leave a ball or dinner without thanking the host and hostess. People left without even saying goodbye. The English felt that the French were people without manners. But what is interesting is that taking leave of someone in this manner is referred to as "English leave" by the French! What the Americans call "French postcards", the French call "American postcards".

It is interesting to note that countries, which have such a low opinion of one another, have come together to fight terrorism! I guess they don't mind the war of words.

Published in The Hindu on October 16, 2001

Word of the day

Impetuous: characterised by undue haste and lack of thought or deliberation

Synonyms: impulsive, adventurous, fearless

Usage: His impetuous decision to quit his job surprised everyone.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/impetuous

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ɪmpetʃuəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

On the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, here is a quiz on brothers and sisters

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

In politics, he was the first PM of his newly independent country, while she became the first woman President of the UN General Assembly in 1953. Name the famous siblings.

QUESTION 2

This famous 1807 work that narrated the works of a famous English playwright was authored by a brother-sister duo. Name them and the work.

QUESTION 3

According to historians, Ptolemy XIII and Ptolemy XIV were consorts and ruled alongside their sister, who is considerably more famous and legendary than the two men. Name her.

QUESTION 4

In later Ramayana traditions, what was the name of Rama's elder sister, who was married to the sage who oversaw the sacrifice that Dasharatha performed for obtaining sons?

QUESTION 5

Name the Russian siblings who have not only won titles at a tennis Major but are the only brother and sister to reach the No.1 ranking in singles.

QUESTION 6

The National Bravery awards given by the Indian government are named after two teenagers who were murdered after being abducted in Delhi in 1978. Name the two.

QUESTION 7

In Greek myth, name the twins born to Zeus and Leto, with one becoming the god of prophecy, music, healing and archery and the other the goddess of the hunt, wilderness and childbirth.

Visual Question:
Name these siblings who have also won Oscars apart from the Grammys and other leading awards. AP

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Who led the Visigoths who sacked Rome in 410 CE? **Ans: Alaric I**
2. For approximately how long had Rome avoided being sacked by a foreign enemy before 410 CE? **Ans: Nearly 800 years**
3. Which Roman emperor was ruling the Western Roman Empire when Rome was sacked? **Ans: Honorius**
4. Which city served as the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire at the time? **Ans: Constantinople**
5. Which Christian theologian wrote The City of God in the aftermath of the sack of Rome, addressing arguments that the rise of Christianity had contributed to Rome's troubles? **Ans: St. Augustine of Hippo**
Visual: Identify the Roman writer who described the catastrophe with the words, "The City which had taken the whole world was itself taken." **Ans: St. Jerome**
Early Birds: Siddhartha Viswanathan | Erfanally Oosmany | Suchit Narottam | Dodo Jayaditya | Parimal Das

From Page One

At least 290 Indians missing, says Centre

The second tranche of relief materials being dispatched to Nepal in an IAF C-17 aircraft on Thursday. ANI

"The second consignment of 37.5 tonnes of HADR material, medicines and food packets has been handed over to Mr. Mahabir Pun, Minister for Science, Technology and Innovation to support Nepal's flood relief and rescue efforts. India remains committed to standing by Nepal and its people," official spokesperson of the External Affairs Ministry, Randhir Jaiswal, said.

On Thursday afternoon, Mr. Jaiswal said that two separate groups, comprising 37 and 49 people from Tamil Nadu who travelled to Kailash Manasarovar, were among the 288 Indians who could not be contacted. Later, the number was revised to 290. Giving a tentative breakdown of the Indians who remain unaccounted for so far, he said, "There is a group of 32 nationals from West Bengal who travelled with the help of Samrat Travels in Timure, which is in Rasuwa district, where this disaster happened. Then, a group of 61 Indian nationals from different States who travelled through Richa Tours, and then a group of 33 Indian nationals from Kerala."

He said that as rescued people return to Kathmandu, arrangements would be made to facilitate their journey home.

Officials said that 63 Indian nationals employed in the Trishuli-1 project and 21 Indians from Tamil Nadu have been rescued, while the search is on to locate those who have not been heard from for over 24 hours.

The situation in the disaster-hit zone from Rasuwa to Chitwan is difficult to assess because of the absence of a stable telecom network, which was disrupted by the flash flood, officials said, expressing hope that more people would be located in the coming hours.

Jaishankar holds review meeting

As part of the ongoing process, Mr. Jaishankar held a review meeting with Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri and other senior officials on Thursday. The meeting was also attended through video link by the Indian Ambassador to Nepal, Naveen Shrivastava, and the Indian Ambassador to Beijing, Vikram Doraiswamy.

Meanwhile, family members of several of those unaccounted for so far have taken to social media to express their concern. Government sources said efforts are under way to account for those who remain "uncontactable".

Four Nagas killed in ambush in Manipur

The groups had signed the Suspension of Operation agreement with the Centre in 2008. It expressed resentment over the "complete security failure" and demanded that authorities book the perpetrators, form a Special Investigation Team, and deliver speedy justice.

Shutdown observed

Following the incident, people in Senapati district observed a shutdown. The UNC announced a one-day *'genna'*, a period of strict prohibition, rest, and community worship, across Manipur's Naga-inhabited areas on Friday to pay homage to the victims.

The ambush was carried out at a time when the Manipur government is continuing its efforts to restore peace in the ethnic violence-scarred State. The efforts included the resumption of the Imphal-Guwahati bus service via National Highway-2, which was blockaded for more than three years after the conflict between the Kuki-Zos and Meiteis erupted on May 3, 2023.

The highway passes through Kuki- and Naga-inhabited areas.

Series of attacks

In February, the situation in Manipur took another turn following a series of attacks, including arson, involving the Kuki-Zo and Naga communities.

At a high-level security meeting held after the expiry of a 15-day ultimatum asking individuals and groups to surrender illegal weapons, the Chief Minister instructed security officials to nab and initiate action against the perpetrators of Thursday's attack.

'Stringent action'

"We decided to take stringent action against any individual, irrespective of community, found in possession of illegal arms and weapons. We also decided that members of outfits under the SoO or peace talks with the government will face action if found to carry weapons beyond their designated camps," he said.

Mr. Konthoujam, Chief Secretary Puneet Kumar Goel, Security Advisor Kuldiep Singh, Director General of Police Mukesh Singh, and heads of Army, paramilitary forces, and intelligence agencies in Manipur attended the meeting.

Centre blames middlemen as onion prices hit ₹62 per kg

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Thursday blamed "black marketing, hoarding and profiteering" for the increasing price of onions across the country and said the essential vegetable will be made available for retail sale at a discounted price of ₹35 per kilogram through designated mobile vans in cities such as Delhi. On Thursday, the price for a kilogram of onion in the Delhi market was ₹62.

The Consumer Affairs Ministry said the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Limited (Nafed), and the National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India Limited (NCCF) will sell the onions through its retail stores and the Kendriya Bhandars under the price stabilisation measures.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said middlemen are the reason for the increase in onion prices and the farmers should get a reasonable income while the consumers should get the product at a reasonable rate.

India, China discuss ways to clarify perceptions on LAC

Differing views on the subject are seen as a key factor behind tensions in some sectors; both sides agree to address 'any situation on the ground through the existing diplomatic, military channels'

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

India and China discussed ways to improve their understanding of each other's perception of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the 25th Round of Special Representatives talks on the boundary question held in Beijing on Tuesday.

Officials from both sides see differing perceptions of the LAC in some regions as a key factor behind tensions in both Western and Eastern Sectors of the border.

An eight-point outcome document released on Wednesday, a day after National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi held the talks, acknowledged those concerns. It said the two sides "discussed ways to improve understanding of LAC in appropriate areas, for better border management".

The joint consensus statement noted both sides agreed that "any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly through existing diplomatic and military channels, including the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC), local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the LAC."

India has long pushed for clarifying the LAC to reduce likelihood of incidents between patrols in areas where claims overlap. FILE PHOTO

In another key outcome, the document said, an Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation would "advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation". That process, which would start with both sides agreeing to the terms of reference, is expected to focus on sectors where there are no pronounced differences in alignment.

India has long pitched for clarifying the LAC to reduce the likelihood of incidents between patrols in areas where claims overlap. A 1996 agreement on confidence-building measures noted the need for the two sides "arriving at a common understanding of the alignment of the LAC".

During his first visit to China as Prime Minister in 2015, Narendra Modi made a public pitch to resume the LAC clarification process. That did not happen, with Chinese officials saying a clarification process on LAC alignment would further complicate attempts to resolve the boundary dispute.

However, the tensions in eastern Ladakh starting in April 2020 sharply underlined the need to address differences over alignment, especially in the Western Sector. In the Eastern Sector in Arunachal Pradesh as well, differing perceptions of LAC alignment were cited for tensions earlier this month.

The outcome document eschewed any reference to clarification, and, given the contested history of the term, a resumption of the process envisaged in 1996 remains unlikely. However, the two Special Representatives did give a political endorsement of the need "to improve understanding of the LAC in appropriate areas", opening the door for both sides to initiate a process of better understanding the other's perceptions.

Conflicting claims made on Pak.-China ties, says Cong.

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Seeking a comprehensive official review of Operation Sindoor, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday questioned what he described as conflicting statements by senior military officials on the extent of cooperation between Pakistan and China during the operation. India had launched the operation in May 2025.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh shared two video clips and contrasted the remarks made by Deputy Chief of Army Staff Lt. Gen. Rahul Singh on July 4, 2025, and former Chief of Defence Staff Gen. Anil Chauhan on August 25, 2026.

Mr. Ramesh said Lt. Gen. Singh had revealed the very disturbingly deep nature of the Pakistan-China *jugalbandi* [close ties] during Operation Sindoor.

However, he said Gen. Chauhan's more recent remarks on the same issue were simply opposite to what the Army officer had stated. "The nation is confused," Mr. Ramesh said, asking, "What is going on here?"

Cong. accuses Centre of facilitating a 'sugar scam' ahead of festival season

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday accused the Narendra Modi government of facilitating a ₹36,000-crore "sugar scam", alleging that its failure to act on a shortage allowed hoarders and black-marketeers to profit from a sharp rise in sugar prices ahead of the festive season.

Addressing a press conference, Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala said the government knew in April that there would be a shortage but "sat quietly" and did not act.

Explaining the issue, he said that the opening stock of sugar for 2025-26 was 50 lakh tonnes, which was 30 lakh tonnes lower than the previous year. On April 30 this year, the Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers' Association had stated that sugar production was 275 lakh tonnes.

Further, he said around 120 lakh tonnes of sugar was expected to be consumed between August and November. And already, the price of retail sugar has gone from ₹45 to ₹75 per kg. At an additional ₹30 a kg, he said, consumers would collectively pay ₹36,000 crore more, benefiting hoarders and black-marketeers.

Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala addressing the media in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

"When people celebrate Dussehra and Deepavali, they will face the brunt of the price rise of sugar this year and shell out more from their pockets. The 120 lakh tonnes of sugar will amount to ₹36,000 crore, which will directly benefit hoarders and black-marketeers. What could be a bigger example of collusion with those in power," Mr. Surjewala asked.

"Due to less production and swindling of stocks, sugar has become expensive during the festive season," the Congress leader said, alleging that "this is the Modi government's new masterstroke to openly rob the public".

Mr. Surjewala claimed that the government had used 32% of sugar cane stocks for producing E20 fuel between November 2025 and July 2026, leaving less sugar available in the market for consumers.

He demanded that the government restore the scheme of providing 500 grams of sugar to every member of a family at subsidised rates through the Public Distribution System.

Kharge urges PM to share delimitation plan, freeze Lok Sabha strength at 543

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday called for the existing strength of the Lok Sabha to be frozen at 543 seats for the next 25 years and sought implementation of one-third reservation for women from the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Mr. Kharge urged him to share the government's proposals on delimitation with all political parties and the State governments. "This is an issue that has enormous significance for the country," he said, adding: Please do not again try and bulldoze [the Bill through Parliament] as you attempted on April 16 and 17, 2026."

Mr. Kharge sought an all-party meeting to discuss the delimitation proposals and adequate time for political parties and State governments to study them before any legislation is brought before Parliament in a special session.

Referring to his July 16 letter to Mr. Modi in which he had made a similar appeal, Mr. Kharge said: "I am writing now to reiterate this request since the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs has publicly stated in a television interview last night that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened."

Mallikarjun Kharge

Three demands

Mr. Kharge said the Congress was clear on three points – maintaining the existing strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 for the next 25 years, retaining the existing State-wise allocation of seats for the same period, and introducing one-third reservation for women from the 2029 election. "Before you go ahead as indicated by the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs, I wish to reiterate my earlier request to you to - convene an all-party meeting to discuss whatever delimitation proposals you have in mind; give all political parties and State governments adequate time to study such proposals," he said.

On August 19, the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the party's highest decision-making body, called for the Lok Sabha's strength to be frozen at 543 seats, as well as the existing State-wise allocation, for 25 years, while seeking implementation of one-third reservation for women from 2029.

The Congress's latest position is also in line with a unanimous resolution adopted by the Tamil Nadu Assembly on delimitation.

During the Budget Session on April 17, a Constitution amendment Bill involving delimitation for implementing women's reservation was defeated in the Lok Sabha.

Ahead of Sept. 1 rally, CPI hits out at Centre over economy, education

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of its 'Badlaav Zaroori Hai' (Change is Necessary) rally at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan on September 1, the Communist Party of India on Thursday launched a broadside at the Narendra Modi-led government, accusing it of failing to address economic distress, weakening democratic institutions, undermining federalism, and responding to public dissent with repression rather than engagement.

Addressing a press conference at the party's headquarters in Ajoy Bhawan in New Delhi, CPI general secretary D. Raja said the country was facing multiple crises, including unemployment, rising prices, declining purchasing power, growing inequality, and pressure on public education and healthcare systems. He said farmers continued to demand a legal guarantee for minimum support price (MSP), while workers faced increasing insecurity and students were being subjected to police action for raising legitimate concerns.

D. Raja

'Troubling trend'

Referring to recent protests by students and youth across the country, Mr. Raja said the government had failed to address concerns over jobs, education and examination-related controversies. He pointed to police action against student protesters in Delhi, Jharkhand and Bihar as a troubling trend.

"The incidents of violence against students are particularly serious because they demonstrate how the ordinary exercise of democratic rights can be treated as a law-and-order threat by the BJP," Mr. Raja said.

"Students protesting peacefully should not have to fear police action, detention or physical injury," he added, while also criticising BJP leaders for allegedly branding protesters as "*dimagi* Naxals".

13 held for double murder in Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

West Bengal police have arrested 13 people in connection with the murder of Congress leader Anisur Rahman and his son Abu Sufiyan at Nakasipara in Nadia district of West Bengal on August 15, officials said on Thursday.

APPEAL

Master Rishi Parke, Mazumdar Shaw Medical Center MRN No.10020001780658, 7 years is diagnosed with Thalassemia Major, a condition where the body fails to produce enough Red Blood Cells. These patient require life-long Blood transfusions every few weeks. The only Curative Treatment is Bone Marrow Transplant. The approximate costs for the treatment is Rs.45,20,000/-.

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States step up efforts to trace missing, stranded people after Nepal disaster

West Bengal launches efforts to find 32 pilgrims who travelled for Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra; former Union Minister Mukul Roy's daughter-in-law is part of the group; Isha Foundation in T.N. says pilgrim group of 80 from various countries missing; measures to bring back people being worked on

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Officials of several States stepped up efforts to trace people missing or stranded after the devastating flash floods in Nepal, with Chief Ministers urging departments to coordinate to ensure prompt rescue measures. The State governments were also in touch with the Centre to bring back stranded residents.

In West Bengal, the focus was on a group of 32 people who had travelled for the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra and remained untraceable. Among the 32, at least 21 are senior citizens, and many others are in their late 50s. Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, daughter-in-law of former Union Minister Mukul Roy, is also part of the group.

"The Government of West Bengal is actively coordinating with the Embassy of India in Kathmandu and proper administrative channels," Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari posted on social media.

Flood aftermath: Nepal army personnel comforting twin babies amid a search operation after the devastating flash floods at Trishuli camp; and Indian nationals, who were airlifted from Rasuwa district, sitting inside the Maithali Barrack in Nepal on Thursday. PTI, REUTERS

The group had booked their trip with Cholo Jai, a travel agency in West Bengal, and started from Kolkata on August 21. Samrat Travels, their partner company, handles the Nepal portion of the trip.

Cholo Jai staff were not able to establish contact with the group. According to the agency, the group left their hotel in Nepal's Rasuwagadhi on Wednesday morning and headed towards the China border. Around 8.30 a.m., they went to the immigration office in the same area to cross over to Tibet. Rasuwagadhi is one of the worst hit areas in the flash flood.

"Today morning, four managers from our company went there to get local information and further details about the rescue operations. We are constantly in touch with families," Manish Singh, a Cholo Jai staffer, told presspersons.

A film crew from Bengal is also stuck in Nepal. They are in a safe zone and accessible by phone.

In Tamil Nadu, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay directed Ministers and officials to oversee the rescue and safe return of people from the State. A total of 103 people from Tamil Nadu who had gone on a pilgrimage were stranded. Several of them were feared missing.

80 pilgrims missing

Isha Foundation, based in Coimbatore in the State, said a pilgrim group with 80 members of several countries, was missing in the floods.

The foundation has reached out to the Embassies for authoritative information on the missing members, it added. In a video message from the Tibet side of the Chinese border, founder of Isha Foundation Sadhguru Jaggi Vasudev said the pilgrim group consisted of 34 men and 46 women.

The Keralam government confirmed that it received around 17 distress calls from families affected by the Nepal disaster. The government said it was trying to establish contact with the 53 stranded persons from the State and ensure their safety.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu directed officials to maintain round-the-clock vigil on the Nepal situation and ensure all possible assistance.

Sources said seven from the State were reported missing or stranded. Four pilgrims from Adoni and Kurnool were found to be safe and staying at a hotel in China, while efforts continued to locate three others.

The four traced pilgrims were part of a 156-member Kailash-Mansarovar group, they added.

The Telangana government said it had provisionally identified 23 residents of the State who were stranded in Nepal. The State government was coordinating with the External Affairs Ministry, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu and Nepalese authorities. On Thursday, the Ministry said at least 290 Indian nationals remained "uncontactable" after the tragedy in Nepal.

Taking stock: Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducting an aerial survey of the flood situation in border areas. PTI

Water levels subside in Bihar rivers; risk of flooding reduces

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

A day after a flash flood killed hundreds in Nepal and threatened to overflow into neighbouring Bihar, the risk of flooding in the Gandak, Ganga, and other tributary rivers subsided significantly on Thursday.

However, debris and cattle carcasses were seen in the Gandak river.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducted an aerial survey of the Valmikingar barrage areas of West Champaran district along the Indo-Nepal border which had faced an imminent threat till Thursday afternoon.

"The way disaster had struck Nepal is a matter of concern. The Prime Minister and Union Home Minister were continuously keeping a close watch on Bihar," he told presspersons. "The situation is gradually becoming normal... The discharge at the barrage was around 1 lakh cusecs today," he added.

Fearing a flash flood in the Gandak, all 36 gates of the Valmikinagar barrage had been opened on Wednesday. The barrage started witnessing three-metre-high waves and the water gush peaked at 1.5 lakh cusecs on Thursday afternoon. It then "started decreasing", one of the senior engineers said.

Water levels also receded in the Ganga river at some places in Patna.

U.P. activates rescue teams, focuses on monitoring rivers in border areas

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

In the wake of the flash floods in Nepal, the administrations of districts in Uttar Pradesh bordering the country said on Thursday that their focus remained on continuous river monitoring.

They focus was also on alerting vulnerable villages and keeping relief and rescue teams ready for any possible flood situation.

"Amid the floods and natural disaster in Nepal, the Uttar Pradesh government has taken charge, on the instructions of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, to ensure the safety of citizens of the State," an official statement said.

Family members of U.P. citizens stranded in Nepal may contact 1070 for information, says State govt.

The government has activated relief and rescue teams along with necessary resources to safely evacuate Uttar Pradesh citizens stranded in Nepal and provide them with immediate assistance. The Control Room of the Relief Commissioner's Office is continuously monitoring the situation in the districts bordering Nepal, the statement said.

Platoon deployed

The State government has also deployed a 32 member platoon of State Disaster Relief Force (SDRF) for relief and rescue operation in Nepal.

"In addition, 22 personnel from the 26th Battalion of PAC have also been sent to Nepal. The government has made preparations to provide additional forces and resources as required, ensuring that there is no shortfall in delivering relief to the affected people. Four rubber boats are already available at the site to make the rescue operation effective in flood-affected areas. An aluminium boat is also being sent to Nepal along with an additional SDRF platoon," the statement added.

The government said that the entire focus was on safely evacuating stranded citizens and ensuring that aid reaches those in need. "Family members of Uttar Pradesh citizens stranded in Nepal may contact 1070 for any information," it said.

Learn from disaster, halt hydropower projects in State: Sikkim group to PM

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A body of two ethnic communities in Sikkim has advised the Centre to learn from the flash flood disaster in Nepal and scrap all new and proposed hydroelectric projects in the Himalayan State.

According to the Nepal Electricity Authority, at least 13 hydropower projects along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli River corridors suffered extensive damage.

The mudslide hit Gyirong port in Tibet and slammed into Nepal, creating high-speed flash floods that washed away entire roads, power projects, and inundated villages. The 111-megawatt Rasuwagadhi Hydropower Plant in Rasuwa district of Nepal was among those affected.

> The disaster highlights the vulnerability of the Himalayan region, requiring a fresh assessment of development activities
>
> **TSETEN TASKI BHUTIA**
> SIBLAC convenor

On Wednesday evening, the Sikkim Bhutia Lepcha Apex Committee (SIBLAC) urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to halt new hydropower projects in the State and order an independent probe into the existing projects.

SIBLAC convenor Tseten Taski Bhutia, also the chief adviser to the Sikkim unit of the BJP, expressed solidarity with the people of Nepal and hoped for the success of the relief and rescue operations.

"The disaster in Nepal highlights the vulnerability of the Himalayan region, requiring a fresh assessment of development activities," he said, insisting that the Centre should reconsider plans for new hydroelectric projects on Sikkim's rivers.

Seeking an independent inquiry into the environmental, geological, seismic, social, and national security implications of all existing and proposed projects, he urged the Centre to publish a White Paper containing the findings of such an assessment.

He said the group was not against development, but not at the cost of the ecological and social security of the area.

Rahul attacks Centre over NCLT plan for businessman

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday accused the Centre of creating "two systems" in the country, one for a handful of billionaires and another for everyone else, after the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approved a resolution plan allowing businessman Subhash Chandra to settle ₹22,006 crore dues for ₹6.5 crore.

In a post on X, Mr. Gandhi quipped that NCLT stood for "Neta-Company Loot Tribunal". He said, "If a farmer doesn't pay 50 thousand, his land gets auctioned off. If a salaried person misses even one EMI, bank goons show up at the house. Poor students can't even get loans for education." "But for select 'friends,' bank money is like personal property – withdraw as much as you want, repay whatever you feel like," he said.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh described the settlement as a "mundan", saying it made "a completely mockery of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016".

Security tightened at disputed Mathura temple amid 'Kar Seva' concerns, HC told

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Mathura administration recently informed the Allahabad High Court that security arrangements were made at the disputed Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah premises amid concerns of 'Kar Seva'.

'Kar Seva' was called by Hindu religious leaders in Mathura for voluntary action to "liberate" the Krishna Janmabhoomi site.

The Bench, during the hearing of the Original Suit No. 4 of 2023, filed by the Shri Krishna Janmbhoomi Mukti Nirmaan Trust and others against the Shahi Masjid Eidgah Management Committee and others, noted that the court had received a report in a sealed cover.

The report had originally been called for by the High Court on July 17, after a plaintiff filed an application asking the court to direct the State Government and local administration to prevent any individual or group from entering the disputed site to hold meetings, perform Kar Seva, or organise events that might disturb public peace.

The court is presently hearing 18 suits that seek the removal of the Shahi Idgah, which they claim is an encroachment on the premises of the temple.

The matter will now be heard on September 18.

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The Delhi Technological University (DTU) shall conduct a Special Spot Round for admission in B.Des and M.Des Program for vacant seats on **Monday, 31.08.2026.** in the Department of Design, DTU.
For details visit **www.dtu.ac.in**. For any query please mail to **bdes_admission@dtu.ac.in** for B.Des admissions and **mdes_admission@dtu.ac.in** for M.Des admissions.
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Ministry Of Science And Technology
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Announces Call for Applications under "Biotechnology Career Advancement and Re-Orientation (BioCARe) Programme for Women Researchers" for 2026-27

Department of Biotechnology, Ministry of Science & Technology, Government of India invites the applications under the BioCARe Programme for women researchers for the year 2026-27. The programme is targeted to enhance the participation of women researchers in India towards research in Biotechnology and allied areas.
Detailed information on the fellowship grant, eligibility criteria, guidelines and application process is available at DBT website - **https://dbt.gov.in/** and RCB website - **https://rcb.res.in/DBTBioCARe/** To apply, interested applicants may kindly visit Common Fellowship Portal via **https://fellowships.gov.in/**.
Start Date of Online Application : 25th August, 2026
End Date of Online Application : 23rd September, 2026
For any queries, please contact DBT-HRD Project & Management Unit, Regional Centre for Biotechnology at **biocare.dbt@rcb.res.in**.

INBRIEF

Adityanath unveils U.P. start-up mission portal, start-up policy

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday launched the Uttar Pradesh Startup Mission portal and Uttar Pradesh Startup Policy, 2026. He said the State has more than 24,000 start-ups, including eight unicorns. At the event, incentives worth more than ₹3.42 crore were distributed to 107 start-ups and ₹1.79 crore to nine incubators. Recognition certificates were also given to new incubators. Mr. Adityanath said the initiatives are aimed at providing the youth funding, incubation support, and platforms to help their ideas and businesses grow. "We have gathered here to give flight to the dreams of the youth," he said. PTI

Fighter jet bid deadline extended to October 30

The deadline for Indian defence majors to submit bids for the development of the indigenous fifth-generation fighter jet, Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), has been extended by two months to October 30, 2026, from the earlier deadline of August 27, defence officials said. A document accessed by *The Hindu* shows that the bids for the mega fighter aircraft project will now be opened on October 31, a day after the revised submission deadline. The earlier schedule envisaged opening the bids on August 28. The Aeronautical Development Agency issued a corrigendum on Thursday extending the deadline after prospective bidders sought additional time to prepare and submit proposals.

Rajnath lays foundation for tank overhaul facility in M.P.

The ₹472-crore project seeks to keep T-72 and T-90 tanks operationally ready; the facility aims at bridging the capacity gap and ensuring faster availability of refurbished tanks to the Army

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday laid the foundation stone for a ₹472-crore project to establish facilities for overhauling T-72 and T-90 tanks at the Vehicle Factory Jabalpur, located in Madhya Pradesh's Jabalpur district. The project is aimed at augmenting the Army's capacity to keep its armoured fleet operationally ready.

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav joined Mr. Singh at the ceremony at the Vehicle Factory Jabalpur, a unit of the Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited (AVNL).

According to the Ministry of Defence, the new facility will have the capacity to overhaul 80 tanks annually. The Army requires around 230 tanks to be overhauled every year, and the Heavy Vehicles Factory in Avadi, a suburb of Chennai, currently has the capacity to overhaul 150 tanks annually. The Jabalpur facility will, therefore, bridge the existing capacity gap and ensure faster availability of refurbished tanks to the Army.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav at the Vehicle Factory in Jabalpur on Thursday. PTI

He said the project reflected India's growing technological and industrial capabilities and would strengthen Jabalpur's position as a hub for defence maintenance, modernisation and manufacturing.

Mr. Singh said the changing character of warfare, marked by drones, precision-guided weapons, missiles, satellites, artificial intelligence and cyber capabilities, had not diminished the relevance of tanks, but had changed the way they would be employed.

"Modern warfare demands combined capabilities rather than dependence on a single platform," he said, stressing the need to integrate tanks with infantry, artillery, drones, air power, surveillance and precision weapons.

Mr. Singh also called for existing tanks to be equipped with superior sensors and modern battlefield capabilities.

He said the government's focus was to provide the armed forces with modernised tanks alongside drones, missiles, artillery, electronic warfare and energy weapons.

He highlighted the contribution of the Heavy Vehicles Factory in Avadi, which has supplied around 4,400 tanks to the Army over four decades. The AVNL, he said, had 25 years of experience in overhauling T-72 and T-90 variants and should set higher benchmarks in quality, productivity and innovation.

Big boost for MSMEs

The project is also expected to generate opportunities for micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) supplying mechanical, electrical, electronic and hydraulic components and services, creating a wider local defence-industrial ecosystem.

Mr. Singh said India's defence production had risen to around ₹1.80 lakh crore in 2025-26 from ₹46,000 crore in 2014, while defence exports increased to approximately ₹39,000 crore from less than ₹1,000 crore.

He said the government's objective was to reduce dependence on foreign supply chains by manufacturing, repairing, maintaining and upgrading defence systems domestically.

Mangled remains: The wreckage of a twin-engine training aircraft in an agricultural field in Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh, on Thursday. PTI

Pilot, instructor die as training aircraft crashes in Kanpur

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two persons were killed after a Tecnam P2006T twin-engine aircraft operated by Garg Aviation Ltd., Kanpur, crashed near the Ganga Barrage on Thursday, according to preliminary information.

The aircraft, bearing registration VT-NBV, was on a training flight within the local flying area of the Kanpur Civil Airport when it met with an accident approximately five nautical miles from the airport, near the Ganga Barrage.

Two people on board – a trainee pilot and an instructor – sustained fatal injuries in the crash.

PTI reported that the aircraft took off around 11.30 a.m. and crashed about 20 minutes later. The trainer had around 3,000 hours of flying experience.

A three-member team of officials from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) will visit the accident site.

AAIB alerted

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has also been informed and will conduct a detailed investigation into the accident.

The same aircraft was involved in an earlier incident in which a female trainee pilot was injured after being struck by the spinning propeller while disembarking following a night training flight.

Two Chinese crew members of sunken Panama-flagged ship brought back safe to Paradip

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Two rescued Chinese crew members of the Panama-flagged bulk carrier, *MV Ocean Winner*, that sank in Bay of Bengal were brought to Odisha's Paradip on Thursday.

"Indian Coast Guard Ship (ICGS) Varad safely brought two Chinese survivors identified as Pan Tonglai and Chen Jianhe to Paradip. Rescued from a liferaft on August 22, 2026 both received medical care onboard during transit and have now been handed over to authorised company representatives in the presence of Bureau of Immigration and local police officials," ICG spokesperson Commandant Amit Uniyal said.

Life line: Indian Coast Guard Ship (ICGS) *Varad* safely brought Pan Tonglai and Chen Jianhe to Paradip. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The development comes after the two Chinese nationals were rescued by a merchant vessel on August 22, after a distress call was received by MRCC Sri Vijaya Puram.

Commandant Uniyal said coordinated sea and air search operations continue in full swing to locate the remaining missing crew members. "Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) Sri Vijaya Puram is continuously coordinating with all participating assets in the ongoing rescue efforts," he said.

On August 25, MRCC, Beijing had joined the Search and Rescue operation to trace remaining 22 crew members.

The MV Ocean Winner had sailed from Paradip for China on August 20.

Non-govt. colleges dominate AYUSH education's growth

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

As the Centre pushes to widen the role of AYUSH in India's healthcare system – including through greater coverage, rural outreach and integration with mainstream health services – the country's AYUSH medical education infrastructure has expanded rapidly.

But the expansion appears to have been driven largely by non-government institutions, according to government data.

The number of Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy (AYUSH) colleges rose from 789 in 2021 to 971 in 2024, an increase of about 23%. Over the same period, total admission capacity grew from 63,477 to 79,593, or nearly 25%, while permitted seats grew from 50,711 to 72,490 – an increase of about 43%.

By April 2024, the Ministry registered 541 Ayurveda, 58 Unani, 17 Siddha, 71 Yoga and Naturopathy, 277 Homoeopathy and seven Sowa-Rigpa colleges.

Of the 541 Ayurveda colleges in April 2024, 467 were non-government – nearly 86% of the total. In Homoeopathy, 236 of 277 colleges, or about 85%, were non-government. The pattern was similar in other systems. Of the 58 Unani colleges, only 16 were government-run; just three of 17 Siddha colleges were government institutions. Data clearly indicates that non-government institutions have become an important source of undergraduate medical education in AYUSH.

SRMIST, *The Hindu* to host webinar on balancing clinical experience with technology

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

SRM Institute of Science and Technology, in association with *The Hindu*, will organise a webinar on 'The Future Doctor: Balancing Clinical Experience with Technology' as part of the Future Career Conversations series on Saturday.

The session will explore how the medical profession is evolving with the rapid integration of Artificial Intelligence, robotics, and digital health, and how future doctors can adapt to these advancements while continuing to uphold clinical excellence and patient-centred care. The discussion will examine how medical professionals can effectively leverage tools such as AI-assisted diagnostics to treatment planning, telemedicine, and digital consultations, while addressing the ethical challenges associated with technology-driven healthcare.

The panel will also deliberate on the evolving debate between specialisation and general practice, as well as the need for reforms in medical education while offering insights into the skills, adaptability, and multi-disciplinary approach required to succeed in the medicine of tomorrow.

The panel will consist of R. Jayanthi, Dean, SRM Medical College Hospital and Research Centre; Vivek Narayanan, Dean (Dental), SRM Kattankulathur Dental College and Hospital; Ritubhan Gautam, Head - Global Health, Deep Tek.ai, and K. Ganapathy, Honorary Distinguished Professor, IIM Jammu, Distinguished Professor, Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University, and Emeritus Professor, National Academy of Medical Sciences.

The session will be held at 4.30 p.m. on August 29 and will be moderated by Geetha Srimathi S., Senior Reporter, *The Hindu*. Registration can be made on newsth.live/THSRMFE or by scanning the QR code.

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(set by Dr. X)

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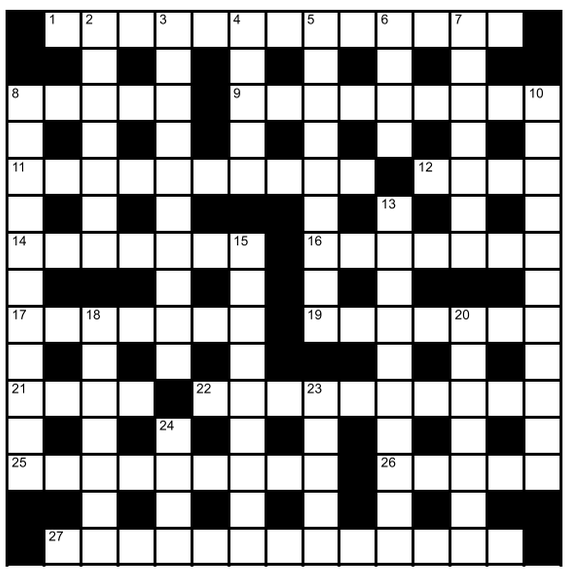


Across

1 Reckless cheater's cool, having hot mistress (13)
8 Injured crossing small, wooded area (5)
9 Bishop made a psalm — it's relating to a Christian rite (9)
11 Gosh! Feel so nervous — it's a result of fear (10)
12 Catch small bug (4)
14 Batting star behind victory (7)
16 Australian knocked back drink, having devoured ham (7)
17 Ordered meat loaf, wanting fine breakfast dish (7)
19 Have a snack in shed around 4 pm in Britain (7)
21 Brought back superior adhesives (4)
22 Mighty unpleasant American making a bloomer (10)
25 Sentry in compound tackling a bully (9)
26 Tell a gang to secure goods at bottom of sea (5)
27 Compose tune for girl and propose — that's impressive (13)

Down

2 Box contains old comic strip (7)
3 Where one in bathroom might be having a lively night out (2,3,5)
4 Falsehood about bachelor and lady is defamation (5)
5 Fool under pressure after knight's captured by awfully neat chess move (2,7)
6 Crack in bottom of pelvic joint (4)
7 Individual cuddling model under tree in Californian city (2,5)
8 Drunk women getting noisy, tense and agitated (11)
10 Dexterous trickery by crafty gem dealer at home (11)
13 Dance in rave on Ecstasy, high around afternoon (10)
15 Dashing girl on clip, breaking record (9)
18 Monkey in tree, killing a little dove (7)
20 Support associate crushed by evil criminal (7)
23 Use axe essentially to cut conifer in retreat (5)
24 Aware of revolting idiot nobbling rings (2,2)

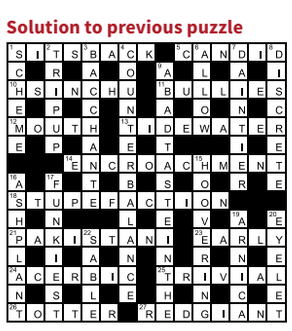
SUDOKU

6		3		7				
	2					1	3	7
9			2		3			
	6	8		5	2	3		
		5	6	1		7	2	
			1		7			3
3	4	7					9	
				9		8		6

No.SS6986 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

6	2	3	7	8	1	4	5	9
4	1	7	2	9	5	8	6	3
8	9	5	3	6	4	1	2	7
1	6	8	9	3	7	5	4	2
9	7	4	5	1	2	6	3	8
3	5	2	6	4	8	7	9	1
5	3	9	1	7	6	2	8	4
7	4	6	8	2	3	9	1	5
2	8	1	4	5	9	3	7	6

FAITH

Lord Vishnu's unique power

Lord Sriman Narayana has a unique divine power called "*Aghatitha Ghatana Samarthya*," the capability to bring together contradictory, opposing or incompatible qualities and make the impossible possible. Adisesha (the serpent) and Garuda (the eagle), though natural adversaries, coexist harmoniously in Lord Vishnu's shrine to serve Him together. Tirukudandhai Dr. Venkatesh said in a discourse that He unifies the three causes of creation (*Upadana, Nimitha, Sahakari karana*) – Lord Narayana Himself serves as the raw material, the creator, and the instrument of creation. Just like a spider spins a web entirely out of itself, the Lord combines all three causes within himself. He (*Bhagavan*) is the means (*Sadhana*) and the goal (*Saadhya*). As highlighted by Nammazhwar's line, "*aarum avane, perum avane,*" Lord Narayana serves as both the path and means (*aaru*) to reach salvation and the ultimate goal (*peru*) to be attained.

Lord Narayana is the supreme sovereign master and the humble servant. He, being the supreme, willingly surrenders to the love of His devotees. When a devotee approaches Him with pure devotion, the master transforms into a servant: transcendent supreme majesty (*Paratvam*) and total humility (*saulabhyam*) are inherent in His avatars. Sriman Narayana sheds all His pride, assumes the form of an animal without hesitation, and descends as an avatar such as Varaha Swami (wild boar avatar). He sniffs the earth out of love to rescue it, showcasing how transcendent supreme majesty (*Paratvam*) and absolute down-to-earth accessibility (*Saulabhyam*) unite seamlessly in Him.

INBRIEF

LIC subscribes to Bajaj Finance's ₹5,000 cr. NCDs

LIC has subscribed to Bajaj Finance's ₹5,000 crore non-convertible debentures (NCDs). The insurer said it has subscribed to five lakh NCDs of face value of ₹1 lakh each, of the deposit-taking non-banking financial company, totalling ₹5,000 crore, LIC said in a filing. The instruments carry a coupon rate of 8.15% per annum and a tenure of 3,653 days.The first coupon payment will be on August 27, 2027 and annually thereafter. The maturity date of the NCDs is August 27, 2036.

KPR Mill to invest ₹1,225 cr. in greenfield projects, expansion

Coimbatore-based KPR Mill, which has integrated textile production capacities, is investing ₹1,225 crore in greenfield projects and expanding existing capacities. The company said it expects ₹2,000 crore additional revenue from the new facilities when they are commissioned and the entire capex will be met through internal accruals. KPR will also set up a new sweater manufacturing factory in Coimbatore at ₹75 crore to make 2.5 million garments.

HCL sets up GCC in Pune for German partner Wacker

HCLTech on Thursday announced that its partner Wacker Chemie AG, a German chemicals and biotechnology company, had established a Global Capability Center in Pune. The GCC, set up and operated by HCL, will support Wacker's engineering, IT and digital transformation initiatives, it said. The initiative marks an important milestone in Wacker's digital transformation," said Dr. Frank Fehler, Executive V-P and Country Head - Germany, HCLTech.

A.P. to become third subsea hub on data centre buildout

The State is witnessing investments from tech giants Microsoft and Google, which are building fresh subsea cable infrastructure, currently concentrated in Mumbai and Chennai

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

As a result of datacentre buildout in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, the former's coastline will soon hold new landing stations for subsea cables, which connect global internet with India.

On one hand, Microsoft is participating in a consortium with firms like Lightstorm and Singaporean telco Singtel to land the 3,600 km India-Southeast Asia (I-2SEA) Submarine Cable System, and Google has the globe-spanning America-India Connect system, which will land in Visakhapatnam, where the tech giant's datacentre complex is being built.

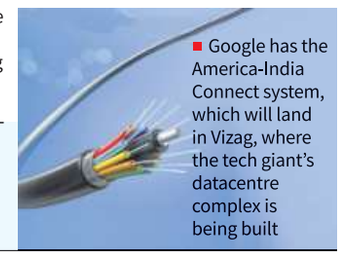
"As part of this AI hub... we're bringing in multiple new subsea cables that will land on the coast of Andhra Pradesh around the Vishakhapatnam area," Alexander Smith, a Google executive who oversees several of the firm's physical infrastructure projects in the Asia Pacific region, told *The Hindu* in an interview on Thursday.

"That will mean that essentially India will have, after Mumbai and Chennai, a third digital international subsea gateway... connecting India directly with Southeast Asia, so Singapore and a couple of the other main markets, down into Australia and right around into the Middle East and Europe and beyond. So this will... make India and Vizag in particular one of the most connected places in the world," Mr. Smith added.

Network busy

A.P.'s coastline will soon hold new landing stations for subsea cables, which connect global internet with India

- Essentially India will have a third digital international subsea gateway connecting India directly with Southeast Asia
- Microsoft is part of a consortium with firms like Lightstorm and Singtel to land the 3,600 km I-2SEA Submarine Cable System



- Google has the America-India Connect system, which will land in Vizag, where the tech giant's datacentre complex is being built

Lightstorm CEO Amajit Gupta said in an interview with *The Hindu* in June that I-2SEA "connects Southeast Asia, specifically Singapore and Malaysia, to the east coast of India," and that the cable system, which also connects to Chennai, "provides a brand new corridor to South Asia" from South East Asia, where a lot of infrastructure serving Indian enterprises and consumers continues to reside.

The cable system is set to be ready for service in Q4 2029. Mr. Gupta said that new cable buildout in a fresh location was key to preserving Indian internet connectivity from a strategic standpoint.

"If you peel the onion and look at the cables which connect the east coast of India... most of these are pretty old cables," he said. "They are easily about 8, 10, 12, 15 years old... [they] are filled with capacity and are also rapidly running into end of life." Mr. Gupta said that there were geopolitical derisking tailwinds driving these investments. "I don't need to tell you what's happening in West Asia, which means people are beginning to think, hey, now this is getting so dangerous, why can't we flush the traffic out to the eastern coast of India so that at the least I have resilience and at the best I have an alternate path [in case connectivity is lost]."

On top of the subsea cable landing, both projects require significant infrastructure further inland. "This is a pan-India project," Mr. Smith said.

"We're needing to install and then light and operate thousands of kilometres of new fiber ... I think what's kind of underappreciated is that this will really create a robust new layer of digital connectivity... that will go between some of the mainline metros." Taking a cue from landside fiber built on top of electrical transmission lines, Mr. Gupta said that Lightstorm is "likely to build a terrestrial corridor ... which will connect Machilipatnam to Mumbai, Hyderabad and similarly Chennai to Hyderabad and Mumbai with the same bandwidth".

"Fiber itself is out of stock across the globe," Mr. Gupta said, adding "including from Indian manufacturers. And then the fiber sub-components, the fiber raw material, the inputs are all in short supply. So that has never been the case for the last 10 to 15 years."

Google facility

Mr. Smith said that Google's Visakhapatnam facility will focus on inference, with no immediate plans for performing power-hungry training runs. He added that the firm was trying to acquire as much renewable power for the project as possible – pointing out that Google is among the biggest buyers of renewable energy in the world – and that water use minimisation was also on the agenda with air cooling technologies.

He added that the Google facility will focus on inference for domestic enterprises and government agencies, as there has been "pretty deep AI adoption across the delivery of government services at the State levels as well as Union level."

SEBI to propose SOP for unscheduled holidays

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Tuhin Kanta Pandey

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is set to propose a standard operating procedure (SOP) for operational activities related to unscheduled market holidays, as part of efforts to strengthen market resilience while improving efficiency and ease of doing business.

"Our endeavour has been to build resilience and strengthen the risk management systems. At the same time, we want to facilitate greater efficiency and ease of doing business," SEBI Chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said at an event marking the 30th anniversary of NSE Clearing Ltd. on Thursday.

Addressing questions on potential changes to the newly introduced Closing Auction Session (CAS), he said currently there were no plans to modify the system and expressed confidence that participation would increase over time.

GAIL to stretch natural gas pipeline network up to 20,000 km: CMD

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Gas Authority of India Limited (GAIL) has about 1,500 km of natural gas pipeline under construction, which upon completion would expand its network to about 20,000 km, Deepak Gupta, Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) said at the company's AGM with shareholders.

"Our network now extends over 18,690 km, with nearly 1,500 km under construction. Upon completion of the ongoing projects, the network will expand to almost 20,000 km," the CMD said.

In his address, Mr. Gupta also underlined that GAIL was also expanding their LPG transmission network. He pointed to the Delhi-headquartered distributor expanding the capacity of its LPG transmission pipeline from Jamnagar to Loni, from the present 3.25 MMTPA to 6.5 MMTPA.

This would further build on three LPG pipelines, cumulatively spanning about 1,775 km, for which it recently received a go-ahead from the Petroleum Natural Gas and Regulatory Board (PNGRB).

Zee's Chandra to pay ₹6.5 cr. under IBC vs. ₹22,000-cr. due

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Top banks may face a 99% haircut via the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) ordering Zee Media Group founder Subhash Chandra to pay ₹6.5 crore against ₹22,006.57 crore due to creditors in personal insolvency proceedings

The NCLT went by the decision of 80.81% creditors who okayed Mr. Chandra's offer. The matter involved Indiabulls Housing Finance and personal guarantor Mr. Chandra.

The tribunal went by the decision of a majority of Committee of Creditors (CoC) who chose the offer.

Allegedly they were related party and associated with Mr. Chandra and a large segment of creditors from Haryana whose claims were admitted by the Resolution Professional without examining the manner in which the alleged debts had arisen.

"The Repayment Plan submitted by the Personal Guarantor is required to be approved ...subject to exclusion of the claims submitted through Anil Kumar on behalf of 960 individuals and Sunil Jain on behalf of 300 individuals from the final list of creditors and consequential redistribution of the repayment amount among the remaining eligible creditors...," NCLT order read.

"The approved Repayment Plan will be binding on all the creditors," it said.

In this case, the more than 88% creditors who willingly approved Mr. Chandra's proposal saw their credentials questioned by other creditors.

The creditors who opposed the repayment plan included Axis Bank, RBL Bank, IndusInd Bank, IDBI Trusteeship (for Franklin Templeton), LIC Housing Finance and Union Bank of India with a collective vote share of 19.186%.

Subhash Chandra

Those who approved Mr. Chandra's plan included Appearance Corpcall Capital Advisors LLP, Catalyst Trusteeship, World Crest Advisors LLP, Direct Media Distribution Ventures Pvt. Ltd., Lemonade Capital Advisors LLP and Veena Investments Pvt. Ltd. allegedly associated with Mr. Chandra.

Multiple objections

It was submitted multiple creditors raised objections against the inclusion and voting rights of some associate and related entities of the personal guarantor who together held about 61.78% voting share in CoC.

As per RP Shiv Nandan Sharma, the personal guarantor's (Mr. Chandra's) estate, in the event of bankruptcy, may not be enough even to cover the expenses of the process. Therefore, the creditors may not be able to get any dividend from the bankruptcy trustee so they had accepted it.

However, a net worth certificate submitted by RBL Bank Ltd. in 2017 showed Mr. Chandra's net worth at $7.17 billion, (₹45,888 crore). Also, separate certificate to Canara Bank in 2018 assessed his net worth at ₹40,562 crore. Suddenly, how he turned poor, wondered creditors.

Canara Bank had opposed the plan stating it constituted only about 0.028% of the value of Mr. Chandra's assets. In 2022, Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd. moved the NCLT in a case involving personal guarantee given by Mr. Chandra for loans of Essel Group companies.

Anil Kumar and Sunil Jain submitted claims on behalf of 960 and 300 individuals from Haryana, Mr. Chandra's native and it was alleged the RP admitted the claims without undertaking any due diligence or inquiry into the relationship of the concerned individuals with Mr. Chandra or examining the manner in which the alleged debts had arisen. After admitting 'unverified and unsubstantiated' claims of entities alleged to be related/associate parties, the RP permitted them in Repayment Plan voting process.

'Related parties'

It was submitted the documents showed the related-party status of Veena Investments, Direct Media Distribution Ventures, World Crest Advisors, Lemonade Capital Advisors and Corpcall Capital Advisors with Mr. Chandra. Despite such material, the RP disregarded the same and instead relied upon Mr. Chandra's contention that following a "family settlement", the entities no longer were related to him.

Meanwhile, Mr. Chandra said he did not borrow money from any lender and was only a personal guarantor.

Insurers can invest in NDB's onshore rupee bonds, says IRDAI

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Insurance regulator IRDAI permitted insurers to invest in Maharajah INR Bonds (Onshore Rupee Bonds) of the New Development Bank (NDB), an approval that assumes significance ahead of next month's BRICS Summit in New Delhi.

It follows representation from the NDB seeking approval, for the NDB Maharajah INR bonds under which it proposes to raise ₹25,000 crore over a five-year period, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) said communicating its approval to the insurers in a circular.

The multilateral development bank, established by Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa (BRICS), intends to use the bond proceeds towards general corporate purposes for financing/onward lending to sustainable development, sustainable infrastructure, green, social projects in India.

"The proposed onshore rupee bond issuances by NDB are covered under the definition of Securities under the Securities Contracts (Regulations) Act, 1956," IRDAI said, explaining it is permitting investments in the same to enable insurers to have more scope for investments. It will be part of the 'approved investments' and subject to the bonds governed by norms, if any, laid by Government of India and SEBI approval among others."

The NDB is a multilateral development bank.

NIT FOR PUBLICATION

Tender No : Zoological Park/06/2026/02

The **Deputy Conservator of Forest, Wildlife Division Hamirpur,** on behalf of Govt. of Himachal Pradesh invites e-tender from firms/contractors/agencies for REQUEST FOR ROPOSAL FOR ENGAGEMENT OF AN AGENCY FOR SOURCING, HANDLING, CRATING, TRANSPORTATION QUARANTINE AND DOCUMENTATION OF ANIMALS FROM INDIA OR ABROAD FOR DURGESHARANYA-KANGRA ZOOLOGICAL PARK DISTRICT KANGRA, HIMACHAL PRADESH, INDIA 2026-27. Interested firms/contractors/agencies engaged in relevant business are eligible to submit their bids. Complete Tender document shall be available on website: https://hptenders.gov.in Intending tenderers are required to register at portal of **e-Tender** of the HP Govt. and participate through the online tender portal only.

1.	Date of downloading tenders	26.08.2026
2.	Last date and time of online submission of Tender	07.09.2026 (10:15 Hours)
3.	Date and time of opening of tender	07.09.2026 (11.15 Hours)

HP / 2962/26-27

Divisional Forest Officer,
Wildlife Division Hamirpur (HP) 177001

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TRIPURA ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION
Bidyut Bhavan Complex, Bhutoria, Banamalipur,
Agartala, Tripura (W), Pin-799001
PRESS NOTICE REGARDING REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

RFP No. TERC/RFP/BID/2026-27/02 Dated: 27/08/2026

Tripura Electricity Regulatory Commission (TERC) invites Technical and Financial Bids from eligible and experienced consultancy firms for providing consultancy and analytical support to TERC on work related to analysis and disposal of Tariff /ARR/True-Up Petition/(s) filed by Tripura State Electricity Corporation Limited (TSECL) (combined for Generation, Transmission & Distribution) for FY 2027-28 and FY 2028-29, along with True-Up for FY 2025-26 and FY 2026-27 and support in regulatory formulation and amendments.

Details of the RFP notice and the bid document is available under Tender ID: 2026_TERC_76362_1 for downloading in the e-procurement platform **https://tripuratenders.gov.in/** w.e.f. 27/08/2026.

Sd/-
Secretary
Tripura Electricity Regulatory Commission
Agartala, Tripura

BHAKRA BEAS MANAGEMENT BOARD

Notice Inviting e-Tender

Name of Office	NIT No. / Name of work	Starting Date (Time) Closing Date (Time)	Estimate Cost/ Earnest Money (Rs.)
Executive Engineer Bhakra Mechanical Division Nangal	**NIT No 79/BM/26** Clearance of drains and wild growth along the railway track from Nangal to Bhakra	26/08/26 at 09:00 Hrs. 07/09/26 at 15:00 Hrs.	Rs. 275177/- Rs. 5504/-
Executive Engineer O&M, Division, BBMB, Delhi.	**E-NIT-11/OMD/ 2026-27 Date:** **20.08.26** Providing CC for raising of existing path between NA block in BBMB complex at 220kV sub-station, BBMB, Delhi	20/08/26 18:00 Hrs. 21/09/26 12:00 Hrs.	Rs. 4,880/- Rs. 4,87,920/-
	E-NIT-12/OMD/ 2026-27 Dated: **26.08.2026** Replacement of damaged door & window alongwith other items in office building & Mtc. of Rest House at 220 KV sub-station, BBMB, Narela	26/08/26 18:00 Hrs. 28/09/26 12:00 Hrs.	Rs. 9,900/- Rs. 9,85,925/-
Sr. Executive Engineer, Nangal. Electrical Division, BBMB (IW) Nangal Township.	**NIT No. 54/2026 /NE** "Replacement of 4 Nos. steel wire rope 34mm dia of floating deck No I & II and 4 Nos. steel wire ropes 20mm dia of 4 Nos Inclined carriage way trollies at Timber rope way section at Bhakra Dam	27/08/26 09:00 Hrs. 28/09/26 15:00 Hrs.	Rs. 4005837.00/- Rs. 81,000.00/-
Executive Engineer, BC & Township Division, BBMB, Nangal Township.	**NIT. No. 902/ 2026/TS.** Repair of Physics, chemistry, bio-lab work at BBMB DAV Public school Nangal.	28/08/26 09:00 A.M. 28/09/26 03:00 P.M.	Rs. 2,18,000/- Rs. 4370.00/-

For detailed NIT/terms & conditions etc. please visit/downloaded from BBMB website **www.bbmb.gov.in, www.etenders.gov.in**
NOTE: if any, Corrigendum, shall be uploaded on website only.

313/PR/Bd Sectt./5 FOR YOUR BETTER TOMORROW SAVE ENERGY TODAY

कार्यालय पुलिस उपायुक्त, मुख्यालय, सोनीपत

मु.न.219 दिनांक 23.08.2026 धारा 127 (6) बी. एन. एस. थाना सैक्टर-27, सोनीपत, जिला सोनीपत।

गुमशुदा की पहचान

नाम- मनीषा।
पति का नाम - ईमरान।
पता - वासी खान कालोनी जिला सोनीपत।
उम्र - 29 वर्ष।
कद - 5 फुट 7 इंच।
हुलिया :- रंग गेंहुआ, लम्बुतरा चेहरा, पतला फुर्तिला शरीर, काले लम्बे बाल, काली आँखे, लम्बी नाक, नाक पर तिल है।
पहनावा - पीले रंग का सुट-सलवार, गुलाबी रंग के चप्पल पहने हुए है।

सर्वसाधारण को सुचित किया जाता है कि दिनांक 21.08.2026 को मनीषा पत्नी ईमरान वासी खान कालोनी जिला सोनीपत, बिना किसी को बताए घर से कहीं चली गयी हैं। अब तक वापिस नही आयी हैं। जिस सम्बन्ध में उपरोक्त मुकदमा थाना में दर्ज रजिस्टर है। अगर किसी को उपरोक्त गुमशुदगी बारे कोई सूचना मिलती हैं तो निम्नलिखित नंबरो पर सुचित करें।

प्रबन्धक थाना मो0 न0 - 7419410535
अनुसंधानकर्ता मो० न०- 8295218800
कन्ट्रोल रुम सोनीपत- 0130-2222903, 100

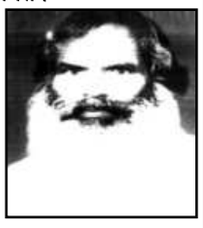
अपराध अभिलेख अधिकारी,
कृते पुलिस उपायुक्त
मुख्यालय, सोनीपत।

1084/11/5252/2027/48678/199/7

कार्यालय पुलिस उपायुक्त, मुख्यालय, सोनीपत

मु.न. 466 दिनांक 20.08.2026 धारा 127 (6) बी. एन. एस. थाना खरखौदा, जिला सोनीपत।

गुमशुदा की पहचान



नाम – सुरेन्द्र सिंह।
पिता का नाम - रणधीर सिंह।
पता - वासी गाँव सैदपुर जिला सोनीपत।
उम्र - 58 वर्ष।
कद - 5 फुट 7 इंच।
हुलिया :- रंग गेहुआ, गोल चेहरा, काली आँखें, काले व सफेद बाल, लम्बी सफेद मुंछ व दाढी।
पहनावा – सफेद रंग का कुर्ता-पायजामा व पैरो मे हवाई चप्पल पहने हुए है।

सर्वसाधारण को सुचित किया जाता है कि दिनांक 18.07.2026 को सुरेन्द्र सिंह पुत्र रणधीर सिंह वासी गाँव सैदपुर जिला सोनीपत अपने घर से गंगोत्री गया था अब तक वापिस नही आया हैं। जिस सम्बन्ध में उपरोक्त मुकदमा थाना में दर्ज रजिस्टर है। अगर किसी को उपरोक्त गुमशुदगी बारे कोई सूचना मिलती हैं तो निम्नलिखित नंबरो पर सुचित करें।

प्रबन्धक थाना मो0 न0 - 7419410536
अनुसंधानकर्ता मो0 न0 – 9729342422
कन्ट्रोल रुम सोनीपत- 0130-2222903,100

अपराध अभिलेख अधिकारी,
कृते पुलिस उपायुक्त।
मुख्यालय, सोनीपत।

1084/11/5251/2027/48677/199/7

NAIROBI

WHO declares Uganda Ebola-free after 42 days without a new case

AFP

Uganda was declared officially Ebola-free by the World Health Organisation on Thursday after 42 days without a new case. The country has been praised for its efforts in preventing the spread of the outbreak that has overwhelmed health facilities in parts of the east of neighbouring Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC). AFP

QAMISHLI

Syrian Kurdish women fighters discuss merger with Turkish govt.

REUTERS

The Syrian Kurdish Women's Protection Units (YPJ) said on Thursday it had discussed with the Interior Ministry integrating their fighters into the government's forces. The announcement came two days after the head of Kurdish fighters in Syria, Mazloum Abdi, announced the dissolution of the Syrian Democratic Forces. AFP

TAIPEI

'China deploys record number of ships around Taiwan last month'

AFP

China deployed a record number of coast guard, scientific research and other ships in Taiwan's waters last month, the island's coast guard said. Taiwan's coast guard warned of an increasingly severe situation, as analysts say the increased activity is part of China's bid to map the region for submarine warfare. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump signs order renaming Lake Ontario as 'Lake America' in U.S.

AFP

President Donald Trump said on Thursday he is renaming Lake Ontario to be known as "Lake America" in the U.S. The Republican President signed an executive order that updated the lake's name for the U.S. geographic naming service. He, however, cannot force Canada to follow his preferred naming convention. AP

Iran executes over 500 people in new surge of hangings: rights group

'The failing Islamic Republic of Iran is killing protesters, even when they are not protesting, at levels not seen before,' says U.S. President Trump; activists accuse Tehran of using capital punishment as a means to intimidate the country's citizens

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Iran has executed over 500 people so far this year after a new surge in hangings in recent days, despite President Donald Trump urging the Islamic republic to halt executions, a rights group said on Thursday.

At least 511 people have been executed so far in 2026, according to Norway-based NGO Iran Human Rights, including at least 29 people in connection with anti-government protests in January.

At least 16 women are among those executed and at least 13 "political prisoners" affiliated with banned opposition groups, it said.

Iranian protesters in Rome condemn the silence of Western governments amid growing political executions in Iran. AFP

Activists accuse Iran of using capital punishment as a means to intimidate the population in the wake of the protests and the war against the United States and Israel that erupted on February 28.

"All executions, regardless of the charges, have a clear domestic purpose – to create fear and prevent new protests," IHR director Mahmood Amiry-Moghaddam said.

"We are very concerned that this trend could worsen in the coming months," he added.

Since wartime executions resumed on March 19, two persons have also been executed in connection with the "Woman. Life. Freedom." protests that erupted in 2022.

Mr. Trump on Tuesday wrote on Truth Social that "the failing Islamic Republic of Iran is not paying large segments of their military, while at the same time killing protesters, even when they are not protesting, at levels not seen before".

'On the table'

Meanwhile, White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said in an interview with *Fox News* on Thursday that the United States and Iran are not currently in talks to end the war as Washington focuses on pressuring Tehran economically, but all options remain "on the table".

"No negotiations are happening right now, and this will continue until the President feels that maybe they come to the table in a meaningful way. We have not seen that yet," she said.

'Massive' Russian strikes hit Ukrainian cities overnight

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia bombarded cities across Ukraine with missiles and drones in an overnight onslaught that ran into the daylight hours of Thursday, when explosions echoed around Kyiv through the morning.

Ukrainian officials say Russia builds up missile stocks and launches major attacks every few days, hoping to exhaust Ukrainian defences through the sheer weight of numbers. In response, Ukraine has hit high-profile targets on Russian soil as the countries inflict mutual destruction.

The Russian Defence Ministry said its forces carried out a "massive" strike on targets in nine Ukrainian cities that began after nightfall on Wednesday. It described the targets as military-related, including industrial facilities, oil refineries, logistics hubs and port infrastructure.

A firefighter tries to extinguish a fire in a destroyed warehouse after Russian drone attacks on the outskirts of Kyiv on Thursday. AP

Civilian areas, including apartment buildings, suffered damage. The barrage killed a 78-year-old woman in the southern Zaporizhzhia region and another person in the northern Kharkiv region, with at least 14 people reported wounded elsewhere, Ukrainian officials said.

"Russia continues to invest in missiles and in expanding its war, and that means more countermeasures are needed," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

U.S. presses NATO allies over boosting Europe defence role

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

A senior Pentagon official pressed NATO allies on Thursday to explain how they were stepping up to meet U.S. demands to take responsibility for Europe's defence as Washington reviews its forces on the continent. President Donald Trump's administration has raised fears among allies that it could cut back its forces in Europe after launching a six-month review in July of its deployments.

"The spirit that we come in is obviously one... of consultation, of engagement. We want to hear from our allies," U.S. Defence Under Secretary Elbridge Colby said on a visit for talks with NATO's headquarters in Brussels.

Elbridge Colby

He said Washington was pushing "to advance and accelerate what's happening, and then to look at the strategic posture at a high level of the U.S. forces in Europe".

Human Rights Watch slams Taliban regime as law bans protest

Agence France-Presse
KABUL

Human Rights Watch slammed on Thursday the "ruthless effort to suppress all dissent" by the Afghan Taliban government, after a new police law banned demonstrations across Afghanistan.

The 84-page legislation published by the Justice Ministry outlines a series of changes to law enforcement nationwide, including the rule that "all types of protests are banned". The new law also extends detention without charge from three days to 10, or even longer by court order.

Elaine Pearson, Asia director for Human Rights Watch, said the measure is "another step in the Taliban's ruthless effort to suppress all dissent".

"The Taliban authorities fear any dissent and so they are escalating their repression," she said in a statement.

Demonstrations have been rare during the Taliban administration's five years in power. At least two people were killed in June when security forces allegedly opened fire at a women's rights protest in the western city of Herat, a group of UN experts said.

Amnesty International described the police law as "another sweeping assault on human rights in Afghanistan".

U.S. designates U.K.-based Palestine Action as a foreign 'terrorist group'

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States on Wednesday named the U.K.-based Palestine Action group, which has been banned by the British government, as a "terrorist" organisation, as the Trump administration intensifies its campaign against left-wing movements.

Set up in 2020, Palestine Action is appealing against the U.K. government ban, which has led to thousands of arrests. Rights groups have decried the ban, saying it was aimed at criminalising dissent. It gained visibility after Israel launched a devastating military campaign in Gaza following the unprecedented October 7, 2023, attack by Palestinian militant group Hamas in southern Israel.

Set up in 2020, Palestine Action is appealing against the U.K. government ban, which has led to thousands of arrests. AP

Wednesday's U.S. action also designated Italy-based Autistici/Inventati (also known as A/I Collective) and the pro-Palestinian group Masar Badil as "terrorist" organisations.

U.S. State Department spokesperson Tommy Piggot declared all three groups, including Palestine Action, as being "violent far-left terrorist groups".

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio described Autistici/Inventati as "a major far-left tech collective whose services are used by the most active and violent Antifa cells in the U.S. and across the world".

Huda Ammori, co-founder of Palestine Action, said that the U.K. ban and the U.S. terror designation "should be a wake-up call to anyone who cares about free speech and civil liberties".

Israel welcomed the decision, with the Foreign Ministry emphasising on X that "terrorist organisations have systematically exploited Western civil society, using political and humanitarian pretences to mask violent operations, radicalise youth, and channel illicit funding".

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2	Pediatric Pulmonology	-	01	01	-	01	01	-	-	-	-	01	-	-	5
3	Pediatric Neurology	01	01	-	-	01	-	-	-	01	01	-	-	-	5
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9	Pediatric Critical Care	-	01	-	-	02	-	01	-	-	-	-	01	-	5
10	Pediatric Emergency	01	01	-	-	01	-	-	-	01	01	-	-	-	5
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DIRECTOR

SOLID TECHNIQUE

Padikkal produced good Test-match batting: Kirsten

PTI

Devdutt Padikkal gained a fan in Gary Kirsten. The Sri Lanka coach said: "I liked the way Padikkal batted. The thing with players, who play multiple formats, is that they tend to replicate the style but Padikkal produced good Test-match batting. His innings at Galle was special, he has a solid game".

IMMOVABLE OBJECT

Dinusha batted really well and hardly offered any chances: Gill

AP

Sonal Dinusha may have frustrated the Indians but skipper Shubman Gill lauded Sri Lanka's latest star. "Dinusha batted really well, he has a good defence, played his shots, swept and drove, hardly offered any chances. We did think about testing him with pace but on this pitch (Colombo) he was comfortable".

REMARKABLE RUN

Dinusha joins Zimbabwe legend Andy Flower in elite club

PTI

Sonal Dinusha became the second player after Andy Flower to register four successive fifty-plus scores against India in a two-Test series. The Sri Lankan also joined Douglas Jardine, Everton Weekes, Clyde Walcott and Ken Barrington as the fifth batter to score fifty-plus scores in the first four Test innings against India.

DETERMINED

Will keep working hard, being in the XI not in my control: Padikkal

AFP

You always want to play. You want to represent your country and keep working hard. That is the only thing in your control. Being in the XI is not in your control. You have to help your teammates whenever you get an opportunity — Devdutt Padikkal after winning the Player-of-the-Series award against Sri Lanka.

Dinusha keeps India at bay, earns Lanka a draw

The left-hander notches up his third hundred in four innings to take the host to safety along with tailenders Nuwantha and Kumara; Gill's men finish with a 1-0 series triumph

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

In the instant gratification that limited overs cricket offers, results oscillate between triumphs and defeats. Tests, though, can yield another conclusion, the stalemate, technically called the draw.

A final verdict that remains inconclusive may be presumed dull, but at times a draw can reveal a glorious fightback and reiterate cricket's philosophical second-skin often whispered as 'glorious uncertainties'.

Sri Lanka precisely did this while snatching a draw in the second Test against India at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground on Thursday. Sonal Dinusha (133 n.o., 264b, 8x4, 2x6) scripted this miracle on the concluding day, as the southpaw's hundred, second in the match, and third in the series, kept the visitor at bay.

Heroic deed: Dinusha led a glorious fightback by Sri Lanka on the final day and thwarted India's victory bid. PTI

The host declared its second innings at 429 for nine, a stunning comeback after conceding a 213-run first innings lead. India had to rest content with a muted series triumph at 1-0 when a 2-0 seemed possible especially after enforcing the follow-on. At one point Mohammed Siraj swapped bails at the striker's end, and it reflected the despair coursing through Shubman Gill's men under the harsh Colombo sun.

In the morning, resuming at 229 for six, Sri Lanka, ahead by a mere 16, found its saviours in Dinusha and Keshara Nuwantha. The duo exhibited synergy and patience while a few miscued shots eluded fielders like Devdutt Padikkal.

Gill switched from spin to pace at both ends as Prasidh Krishna and Siraj operated in tandem. Nuwantha drove Prasidh and after a play-and-miss routine against Siraj, picked two fours off the speedster. When Ravindra Jadeja stepped in, Dinusha feathered one past a diving leg-slip. Soon the batter got to his 50 and after Nuwantha survived an lbw appeal from Jadeja, Sri Lanka moved to 329 for six at lunch.

The first session that yielded 100 without any loss of wickets, meant that Sri Lanka could keep its hopes alive. After the break, Nuwantha (46, 150b, 4x4) pushed forward to left-arm spinner Manav Suthar and edged to Dhruv Jurel at first slip. By then he and Dinusha had added 112 runs for the seventh wicket, constituting a vital part of Sri Lanka's resistance.

Gill attempted a scorched-earth policy against Dinusha. Placing eight fielders on the off-side while Siraj bowled around the off-stump. At times, the field was reversed and then the spearhead pegged away on the leg-side. Wear the Sri Lankans down and trigger a mistake, seemed to be the plan.

Just that Dinusha remained unruffled. He punched Prasidh past sweeper-cover, and then guided Jadeja over mid-wicket. Meanwhile, Prabath Jayasuriya fell to Jadeja, finding Jurel nearby.

A swept four off Suthar helped Dinusha move to 98 and at tea, the host was 383 for eight, reflecting a dour second session in which 54 runs were scored. When the last act commenced, Dinusha gained a brace to etch his ton and then soaked in the robust applause from the stands.

He found a doughty partner in Lahiru Kumara (12, 90b, 1x4). Asitha Fernando too replicated the sturdy-tail act as a draw ushered in.

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS
503 for nine decl. in 138 overs
SRI LANKA — 1ST INNINGS
290 in 89.4 overs
SRI LANKA — 2nd INNINGS
Lahiru Udara c Saransh b Siraj 3 *(15b)*, Kamil Mishara lbw b Jadeja 32 *(39b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Pasindu Sooriyabandara st. Pant b Suthar 92 *(173b, 10x4, 1x6)*, Kamindu Mendis c Gill b Prasidh 55 *(92b, 2x4, 3x6)*, Dhananjaya de Silva c Padikkal b Suthar 23 *(44b, 1x4, 1x6)*, Sonal Dinusha (not out) 133 *(264b, 8x4, 2x6)*, Niroshan Dickwella lbw b Saransh 6 *(12b, 1x4)*, Keshara Nuwantha c Jurel b Suthar 46 *(150b, 4x4)*, Prabath Jayasuriya c Jurel b Jadeja 2 *(28b)*, Lahiru Kumara c Jaiswal b Jadeja 12 *(90b, 1x4)*, Asitha Fernando (not out) 0 *(24b)*; Extras (b-7, lb-8, nb-7, w-3): 25; Total (for nine wkts. decl. in 154 overs): 429.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-5 (Udara, 3.3 overs), 2-63 (Mishara, 14.5), 3-178 (Kamindu, 43.1), 4-209 (Dhananjaya, 58.5), 5-212 (Sooriyabandara, 60.3), 6-218 (Dickwella, 64.2), 7-330 (Nuwantha, 104.4), 8-355 (Prabath, 116.3), 9-402 (Kumara, 144.4).

INDIA BOWLING
Prasidh 18.3-3-57-1, Siraj 15-7-26-1, Suthar 41-7-121-3, Saransh 37-4-98-1, Jadeja 38.3-4-94-3, Gill 2-0-8-0, Jaiswal 1-0-9-0, Jurel 1-0-1-0.
Second Test drawn.
India won two-match series 1-0.
Player-of-the-Match: Dinusha.
Player-of-the-Series: Padikkal.

Gill defends decision to enforce follow-on

One that got away: Gill termed the draw a disappointment. AFP

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

Ever since V.V.S. Laxman and Rahul Dravid ambushed Australia at the Eden Gardens in 2001, most skippers are wary about asking the rival team to bat again. But there are exceptions and Shubman Gill, goaded by the whimsical rains in the Sri Lankan capital, had no hesitation in enforcing the follow-on.

However, the men from the Emerald Isle, admirably guided by centurion Sonal Dinusha gained a hard-fought draw in the second Test here at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground. Gill, though, felt that given the match-situation, his decision was fine. "I would not say it (follow-on) backfired. We were also anticipating (wet) weather on day four and five. But you have to take the best decision possible in that situation," Gill told the media here on Thursday.

Explaining the strategy, the Indian skipper said: "We attacked in the beginning but as the match went on, the pitch got slower. As a batter, if you know that bowlers do not have two modes of dismissal (bowled and lbw) in play, then it becomes easier to bat. We tried our best but they also batted really well. It was obviously disappointing."

Looking back at the series, Gill drew heart from the performances of some players: "Devdutt (Padikkal) did really well. And Manav (Suthar), technically this is his first full series, did well. Prasidh (Krishna) has been the pick of our bowlers, been our go-to bowler and created chances. Overall we played good cricket."

WTC final hopes

And as for a chance in the ICC World Test Championship final, Gill leant on hope: "I still think we have a pretty good chance to qualify. If we play the New Zealand series well and then hopefully when Australia comes, we just have to win that series".

Smith, Cox shine for England on opening day

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Jamie Smith and Jordan Cox both scored fifties as England recovered from a top-order collapse against Pakistan to reach 248 for nine when bad light ended Thursday's opening day of the second Test at Lord's.

Veteran paceman Mohammad Abbas took three wickets for four runs off 16 balls, including the prized scalp of England captain Joe Root for just four, as the host slumped to 36 for three after Pakistan won the toss in helpful conditions for seam bowling.

But Smith's 61 and Cox's 55 got England back into the game.

Abbas claimed four for 56 while fellow seamer Mohammad Ali scalped three for 67.

The scores: England 248/9 in 56 overs (Cox 55, Smith 61, Abbas 4/56) vs. Pakistan. **Toss:** Pakistan.

Alcaraz and Sabalenka handed tough draw

Hands full: Stiff challenges await holder Sabalenka. GETTY IMAGES

US OPEN

Reuters
TORONTO

Defending US Open champion Carlos Alcaraz faces a challenging road to the New York final while Aryna Sabalenka will also have her hands full in her bid for a three-peat, following Thursday's draw.

Alcaraz, who is returning to singles action after sitting out five months with a wrist injury, landed in the stronger bottom half of the men's draw along with former champions Novak Djokovic, Daniil Medvedev, Stan Wawrinka and Marin Cilic.

The Spanish second seed will start against Roman Safiullin.

On the women's side, top seed Sabalenka will play Colombian Camila Osorio in her opening match and faces a potential quarterfinal clash with reigning Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova and a semifinal showdown with an in-form Jessica Pegula.

Indian women down Germany for best finish since inaugural edition

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

Relevance for World Cup classification matches is a matter of perspective. For this Indian women's team, which suffered a heartbreaking exit in its push for a semifinal berth, a best-ever finish since the inaugural 1974 edition was at stake.

Having picked itself up to go again, this side earned itself a small piece of history by finishing fifth with a 3-1 win over Germany here at the Wagener Stadion on Thursday.

It was a counter-attacking clinic as goals from Ishika and Navneet Kaur in the second half subdued the World No. 5 ranked side.

Starting the tournament ranked ninth, Sjoerd Marijne's India exceeded expectations in the Netherlands, pulling off draws against China (ranked fourth), England (seventh) and Australia (eighth) to add to this result.

Time for cheer: The Indian women's team is a happy bunch after beating Germany. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA

It will now head into the Asian Games next month, confident of challenging for the gold.

After a passive start, Germany came alive in the second quarter, making multiple circle entries without threatening India's goal. But it was India which shaded Germany for attempts on goal, when Navneet's powerful backhanded drive drew a save from Finja Starck. Salima Tete was alive to a couple of rebounds but Starck kicked them both out.

Germany continued to dominate possession for majority of the game, but the Indian defence, which included tournament debutant, Lalthantluangi, held firm.

Then, against the run of play, India opened the scoring after Neha slipped a through ball for Ishika, who composed herself before lifting the ball past Starck for her first World Cup goal.

India found plenty of joy through Germany's centre, repeatedly catching its defence out on the counter. After having gone three games without a goal, India suddenly scored three in the space of four minutes.

After going cold from PCs in previous outings, Navneet struck from India's second short corner before she added another with a cool flick into the roof of the net from another turnover.

Germany persevered in the last stretch with Savita Punia needing to pull off a couple of key saves, but she couldn't keep out Lynn Krings' effort with 67 seconds left on the clock.

The result:
India 3 (Ishika 42, Navneet Kaur 43-pc, 46) bt Germany 1 (Lynn Krings 58).

PSG to face Barca, City, Villa in UCL

Agence France-Presse
MONACO

Two-time defending champion Paris Saint-Germain was handed meetings with Barcelona, Manchester City and Aston Villa among its eight matches in the league phase of this season's Champions League, as the draw took place on Thursday.

PSG will play Barcelona, Roma, Turkish champion Galatasaray and Slovan Bratislava of Slovakia at home.

Luis Enrique's team will travel to England twice to face City and Villa. The French champion will also go to Spain to play Villarreal and Italy to take on Como.

The first matches in the league phase will be played between September 8 and September 10, with the final games in late January. The UEFA is expected to announce the full fixture schedule on Saturday.

INBRIEF

Wawrinka handed US Open wildcard after outcry

Switzerland's Stan Wawrinka has been granted a last-minute wildcard to compete in US Open singles next week, organisers announced on Wednesday, following controversy and fan outcray over the 2016 champion's omission. The three-time singles Grand Slam winner would replace Patrick Kypson who withdrew with injury. The original snub had sparked criticism from former champion Andy Roddick.

Real routs Sociedad as Mbappe nets hat-trick

Kylian Mbappe scored a brilliant hat-trick to help Real Madrid thrash Real Sociedad 4-1 in LaLiga in Jose Mourinho's first home match back at the Santiago Bernabeu as the club's coach. Real made it two wins from two with Vinicius Junior also on the scoresheet.

The results: Real Madrid 4 (Mbappe 40, 60, 80, Vinicius 68) bt Real Sociedad 1 (Sucic 44). **On Tuesday:** Valencia 0 lost to Real Betis 1 (Garcia 83).

Velavan stuns Eain, meets Chotrani in the semifinal

Eighth seed Velavan Senthilkumar, *in pic.*, stunned World No. 18 Eain Yow Ng in the Budapest Open squash quarterfinals, a $43,500 PSA Copper event. Velavan defeated the top seed 11-2, 11-9, 11-8 to set up a semifinal clash with Veer Chotrani, who defeated Egyptian sixth seed Mohamed Elsherbini 14-12, 12-14, 11-6, 11-8.

GCT finale: Praggnanandhaa lets Caruana off the hook

R. Praggnanandhaa missed out on a great opportunity to level scores, signing peace with Fabiano Caruana of United States in the second game of the grand finale of Grand Chess Tour in St. Louis (USA). After nearly outplaying the top seed, the Indian lost his way towards the end and had to settle for a draw. He had lost the first game of the finale to the American. The scoreline now reads 3-9 for Pragg and he can make a comeback in the rapid and blitz games that follow.

The results: R. Praggnanandhaa 3 drew with Fabiano Caruana (USA) 9; Wesley So (USA) 6 drew with Vincent Keymer (Ger) 6.

LIVE TELECAST

Hockey World Cup: Men: Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 1 p.m. 2.30, 4, 5.30, 6.30, 9.30; India vs Belgium, 9.45 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Saturday).

England vs Pakistan: Second Test, Day 2, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.

Europa League (league-phase draw): Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4.30 p.m.

T20I tri-series: Namibia vs South Africa, FanCode, 5.30 p.m.

TNPL (final): Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube @www.tamilnadupremierleague.com), 7.30 p.m.

Women's T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.

US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m.

Bundesliga: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.00 a.m. (Saturday).

Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.15 a.m. (Saturday).

Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 12.30 a.m. (Saturday).

LaLiga: FanCode, 1 a.m. (Saturday).

Muchova and Mensik have the last laugh

The duo, which won its maiden Grand Slam crown, saved two match points in the semifinal before bouncing back from a second set blip in the summit clash to beat Bencic and Cobolli

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Czech mates: Mensik and Muchova came through two tough matches before taking the top honours. AP

The Czech team of Karolina Muchova and Jakub Mensik won the US Open mixed doubles on Wednesday, saving two match points in a nervy semifinal and then pulling through in a tight final.

Pummelling

The pair survived a second-set pummelling in the championship decider to overcome Belinda Bencic of Switzerland and Flavio Cobolli of Italy, 6-3, 1-6, [10-6].

Earlier, a Mensik ace saved one of two match points when the Czech pair edged the Russians Mirra Andreeva and Andrey Rublev, 5-4, 3-5, [11-9].

The back-to-back wins secured the first Grand Slam title for both Mensik and Muchova, who lost a heartbreaking Wimbledon singles final in July in three sets to fellow Czech, Linda Noskova.

"At the end the matching outfits made the difference for us," Muchova quipped during the trophy presentation, referencing the white and maroon kit worn by the team.

Cobolli and Bencic had beaten the married team of Elina Svitolina of Ukraine and Gael Monfils of France in a hard-fought marathon, 4-5, 4-1, [10-5] in the other last four clash.

The results: Final: Muchova & Mensik (Cze) bt Bencic (Sui) & Cobolli (Ita) 6-3, 1-6, [10-6].

Semifinals: Bencic & Cobolli bt Monfils (Fra) & Svitolina (Ukr) 4-5(7), 4-1, [10-5]; Muchova & Mensik bt Rublev & Andreeva 5-4(6), 3-5, [11-9].

Queens beat Strikers narrowly for their first win

Crucial runs: Monika's 47 boosted Queens' total.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

DPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Central Delhi Queens registered its first win of the women's leg of the Delhi Premier League by beating North Delhi Strikers by three runs at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Thursday.

Queens had lost their opening three games of the T20 competition.

Batting first, Queens rode on Monika's contribution of 47 to post a middling 125 for seven in 20 overs.

For Strikers, Apeksha Anand was the pick of the bowlers with figures of four for 17.

Strikers began their response solidly as Shivi Sharma and Ayushi Soni added 45 runs for the second wicket.

Shivi went on to make 36 off 33 balls while Ayushi contributed 51 off 40 balls. Once they were dismissed, though, Strikers fell apart.

For Queens, Sumiti Soni, Nidhi Mahto and Deeksha Sharma picked a wicket each.

The scores: Central Delhi Queens 125/7 in 20 overs (Monika 47, Apeksha Anand 4/17) bt North Delhi Strikers 122/5 in 20 overs (Shivi Sharma 36, Ayushi Soni 51).

Yastika and Anushka named captains for India-A in the series against Australia-A

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Anushka Sharma will captain India-A in the three-match T20 series while Yastika Bhatia will lead the one-day and multi-day teams as the BCCI women's selection committee on Thursday announced the squads for Australia-A's upcoming tour of the country.

Sayali Satghare will be Anushka's deputy in the T20s while Anushka will serve as vice-captain to Yastika in both the one-day and multi-day formats.

Yastika will lead the one-day and multi-day squads.
FILE PHOTO

The tour starts on September 12 and comprises three T20s, three one-day matches and a four-day multi-day fixture. The T20 series will be played in New Chandigarh, the One-Day matches at the PCA Stadium in Mohali and the multi-day game in Dharamshala.

The T20s will be played on September 12, 15 and 17 in New Chandigarh.

The one-day matches are scheduled for September 20, 23 and 25 in Mohali, while the four-day multi-day fixture will be played from September 29 to October 2 in Dharamshala.

The squads:

T20s: Anushka Sharma (Capt.), Sayali Satghare (Vice-capt.), Vrinda Dinesh, Sujata Dey, Tejal Hasabnis, Nikki Prasad, Shipra Giri (wk), Shweta Sehrawat, Uma Chetry (wk), Tanuja Kanwer, Minnu Mani, Vaishnavi Sharma, Jintimani Kalita, Shabnam Shakeel, Simran Dil Bahadur.

One-dayers: Yastika Bhatia (Capt. & wk), Anushka (Vice-capt.), Vrinda, Priya Punia, Tanisha Singh, Tejal, Nikki, Uma, Minnu, Amandeep Kaur, Vaishnavi, Sayali, Jintimani, Shabnam, Akshita Bhagat.

Multi-day: Yastika (Capt.), Anushka (Vice-capt.), Shubha Satheesh, Priya, Tanisha, Tejal, Nikki, Mamata Madiwala (wk), Sushree Dibyadarshini, Shuchi Upadhyay, Vaishnavi, Sayali, Jintimani, Shabnam, Akshita.

The schedule:

T20s: September 12, 15 and 17, New Chandigarh.

One-dayers: September 20, 23 and 25, Mohali.

Multi-day: September 29 to October 2, Dharamshala.

Anvay Dravid, Aaryavir Sehwag in India under-19 one-day squad

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Rahul Dravid and Virender Sehwag's sons, Anvay and Aaryavir respectively, were on Thursday included in the India under-19 squad for the one-day series against Australia, beginning September 18.

The BCCI selection committee picked separate contingents for the three one-day matches and two multi-day games, with Lakshya Raichandani set to lead the white-ball side and Yashbardhan Chauhan named captain for the longer-format fixtures.

Both Anvay and Aaryavir are only part of the one-day squad. It is a maiden India call-up for 18-year-old Aaryavir, who is playing in the Delhi Premier League.

Anvay and Aaryavir... following in their fathers' footsteps.

The squads:

One-dayers: Lakshya Raichandani (Capt.), Yashbardhan Chauhan (Vice-capt.), Rajat Baghel (wk), Aaryavir Sehwag, V.K. Vineet, Kushagra Ojha, Arjun Rajput, Manal Chauhan, Anvay Dravid (wk), V. Yashveer, Rohit Yadav, Shavin Vinodh, Mohit Ulva, Chigurupati Venkata, and Kavya Patel.

Multi-day: Yashbardhan Chauhan (Capt.), Lakshya Raichandani (Vice-capt.), Sagar Virk, Kushagra Ojha, Manal Chauhan, Kush Patel, Manav Krishna (wk), Abhipray Biswas (wk), Rohit Yadav, Ishan Om, Ayaan Akram, Pranav Ragavendra, Priyanshu Singh, Mohit Ulva, and Aryan Yadav.

The schedule: One-dayers: Sept. 18, 21 & 23 (all at Rajkot); **Multi-day:** Sept. 27 to 30 (Rajkot), Oct. 5 to 8 (Ahmedabad).

Divya excited about her GCL debut

Sports Bureau

Divya Deshmukh, the women's World Cup winner, is looking forward to her maiden Global Chess League. She will play for Alpine Pipers in the fourth edition of the GCL, beginning in Bengaluru on September 5.

Her teammates include the World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen and fellow Indian Arjun Erigaisi.

"It's my debut, so I'm definitely very excited," Divya said.

"It's not like any other chess tournament. There's going to be a lot of audience for this one, which is really nice. Playing in India is always fun."

Divya is also keen to explore GCL's format. "I can't say anything about the format now. This is going to be my first event in Bengaluru. I have only been to the Bengaluru airport before."

Divya. FLICKR

The GCL, a joint venture between Tech Mahindra and global chess governing body FIDE, will be held at Lalit Ashok and conclude on September 13.

India vs Uruguay friendly in Kolkata on Oct. 6

FOOTBALL

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

The Salt Lake Stadium will host two-time World Cup champion Uruguay in an international friendly on October 6.

The fixture will be India's third high-profile international friendly during the FIFA window, the All India Football Federation announced on Thursday.

India will begin the series against Panama in Bengaluru on September 26 before facing five-time world champion Brazil in Kolkata on October 3.

Uruguay's visit will complete the run of three matches against three Latin American World Cup-playing nations within the same international window.

Uruguay, one of the most decorated teams in international football, is currently ranked 20th in the FIFA World Ranking.

The Uruguay match will provide Indian football fans the opportunity to watch another top football nation just three days after the highly anticipated Brazil encounter at the same venue.

Aaryavir's confidence stands out, says DPL coach Gupte

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

The surname is Sehwag. There are shades of his famous father in his ability to carve the ball through the off-side.

Ever since Aaryavir Sehwag held a cricket bat seriously, he has had high expectations to meet. On Thursday, the 18-year-old, the elder son of Virender Sehwag, took a significant step in his development by earning a call-up into the India under-19 squad for three one-dayers against Australia in Rajkot in September.

Interestingly, Anvay Dravid, the younger son of Rahul Dravid, has also been picked in the squad.

Aaryavir was most recently involved with the West Delhi Lions in the third edition of the Delhi Premier League. The young opener featured in two games and scored just 24 runs this season, but Aaryavir's confidence and infectious energy stayed intact throughout.

"He was in the selection loop throughout. He was playing very well in the nets. He doesn't have a lot of T20 experience. There were senior players who had done well in the opening slots. So we went with them, but Aaryavir came in later," West Delhi Lions head coach Udey Gupte told *The Hindu*.

"When he came on as a substitute fielder for an over in one match, two batters got out. He came back and told me, 'Look, what happened in one over. If I get to play a match, look at what I do.' His confidence stands out."

Aaryavir relishes the slightest width outside off-stump. "He generally looks to play with a straight bat. When he gets any width, he slashes it over point and cover just like *Viru* used to do," the 69-year-old observed.

In 2024, Aaryavir smashed 297 for Delhi against Meghalaya in the u-19 Cooch Behar Trophy.

PTI, AP & AFP

Series victory fails to mask grey areas as India prepares for daunting challenges

Padikkal blossomed, Jurel showed his worth and Prasidh hit his stride in the Emerald Isle; however, the tour exposed a thinning spin cupboard

R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

How often does a draw feel like a defeat? And a stalemate assume the hue of a victory? Often enough, Shubman Gill will insist.

Despite their own uneasy recent dalliance with the five-day format, India would have fancied their chances of bearding the Sri Lankan lion in its own den in a two-Test series that is pretty much the norm when the world's most sought-after side isn't playing against Australia or England.

India hadn't lost a series in this country since 2008 and arrived early this month sitting on a five-Test winning streak on Sri Lankan soil. Even though their last visit was in 2017, they had reason to believe the hosts were ripe for the taking.

Significant result

The script seemed to be holding true. Notwithstanding pockets of defiance from their young guns, led by the exceptional Sonal Dinusha, Sri Lanka slumped to a 185-run rout in Galle in the first Test. The result assumed a more significant hue because India were without two-fifths of their first-choice bowling attack – Jasprit Bumrah and Washington Sundar were missing through injuries – but still won a rain-hit encounter with quite a bit to spare.

There was excellent reason, therefore, to aspire for a 2-0 sweep ahead of the second Test at the SSC ground. Sri Lanka, already without Pathum Nissanka and Kusal Mendis, were dealt another unkind cut when Dinesh Chandimal was ruled out of the second Test after hurting his neck while fielding in Galle. But as it turned out, his replacement, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, had a great game at the SSC, desperately unlucky to miss out of centuries in both innings.

Dinusha delights

Dinusha, however, ensured that a similar fate didn't befall him. Ahead of this series, the 25-year-old left-hander had played just three Tests but had showcased his ability and his temperament, not least in the Caribbean in June-July when he reeled off a sequence of 43, 12 not out, 92 and 28 in the two Tests.

It should have been fair warning well heeded; it will be presumptuous to say that India didn't pay much attention to the young man, but they didn't crack the Dinusha puzzle throughout the series, which is one of the main reasons they had to settle for a 1-0 scoreline despite dominating the second Test too for large stretches.

Dinusha batted for a little less than 20 hours in making 420 runs from 722 deliveries, the single point of difference as the Lankans ground out a fabulous draw after being forced to follow on in the second Test.

It wasn't all doom and gloom from an Indian point of view. Devdutt Padikkal grabbed his chances with both hands in his first Tests in more than 20 months. In the absence of Sai Sudharsan, he took giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games.

The volume of runs was impressive, but so was his presence in the middle. In further signs of his evolution as a dependable, oftentimes aggressive all-format batter, he treated the bowling with just about the respect it deserved, using the offside as his preferred area of scoring and looking equally comfortable against pace and spin.

India will find it very hard to look beyond him for the one-drop position when they play two Tests in New Zealand in November. After all, how can you overlook the credentials of someone as consistent as the Karnataka left-hander was in Sri Lanka?

And then, there was Dhruv Jurel, justifying the faith of the Gautam Gambhir-led think-tank which was sure that the wicketkeeper-batter was the answer to their prayers for a dependable middle-order batter who could play spin with soft hands, deftness of feet and no gremlins of self-doubt.

Assured batting

Alongside Sai Sudharsan and Padikkal, Jurel was one of the three batters Gambhir was keen should be a part of the India 'A' side that arrived on these shores for a shadow tour towards the end of June. Admittedly, neither Galle nor the SSC was a rank turner like Kolkata had been against South Africa in November, but Jurel didn't put a foot wrong either in front of the stumps – he had a half-century in the first Test which he topped with his second ton in the next – or behind it when Rishabh Pant sat out much of the Sri Lankan first innings in Colombo with an assortment of blows to his body.

K.L. Rahul was dependable without going big while Pant was, well, Pant – exhilarating, unpredictable, entertaining and compelling. Maybe Gill will be a little disappointed that he didn't join the list of centurions, but his batting looked in decent order, as did Yashasvi Jaiswal's even if he found novel ways of courting dismissals.

Then, there was Prasidh Krishna. Ahead of the series, Gill was asked if he had a difficult choice to make between the Karnataka pacer and the uncapped Gurnoor Brar as Mohammed Siraj's new-ball partner. The skipper barely batted an eyelid when he said that Prasidh was bowling the best with the red ball that he had ever seen him, and the strapping quick didn't disappoint.

Even on the placid decks on offer, he worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest. When he pitched the ball up, there was movement which, allied with pace in the region of 140 kmph, made him a tricky proposition.

Up for the challenge

Prasidh was up for any challenge, including doing the dirty job of trying to soften up the batters with his shortish length, and is shaping up into an excellent support act for Bumrah and Siraj. India will need their pacers to fire on all cylinders when they go to New Zealand, so from that perspective, the development of Prasidh is perhaps the single greatest takeaway for the decision-making group from this three-week sojourn to the Emerald Isle.

But there are worrying signs aplenty too, not least when it comes to back-up spin options. Despite starting his Test career with so much promise in New Chandigarh when he took six wickets in the first innings against Afghanistan, and despite his ten-wicket match haul in Galle, Manav Suthar is still very much a work in progress.

In Colombo, his craft had to play second fiddle to the slowness of the SSC strip; there was bounce aplenty, which took bowled and leg before out of the equation, but the left-arm spinner was slow to respond when the Sri Lankan batters resorted to the sweep and the reverse sweep.

It might appear a touch harsh on someone who was only playing in his third Test, but this is an early education for Suthar and he will do well to heed the lessons if he aspires to step into the shoes of Ravindra Jadeja going forward and become the lead bowler around whom the Indian spin attack will revolve in the future.

Debut to forget

While Suthar did show signs of promise, Saransh Jain had a disappointing debut – and there is no way to sugarcoat that. On the radar of those involved in talent-identification and selection matters for a while now, Jain is an experienced hand at 33, with more than 50 first-class appearances under his belt for various outfits.

His first delivery in Test cricket was a no-ball, which can perhaps be put down to nerves, but he bowled six more of them across the two innings, which couldn't have pleased anyone, least of all new spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule. But it wasn't just the no-balls that were grating. While he did show reasonable control, the threat quotient was barely perceptible.

Saransh wouldn't have been here if Washington was available but as a fallback alternative, he has a long way to go. In some ways, it points to a slight thinning of resources in the spin cupboard, which ought to worry those in the corridors of power because for so long now, India have got used to having the now-retired R. Ashwin and Jadeja to spin their webs of deception and lure batters to their doom.

After a lull, India have plenty of fast-bowling options to summon despite Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep and Harshit Rana and Nitish Kumar Reddy spending a lot of time in the infirmary. But for the traditional land of spin to struggle to unearth an incisive off-spinner is a little hard to fathom and harder still to digest.

Jain deserves the benefit of doubt – after all, this was Test No. 1 and maybe he did have the proverbial ordinary one-off game – but for him to set himself up as a semi-long-term option, there must be obvious signs of improvement.

This tour in general, and the second Test particularly, was a steep learning curve for the captain. It's been a little over 14 months since Gill first led the Test team, in England in Leeds last June. Captaincy looks simple from the outside but entails plenty of decision-making on the fly, even in Test cricket, without second-guessing oneself.

He was handicapped by a rapidly softening ball in Galle and by an SSC surface that had bounce but hardly any pace. Some of the fields he employed were strange, there was a definite occasional slant towards passivity, and the move to almost ignore trying to get Dinusha out on the final day of the series and target the other end was little short of self-defeating.

Mixed run

Gill has had a mixed run as captain – 2-2 in England, 2-0 at home against West Indies, defeat in his only Test against South Africa in Kolkata when he faced a mere three deliveries before contracting a neck injury, a hammering of Afghanistan and now this 1-0 success in Sri Lanka, his first overseas victory as skipper.

The journey has been challenging and exciting, but daunting outings lie in store in the red-ball version before he starts to focus exclusively on the 50-over format ahead of the World Cup in southern Africa in the second half of next year.

India haven't won a Test in New Zealand since 2009 when Mahendra Singh Dhoni led them to a famous series triumph, and their last visit in 2020 was an unmitigated disaster as they were soundly beaten in both matches.

New Zealand will test the technique and the character of the batting group with its seam-friendly conditions, after which Australia will come calling for five Tests in India. Gill must be on top of his game – as lead batter and as leader – and towards that end, Sri Lanka was a timely, useful wake-up call.

THE GIST

- Padikkal has taken giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games at Galle and Colombo
- Even on the placid decks on offer, Prasidh worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest
- Jurel has emerged as a dependable middle-order batter who can play spin with soft hands and deftness of feet without any self-doubt
- Dinusha's patient and purposeful batting was one of the reasons India was unable to make the second Test its own

The changing face of skin lightening practices in India

The language around skin lightening has changed, but the desire for it has remained strong in India; a lot of the advertisement and marketing has now moved online; the country needs strong legislation, campaigns to educate patients, pharmacists and healthcare professionals, and a conversation that shifts the focus to skin health, not colour

Monisha Madhumita

The language of fairness may be changing, but the desire for lighter skin has not necessarily disappeared in our country. As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate.

Skin lightening in India is changing. The fairness creams that once dominated advertisements are less visible today. The language around them has also shifted. Words such as 'brightening', 'glow', 'de-tan' and 'even tone' are now common across skincare products and digital platforms.

For dermatologists, this change is increasingly visible in clinical practice.

Patients may not come to the clinic saying that they have been trying to become fairer. They often present because something has already gone wrong. There may be acne, redness, thinning of the skin, increased facial hair, pigmentation or infections. Oral agents used with the expectation of achieving lighter skin are also being sought.

"We see patients because of the side-effects of what they have tried, and then work backwards," says Rashmi Sarkar, head and director - professor, department of dermatology Vardhman Mahavir Medical College and Safdarjung hospital, New Delhi.

The profile is changing too. What was once viewed largely as a concern among women is now also seen among men, teenagers and transgender persons. This makes skin lightening an important skin-health issue, rather than simply a cosmetic concern.

Not all treatment that reduces pigmentation is skin lightening.

Melasma and post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation are common pigmentary disorders. They can be persistent and distressing, particularly in darker skin tones. These conditions may require treatment. The important distinction, Dr. Sarkar says, is between treating a pigmentary disorder and attempting to lighten a person's normal, constitutive skin colour. This distinction is becoming less clear to consumers.

A product described as 'brightening' may be intended to reduce pigmentation, improve dullness or make the skin appear more even. The term itself does not explain what is being changed.

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person's natural skin colour.

Digital shift

The larger change is taking place online.

Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media.

Need for regulation: Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media. GETTY IMAGES

Algorithms can amplify these messages. A person who watches one video on pigmentation may subsequently be shown repeated content around brightening products, supplements, peels or procedures. Filters and image manipulation add another layer. Photographs can be altered to make skin appear lighter, smoother or more uniform. Artificial intelligence can make these alterations increasingly difficult to recognise.

Dr. Sarkar believes public education, must therefore, also address digital literacy. People need to learn to recognise filtered or manipulated images and to question the aesthetic standards repeatedly presented to them online.

The impact is particularly relevant for younger users. Repeated exposure can gradually alter what is perceived as normal skin and what is considered a problem requiring correction.

Excessive treatment

The growth of aesthetic skincare has also widened the number of places where people seek treatment.

Patients may move between dermatology clinics, aesthetic centres, salons, spas, social media and online marketplaces. The distinction between medical treatment and cosmetic marketing can become unclear.

Dr. Sarkar stresses that pigmentary disorders should be assessed by qualified dermatologists. Procedures also need to be selected carefully and patients should not be overtreated. This is particularly relevant in darker skin tones, where inflammation caused by aggressive treatment can itself lead to further pigmentation. The treatment can then become part of the problem.

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early.

The health consequences can be significant. The International League of Dermatological Societies (ILDS) has warned that the misuse of potent topical corticosteroids in skin-bleaching products can contribute to treatment-resistant fungal infections, irreversible skin damage and systemic side-effects. The organisation has called for stronger regulation, clearer guidance and better public education.

Beyond the clinic

The response to skin lightening therefore also needs to change.

Traditional awareness campaigns remain important, but they may no longer be sufficient when much of the contemporary conversation is taking place online. This is a particular focus of the ILDS Strategic Working Group on Skin Bleaching. The group brings together international dermatology expertise to address harmful skin-lightening practices while also recognising the legitimate need for safe, evidence-based treatment of pigmentary disorders.

The message, says Dr. Sarkar, who is part of the working group, needs to reach people where these practices are now being discussed and promoted. "We need to leverage social media and amplify the message," she says. This includes closer collaboration between the ILDS and national dermatology societies, as well as engagement with pharmacists, educators and credible public voices.

India has previously seen organised campaigns around inappropriate topical steroid use. These efforts included education of both patients and pharmacists. A similar approach is now needed for contemporary skin-lightening practices.

The ILDS initiative also has a wider aim: to move the conversation away from skin colour as an aesthetic hierarchy and towards skin health. The message is simple, but important. Healthy skin exists in every shade.

For those experimenting with skincare routines, particularly skin lightening, it means understanding the difference between a pigmentary disorder and normal skin colour. It means recognising that medicines used without appropriate supervision can damage the skin. It means knowing that repeated procedures are not always better treatment. Increasingly, it also means understanding that the images seen online may have been filtered, lightened or otherwise altered.

Regulation will need to evolve alongside this change. Looking only for products explicitly labelled as 'fairness' products will miss part of the contemporary market. Claims, ingredients, digital advertising, influencer marketing and access to potent medicines all require attention. But regulation alone cannot address the deeper issue.

Greater awareness has made overt fairness advertising less acceptable. Yet, as Dr. Sarkar points out, social perceptions around skin colour continue to persist. The challenge is therefore no longer only the fairness cream. The people seeking these interventions are also changing. The response now needs to change with them.

For dermatologists, professional societies and public-health organisations, the opportunity lies in moving beyond treating complications after they occur. The focus must be on prevention, evidence-based care, digital education and a clearer understanding of what healthy skin actually means.

(Dr. Monisha Madhumita is a consultant dermatologist at Saveetha Medical College, Chennai. mail.monisha.m@gmail.com)

THE GIST

As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person's natural skin colour

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early

Salmonella infections: why India needs to look beyond typhoid and diarrhoea

Athira Elssa Johnson

Salmonella is often linked to food poisoning, diarrhoea and typhoid. But the infection can range from mild gastroenteritis that gets better on its own to a serious bloodstream infection, and therefore, say experts, deserves more attention than it is currently being given.

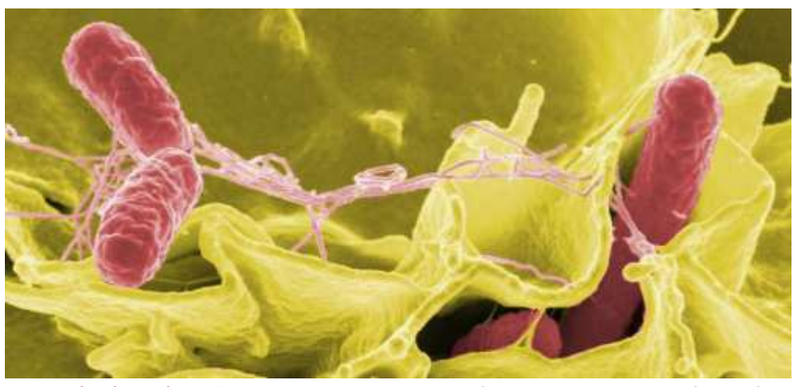
Salmonella is a group of bacteria that can cause different infections. Typhoid and paratyphoid or enteric fever, are caused by Salmonella Typhi and Salmonella Paratyphi. The problem, however, is broader than typhoid. Non-typhoidal Salmonella infections, which often cause gastroenteritis, may go undiagnosed because many people recover without testing. At the same time, antibiotic resistance is making serious infections harder to treat.

Why infections turn serious

Non-typhoidal Salmonella commonly causes gastroenteritis, with diarrhoea, stomach cramps, fever and sometimes vomiting. It is often linked to poultry, eggs and other animal-based foods. Most healthy people recover with supportive care, but the infection can become serious and spread to the bloodstream. "Salmonella should not be seen as only a cause of diarrhoea," said Sweatha Kumar, associate consultant, infectious diseases, Rela Hospital, Chennai. "In some patients, especially young children, older adults and those living with other illnesses or weakened immunity, it can become invasive and life-threatening."

Suresh Kumar D., senior specialist in infectious diseases, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai, said the actual burden of non-typhoidal Salmonella is difficult to estimate as many mild infections are never diagnosed.

Both typhoid and non-typhoidal Samonella infections spread through the faecal-oral route, but their sources are different. For typhoid, humans are the reservoir. Non-typhoidal Salmonella has a wider ecology, involving animals, food and the environment. Poultry, eggs, meat and other animal-derived foods can be sources. Transmission can also occur when raw meat contaminates ready-to-eat food during preparation.



Preventing infections: Typhoid conjugate vaccines, safer water and sanitation, food safety and antimicrobial stewardship all have a role in reducing infections. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

"Contamination can occur at multiple points, from farms, slaughterhouses and food processing to transportation, storage, restaurants and finally the household kitchen," Dr. Sweatha said. "That is why Salmonella is very much a One Health problem involving humans, animals, food and the environment."

Food handlers can play an important role in transmission, as those carrying the infection can contaminate food and potentially expose many people to the bacteria. But food safety cannot depend only on individual food handlers. The wider system needs better training, sanitation, refrigeration, monitoring and enforcement. While the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India has surveillance and testing systems, gaps remain, particularly in the large informal food sector.

At the household level, it is important follow: washing hands, using safe water, cooking poultry and eggs thoroughly, refrigerating perishable foods appropriately and keeping raw meat separate from ready-to-eat food.

Challenges and way forward

The major concern is the growing antimicrobial resistance in Salmonella. India has seen a major shift in the resistance pattern of S. Typhi. A recent study in *PLOS Neglected Tropical Diseases* said, culture-confirmed isolates from 1977 to 2024 found that fluoroquinolone resistance rose sharply, reaching 85% in 2015-19, and remains high despite a subsequent decline.

"The emergence and spread of extensively drug-resistant typhoid shows what can happen when resistance accumulates across multiple antibiotic classes," Dr. Sweatha said, "It can leave clinicians with very limited treatment options."

Experts say the answer is not to simply use stronger antibiotics. Blood culture is the main test for suspected typhoid and should ideally be done before antibiotics are started. The Widal test has limitations and should not be used alone to diagnose typhoid. For uncomplicated non-typhoidal Salmonella gastroenteritis, treatment mainly involves adequate fluids and electrolyte replacement. Antibiotics are usually reserved for severe or invasive infections and people at higher risk of complications.

Prevention remains as important as treatment. The World Health Organization recommends typhoid conjugate vaccines for children from six months of age; however, this not yet part of India's universal immunisation programme.

The challenge is to treat the infections that genuinely require antibiotics while preventing the infections that can be prevented in the first place.

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